Revenge of the Fire Princess

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/72229331.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) & Original Female Character(s), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Original Characters, Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Fire Princess (She-Ra), Original Female Character(s), Melog (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Lance (She-Ra), George (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Tags Contain Spoilers, Major Original Character(s), Drama & Romance, Drama, Angst, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Post-War, Fire Powers, Pregnancy, Unplanned Pregnancy, Pregnant Adora (She-Ra), Abandonment Issues, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Canon Lesbian Relationship, Canon Lesbian Character, Catra is searching for her family, Other Ships Not Mentioned in Tags, Mentioned Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Action/Adventure, Battle Scenes, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Arguing, Break Up, Breaking Up & Making Up, Post-Break Up, Flashbacks, Original Female Character(s) - Freeform, Original Femslash, Engagement, Minor Character Death, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Blood and Injury, Blood, Loss of Limbs, Disasters, Past Relationship(s), Reconciliation, Catradora breakup (but they get back together so its fine)

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Series:
Part 4 of The Search

Stats:
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Revenge of the Fire Princess

by Mimmers

Summary

A mysterious figure from Etheria's past resurfaces after a thousand years, and the information they bring with them ends up straining Adora and Catra's relationship. Things get complicated when Adora discovers that she's carrying Catra's child.

Chapter 1: Prologue: Four Weeks Ago

Ever since being transported out of the dimension of Despondos, Etheria's climate had experienced subtle but noticeable changes. And after She-Ra had released its magic from the Heart of Etheria, the planet had never been the same since.

Nobody knew what exactly these changes would bring to Etheria.

Until now.

On the edge of the Kingdom of Snows, at the border connecting it to the seas of Salineas, was a particular glacier. The glacier had remained completely untouched for tens of thousands of years, but over the centuries small chunks of it would occasionally break off and fall into the ocean, forming icebergs.

Recently, another large chunk of ice had broken off the glacier. And once again, it fell into Salineas' seas. But unlike the other chunks, this one was different. As it made its way across the waves, towards the shore, there was something inside of it encased underneath all that ice.

Something… *Or some**one.***

On the other side of Etheria, in the kingdom of Bright Moon, Adora and Catra were blissfully unaware of what was happening

at the glacier. They had just returned to their bedroom inside of Bright Moon's castle after a fun day out, with both of them feeling giggly and extremely in love. Adora was wearing a red, shoulderless dress, whereas Catra had dressed up in a purple and burgundy suit.

"Today's been the most fun day of my life!" Catra remarked as she embraced Adora, placing a kiss on her lips. "Thanks for the date, Adora. This was such a wonderful surprise!"

"Glad to hear it!" Adora said, proud of herself. "I worked really hard on getting everything set up, I wanted today to be *perfect."*

"All by yourself?"

"...Okay, Bow and Glimmer might've helped."

"Figures." Catra teased her. "But it was a lovely gesture in any case."

"Of course, gotta make sure you won't run away!" Adora playfully fired back.

"Oh, I have no plans of running. In fact," Catra seductively scratched underneath Adora's chin with her index finger. *"I think we should keep the date going."*

“Huh?” Adora tilted her head, confused. “B-but we just got back home! A-and I haven’t really made any other plans for today, I uh-”

“You are such an *idiot.”* Catra giggled lovingly. “What I mean is, we’ve got a perfectly good bed right here.”

“Yeah? You uh, you wanna take a nap or-”

“And I love that dress you’re wearing.” Catra placed her finger over Adora’s lips, then leaned in closer and whispered to her ear: *“But I’d love to see you* ***without it on*** *even more.”*

“Ohhhhhh.” Adora finally realized what Catra was getting at and blushed. “Well, in that case…”

Adora smirked deviously and scooped Catra up with her arms, causing Catra to yelp “Hey!” They both laughed as Adora practically tossed Catra to the bed, climbed on top of her and began making out with her.

While their lips were locked together, Adora clumsily unbuttoned Catra’s shirt one by one, while Catra reached her hand over Adora’s back and unzipped her dress from behind. Things got steamy as the two women kept gradually undressing while

passionately kissing the entire time, until they were down to their underwear.

Adora was breathing heavily as she laid her eyes on the scantily clad Catra, both of their cheeks turning redder than a tomato. Seeing Catra in this state… It was the most beautiful sight in the world to Adora.

"Haah… Hey, Catra?" Adora whispered as she held Catra's hand, their fingers intertwined.

"Y-yeah?" Catra asked. Her heart was burning like wildfire.

"I love you so much."

"I, I love you too Adora." Catra stated as she helped Adora take her bra off. "And I'm never gonna let go of you, I promise."

"Good. Me neither." Adora said, pinning Catra to the bed and kissing her neck.

Adora and Catra lost theirselves in a night of passion, of love.

Neither of them had any idea of the consequences this day would have.

How it would change their lives forever.

Chapter 2: A New Foe Emerges

Chapter Summary

> Adora has been experiencing bouts of nausea for the past few days and Catra is worried she might be sick. The princesses face off against a mysterious figure who has set the Whispering Woods on fire, and their appearance shocks Catra to her core.

Chapter Notes

> Welcome to my most ambitious project yet! This fic is something I have been thinking of for years that I decided to finally put to page.
>
> This one's gonna be long, when I was initially drafting this what ended up being the first three chapters was originally just chapter 1 but things kept expanding in scope, so I decided to split it up into many slightly shorter chapters.
>
> The "Legend of the Fire Princess" graphic novel isn't canon to this story, as I wasn't able to fit it into the narrative that I wanted to tell. I do like it myself so there's definitely going to be some nods to elements from it down the line!
>
> This story follows up from plot threads I've set up in "Cat in the Box", "Tending the Garden" and "Until We Meet Again", which provide a lot of additional context but shouldn't necessarily be mandatory to read this one :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat up, yawning loudly and stretching her arms out when she woke up that morning. It was a beautiful, peaceful day on Etheria. Just like any other.

“Hey, Adora-” Catra turned to her right, only to discover that nobody was there. “Adora? *Adora!”*

Adora had already gotten out of bed. But where had she gone?

Catra looked around the room: All of Adora’s clothes were still there, so she couldn’t have gone too far. Then, Catra’s ears flicked as she heard the sound of *retching* coming from the bathroom.

“Ah. There you are.” Catra sighed before climbing out of bed.

She walked to the bathroom and saw Adora sitting on her knees on the floor, her head hovering over the toilet with an incredibly nauseous expression on her face.

“Bleuuugghh…” Adora groaned. She looked slightly green.

Catra walked up to Adora and gently rubbed her back for a while, in an attempt to help her feel better.

“Adora-” Catra started, but Adora immediately cut her off.

“I’m fine.” Adora claimed. “I-I’m better now. Was just, momentarily feeling sick, that’s all.”

“This is the third day in a row now.” Catra reminded her, sounding concerned. “It’s starting to worry me. What if you’ve caught some kind of illness?”

“I told you I’m fine, Catra.” Adora muttered as she stood back up on her feet. “I-I’ll just walk it off, it’ll be alright-”

“We’re not in the Fright Zone anymore, Adora.” Catra crossed her arms, then softly added: “Hey, I’m just worried because you don’t usually get sick.”

“Yeah, I know.” Adora glanced aside.

“What if it’s something She-Ra related?” Catra suggested.

“Could be. My biology isn’t exactly normal, me being a First One and all.” Adora pondered for a while, until eventually relenting: “Fine. I’ll go see Entrapta about it later, she can do a quick checkup to see if there’s anything wrong with me.”

“Thank you.” Catra smiled and placed a tender kiss on Adora’s left cheek. The two women left the bathroom and got dressed.

“It’s been a while since I’ve transformed, anyway.” Adora claimed as she put her shirt on. “Things have been so peaceful lately that

there hasn't been much need for She-Ra."

"Yeah. Almost *too* peaceful." Catra yawned as she pulled up her leggings.

"I mean, after *the war* are you really complaining?" Adora snarked.

"Nope." Catra walked up to Adora and wrapped her arms around her back, with a sultry look in her eyes. "But I wouldn't mind some more… *Action,* every now and then."

"Oh yeah?" Adora replied, her arms around Catra's neck. "In that case maybe I should arrange for some more action, so my girlfriend doesn't *die of boredom."*

"Maybe you should!" Catra giggled as Adora placed her lips against hers and the two shared a passionate kiss, their tongues dancing together.

Catra began purring quietly, which was a common occurrence any time she was making out with Adora. All of the turmoil that the two had gone through over the years, Catra thought maybe it had all been worth it. Just for these special moments with Adora.

"You're so cute." Adora whispered, causing Catra to blush.

“Shut up, dork.” Catra said affectionately. The two kissed once more, when suddenly-

“Adora! Catra!”

A sparkly sound, a flash of pink and a shrill voice startled Adora and Catra out of the moment, causing them to let go of one another as Adora gasped and Catra yelped. Glimmer had teleported into their room with Bow, the two of them looking extremely distressed.

“G-Glimmer!” Adora stammered, her face all red. “Oh, w-we were uh, we were just-”

“Have you ever heard of *knocking,* Sparkles?!” Catra hissed, annoyed that Bow and Glimmer had ruined her moment with Adora.

“Sorry, it’s an emergency!” Bow said. “You have to come, quick!”

“What’s going on?” Adora wondered, noticing how frantic and worried her best friends looked.

Glimmer grabbed Adora’s wrist and shouted: *“The Whispering Woods have been set on fire!”*

"WHAT?!" Adora and Catra exclaimed in unison. With a determined look on her face Adora summoned her sword and said: "Then there's no time to waste, let's go!"

Glimmer teleported the four of them to the edge of the Whispering Woods. Catra's pupils narrowed and Adora's jaw dropped as they saw the all-consuming lake of fire swallowing the trees around it.

"Whoa, that is a LOT of fire." Catra said in awe.

"Guess you got the action you wanted!" Adora snarked.

Adora and Catra saw that Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, Scorpia, Spinnerella, Netossa and King Micah were all doing what they could to try and put out the flames, to limited success. Spinnerella launched a huge gust of wind at the fire, which seemed to mostly just spread the flames around.

"This isn't working, I'm just making more!" Spinnerella sighed, dejected.

"Don't give up, Spinny!" Netossa cheered her wife on. She had made a giant flyswatter out of her nets and was doing her best to swat the flames down. "We've got this!"

Mermista summoned a stream of water that she aimed at the fire, and while putting out some most of the water just evaporated into steam as it made contact with the devouring flames.

"Uuggghhh!" Mermista groaned. "This is like, so *annoying!* Isn't water supposed to, I dunno, *extinguish fire* or something?!"

"This isn't fair! Ice should be fireproof!" Frosta whined as her blasts of ice melted away when consumed by the fire.

"I uh, I dunno if this is actually helping." Scorpia chuckled awkwardly while firing electricity out of her pincers towards the flames. "I think lightning usually *causes* fires, instead of putting them out."

"It's going to take so long for the Woods to heal from all this…" Perfuma was on the verge of tears, swatting at the flames with a massive pile of succulents she had conjured using her powers. It was bringing her great pain seeing so much wildlife burning to ashes. "Oh, fire is just *the worst!"*

Micah was casting various water and wind-related spells, but even a sorcerer as mighty as him was no match for the ocean of hellfire.

"This isn't good." Micah said seriously, his face covered in soot. "If we can't contain this soon, the entire woods will-" Suddenly, he collapsed in a coughing fit.

“DAD!” Glimmer cried out, teleporting to Micah and bringing her back to where Adora, Catra and Bow were standing.

“Micah…” Catra muttered, worried for the man she had gotten close with over the years.

“Let’s go.” Adora raised her sword and yelled out: *“For the Honor of Grayskull!”,* transforming into She-Ra in a flash of light.

She-Ra and Bow charged towards the fire with their weapons raised, Glimmer was about to but then turned to Catra.

“Catra, look after dad, okay?”

“Got it.” Catra nodded. “Not like I’m gonna be of much use here, without powers…”

Glimmer smiled at her sympathetically, then teleported to catch up with She-Ra and Bow.

“Glimmer!” Frosta exclaimed happily as she spotted the three of them coming to help.

“Adora! Bow!” Perfuma cheered.

“Jeez, about time you guys showed up.” Mermista snarked, wiping her brow with her wrist.

“Sorry we’re late.” She-Ra apologized. “Let’s go, guys! We’ve got this!”

The princesses, invigorated by She-Ra’s arrival got back to work. She-Ra swung her sword, sending a magical shockwave that cut through the flames, while Glimmer fired a massive beam of sparkling energy that she sweeped the flames with.

“Finally, I get to try these out!” Bow pulled three trick arrows out of his quiver and fired them towards the flames. The arrows exploded in midair, raining down a bunch of chemical compound similar to that inside of fire extinguishers.

“Be careful not to breathe in the smoke!” She-Ra warned the others before turning to Spinnerella. “Spinnerella, can you-”

“On it!” Spinnerella used gusts of wind to blow as much of the smoke away as possible.

“Nggghhhh…” Micah was slowly regaining consciousness. He saw a pair of blue and yellow eyes staring at him. “C-Catra?”

“Hey, Micah.” Catra said, relieved to see Micah awake. “You okay?”

“Yeah, I think so.” Micah answered, before coughing. He smiled at Catra and said: “It’s good to see you here.”

“You have any idea what started this?” Catra asked him.

“I’m not sure.” Micah shook his head. “But what I know for certain is... This *wasn’t* an accident.”

“You mean someone did this on purpose?” Catra muttered. “Why?”

“That’s what I don’t know.” Micah sighed. “But it’s not the first time this has happened, there were reports of much smaller fires at Salineas and Plumeria recently but they were put out fairly quick.”

“Huh… So we’ve got a serial arsonist on the loose.”

“One of the Plumerians said they saw a cloaked figure near the edge of the woods a few days prior.” Micah stated. “Which means-”

“The perpetrator might still be here.” Catra concluded.

She stared at the flames, and among the sea of fire and smoke Catra thought she saw something for a moment.

A silhouette.

“W-what?” Catra rubbed her eyes, and the silhouette was gone. Was she just seeing things?

The others were still doing their best trying to put out the flames, to no avail. Bow stared at the fire with fear in his eyes.

“This isn’t working!” He said. “Adora, what do we do? We’re running out of time.”

“I know!” She-Ra said, again swinging her sword towards the flames. Then, she got an idea. “Might be time for a team-up.”

“You mean, our connection?” Glimmer asked, seeming excited. “Yes! Ohh, it’s been *years* since we’ve done that!”

“Everyone, gather around me!” She-Ra commanded the other princesses. “We’re gonna unite our powers, see if that does the trick-”

“ADORA, LOOK OUT!” Catra shouted.

She-Ra turned to her right and saw a cloaked figure leaping out of the smoke, throwing a punch towards her. She-Ra blocked the punch with her sword in the nick of time; She couldn’t see the figure’s face underneath the cloak, but she made out a mouth full of sharp fangs.

“Guess we found our culprit.” Catra stated.

“W-who, who are you?” She-Ra asked the figure. “Did you do this?”

The figure just laughed spitefully and spoke in a gravely, cold voice:

“Hello, ***Mara.*** *Surprised to see* ***me*** *again?”*

“Eh? *Mara?”* She-Ra gasped, completely taken back by the figure uttering Mara’s name. “I’m not- Urrgh!”

The figure used She-Ra’s confusion as a distraction to land a solid hit in her face, knocking her to the ground.

“Adora!” Glimmer cried, then launched a sparkle bomb at the figure who dodged it effortlessly.

“Okay, so uhh, that’s *definitely* the one who set the woods on fire.” Mermista stated. The other princesses and Bow surrounded the cloaked figure, ready for battle.

“Wouldn’t do that if I were you.” The figure said threateningly.

“Oh yeah?” Netossa fired back. “You’re outnumbered here!”

Netossa threw a net ball at the figure, who jumped out of the way and the ball ended up hitting Scorpia instead.

“Whoa!” Scorpia yelped as the net knocked her to the ground.

“Oh heck, sorry!” Netossa apologized.

Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, Mermista and Spinnerella all launched their own attacks at the figure, but no matter what they did none of them were able to land a hit.

“They’re slippery…” Catra mumbled.

Something about the figure's movements, how quick and nimble they were, the way they fought… *It was so similar to Catra's own style.*

"Huh?" Catra spotted something underneath the figure's cloak. "Is that… *A tail?"*

"I told ya." The figure gloated to the princesses and Bow. "I've had experience fighting off princesses before."

"But not us!" Glimmer exclaimed. She teleported behind the cloaked figure trying to tackle them, but the figure seemed to have anticipated this as they hit Glimmer squarely in the nose with their elbow, giving her a nosebleed and almost knocking her out.

"Owowowow!" Glimmer cried in pain, holding her nose. "M-my nose!"

"Glimmer!" Bow and Frosta both yelled. Frosta fired a chunk of ice towards the cloaked figure, causing them to shift their attention towards her.

"No…" The figure mumbled, their demeanor turning from cocky to vengeful. "You, you must be… *Glacia's descendant."*

“Huh? What do you mean, Glaci- AAAHH!” Frosta was attacked by the figure, who kicked her in the stomach and then grabbed her by the throat.

“F-Frosta!” Glimmer cried out.

“Finally,” The figure said with murderous triumph. **“I shall have my vengeance.”**

The figure had a set of sharp claws on their hands, which they were holding over Frosta’s throat ready to slice it open.

“NO!” She-Ra screamed, getting back on her feet. “FROSTA-”

However before anyone could do anything Catra had pounced on the cloaked figure to save Frosta, tackling the stranger a good distance away and pinning them to the ground.

“Urgh!” The figure grunted as they made contact with the dirt.

“Gotcha.” Catra smirked.

“Catra!” Bow said happily. “Good save, you came just in time-”

“Put the fire out!” Catra shouted at the others. “I’m gonna hold this creep off!”

“Got it!” She-Ra nodded, then turned to Frosta to help her up. “Frosta, you okay?”

“Y-yeah.” Frosta mumbled, reeling from her near-death experience. She then muttered to herself: “Glacia…”

“Grrr…” The figure snarled.

“Looks like your little pyromania stunts are over.” Catra taunted the cloaked figure. She held her right arm up with her claws raised, ready to strike at the figure. “If you try anything, I’ll-”

Just then, the hood fell off of their face and Catra was able to see the figure clearly for the first time.

“W-what?” Catra gasped. Her pupils narrowed and she completely froze up.

Underneath the cloak was a woman, roughly a decade older than Catra, with very similar catlike features to her own; Same pointy ears and feline eyes, although the woman had a matching pair of yellow eyes as opposed to Catra’s mismatched ones. Her hair was orange with black streaks, styled in a side mohawk, and she had a scar over her left eye.

“No way...” The woman muttered, staring at Catra and seeming almost equally baffled upon seeing her face. “I-is that *you?* No, it couldn’t be… Your eyes-”

“W-who,” Catra was trembling, so overwhelmed by the woman’s appearance. This was the first time she had ever met another person who looked like herself. “Who *are* you?!”

Meanwhile, the princesses were working on a last ditch effort to stop the forest fire.

“Let’s do this.” Glimmer had plugged her nostrils to stop the bleeding, and all of the princesses held hands together.

They were all intently focused, channeling their powers until they could feel their connection. All of the princesses were enveloped in a colorful, flamelike aura, signifying that their powers had been attuned.

“Ready?” She-Ra looked to her sides, all of the princesses nodding in response.

She-Ra raised her sword, launching a gigantic rainbow-colored wave of magical energy that washed over the entire forest; This combined effort from the princesses was finally enough to completely extinguish all of the fire that remained.

“Yes!” Perfuma cheered. She used her own supercharged powers to regrow the trees and plants that had been burnt in the fire, repairing the vast majority of the damage done to the Whispering Woods.

“You did it!” Bow exclaimed. As their connection waned, the princesses got to celebrating their victory.

“We did it! Together” Glimmer corrected Bow as she teleported up to him and kissed him.

“Wooo! Well done, team!” Scorpia hollered, sharing a group hug with Frosta and Perfuma. Netossa had dipped Spinnerella and was kissing her deep, while Mermista gave She-Ra a high five.

“Not too bad, considering we’re all pretty rusty or whatever.” Mermista joked. She-Ra smiled, happy that the alliance had been able to save the forest, then turned around.

“Oh, right.” She-Ra remembered after seeing Catra still holding the figure down. “Don’t move, Catra! We’ll be right there!”

“You, you must be-” The mysterious woman muttered to Catra, but stopped as she saw She-Ra, Bow and the other princesses running towards them. She pulled her hood back over her face,

leaned in as close to Catra's ear as possible and whispered something to her.

"W-what?" Catra mumbled. "What are you-"

Before Catra could finish, the woman had chopped the side of Catra's neck with her hand, temporarily knocking Catra out cold so she could get her off of her.

"Catra!" She-Ra yelled. She glared at the cloaked figure: "You're gonna pay for this!"

The cloaked figure stepped backwards, then reached into her cloak to pull out something.

"You won this round, Mara." The figure said, raising her hand. ***"But I'll have my revenge on you yet."***

"WAIT!" She-Ra shouted, but before she could do anything the figure had tossed a smoke bomb on the ground. Everyone caught in the smoke was coughing, and by the time the smoke dissipated the figure was already gone, having vanished without a trace.

"Damn it!" Glimmer cursed. "They got away!"

“What do we do now?” Bow asked.

“The fire’s been put out, that’s the important part.” She-Ra said. “But we need to be on the lookout for the perpetrator, they might strike again.”

“Seems we’ve got a new enemy on the loose.” Mermista remarked.

“Ow…” Catra winced, rubbing her neck as she came to.

“You okay?” She-Ra turned back to Adora and offered her hand to Catra, helping her up on her feet. “What happened?”

“I dunno, she uh-” Catra stammered. “She distracted me and got a sneak attack in. Sorry.”

“It’s okay.” Adora reassured her with a smile. “We’ll get her later.”

“Wait, ‘she?’” Bow raised an eyebrow at Catra. “Did you see her face?”

“I… No.” Catra lied. “Just had a hunch.”

“So uh, what do we do now?” Scorpia wondered.

“We need to find out who this person is.” Glimmer stated. “And make sure we’ll put a stop to them, once and for all!”

“We’ll go back to our kingdoms, make sure they stay safe.” Perfuma said. “We’ll inform you if we see the culprit around!”

“I,” Frosta started. “She mentioned the name ‘Glacia’. And that sounds vaguely familiar, I just don’t remember… *Where.”*

“One of your predecessors?” Adora wondered.

“I think so.” Frosta nodded. “I’m gonna go through the library in the Kingdom of Snows, there’s lots of books about my ancestors I’ve never bothered reading before. Maybe if we find something on Glacia, we’ll also figure out who this new foe is!”

“I swear, if it turns out to be Sea Hawk in disguise I’m gonna *keelhaul* him.” Mermista joked, causing everyone to laugh.

“Frosta, we’ll come over to help!” Glimmer said. “Multiple pairs of eyes can see more than one. We’ll gather at your castle tomorrow.”

“Sounds like we have a plan.” Bow agreed. Adora nodded.

“Thanks, guys.” Frosta said gratefully.

“Catra?” Adora noticed that Catra had spaced out, staring into the heart of the woods.

“H-huh?” Catra snapped out of it and turned to Adora. “Oh, right. Sure. You know I love reading.” She said sarcastically. While the others were still discussing, Catra was lost in her thoughts again.

Who was this woman? Why did she look like Catra? And how did she seem to know her?

Catra was sitting on the side of her and Adora’s bed, with Melog having curled up next to her. The mysterious woman had brought back feelings Catra had resolved to bury deep within herself, and they were now bubbling back up to the surface.

Catra reached into her pocket, taking out a particular piece of paper.

A note.

Some time ago, Adora and Catra had been helping Scorpia out with clearing out the Fright Zone. Afterwards they had gone to Shadow Weaver's old office and rummaged through her things, and among them Catra had found this very note.

And while Catra couldn't believe it at first… The note had been written by *her mother.* It had detailed some of her reasons for giving Catra away when she was a baby, and also asked Catra to come find her.

However, the location of where she was had been torn out of the note, lost to time. All that remained was half of the first letter, which could've been any of B, E, R or even something else entirely.

Catra wondered why Shadow Weaver had never told her this. Why she never gave her this note. Did she do it on purpose because she despised Catra? Was she trying to protect Catra by hiding the truth from her? Or did she simply forget, with it having been such a long time ago?

Catra didn't know, and she would never get to know. Shadow Weaver was gone, and she wasn't coming back. Catra couldn't ask her directly.

Ever since finding the note, Catra had been desperately trying to find her family. She spent ages following any lead she could, only

to find that there were none; Everything had turned out to be a dead end.

She looked. And looked. *And looked.* But there were no traces of her mother anywhere. Catra didn't even know if she was on Etheria in the first place.

Four months ago, Catra had officially given up on the search. Even if her mom was somehow still alive, there's no way Catra could ever track her down when she didn't even know where to begin looking.

But now… *Catra might have her lead.*

Catra did not know anything about her past, where she originally came for. She didn't know who or what she was. But now, Catra finally had concrete proof that others like her existed. That she wasn't the only one.

This woman in the woods… Could she be the key to locating Catra's family? To finding her mother and the rest of her kind?

There would be only one way to find out. But Catra knew Adora wouldn't like it-

"Seems the culprit's been keeping low profile."

Adora's voice snapped Catra out of her thoughts and back to the present. Adora had been in a meeting with Bow, Glimmer, Micah and the other princesses, and had just returned to her and Catra's room.

"She hasn't attacked any other kingdoms yet, at least." Adora said, while still seeming cautious. "But why is she doing all this? And why did she mistake me for Mara? Mara's been gone for a thousand years, she-"

Adora noticed that Catra was holding her mother's letter and sighed sympathetically. She sat down on the bed next to Catra.

"You thinking about your mom?" Adora asked. Catra nodded hesitantly.

"I know I said I was giving up." Catra whispered. "But-"

"I know." Adora gave her temple a soft kiss. "We'll find her, Catra. Together."

Catra mustered up a smile towards Adora, while still feeling uneasy. Then, she chuckled.

"Heh."

"What's up?"

"Never thought I'd say this, but… *I wish Shadow Weaver was here."*

"Shadow Weaver?" Adora raised an eyebrow.

"So I could ask her, why." Catra clarified. "Why she never gave *this* to me, why she kept this information from me all this time."

Catra sniffled, and Adora hugged her tight. After a period of silence, Adora let go and said to her: "Hey, I'm gonna go to Dryl to see Entrapta. Figure out what's been causing my nausea."

"Oh, right." Catra realized. "Kinda forgot about that after what happened at the Woods."

"You wanna come with?" Adora asked her.

"Thanks, but I'll pass." Catra rubbed her neck. "That creep messed my neck up pretty good, I need some rest."

"Okay." Adora gently held her hand. "I love you."

“I love you too, Adora.”

With one last quick kiss, Adora exited the room, heading towards the castle grounds where Swift Wind would be waiting for her.

Catra gave the letter in her hands one more look, reading the last line that had been written on it:

“Regardless of what happens or where you end up, your mother will always love you. ***Always.”***

“Then why, w-why did you give me away?” Catra whispered bitterly. “Why did you *abandon* me?”

Catra put the note back in her pocket and made her decision. She nudged Melog with her hand.

“Hey, Melog.” Catra said. “I’m gonna go do something stupid and reckless and possibly very dangerous. You in?”

Melog yawned and mewled, and knowing that Catra had already made her choice it jumped out of the bed and used its powers to turn itself and Catra invisible. Catra and Melog snuck their way outside of Bright Moon, making sure nobody could see them, and then made their way to the heart of the Whispering Woods.

The walk there gave Catra some time to think. This would be such a dumb idea that could easily backfire. But if it ends up leading Catra to her mother…

She was willing to take that risk.

Chapter End Notes

That's a wrap on chapter one, thank you for reading! There's definitely more to come in the near future, so keep your eyes peeled and I hope you'll follow along with me for the rest of the ride.

Chapter 3: Revelations

Chapter Summary

Catra meets up with the woman in the woods, getting answers to some questions she's had all of her life. Meanwhile, Adora receives some big news from Entrapta and is excited to tell Catra about it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Entrapta, how much longer is this gonna take?”

Adora was pacing back and forth restlessly inside of Entrapta’s lab, waiting for Entrapta to analyze the DNA sample that Adora had given her. Hordak, Wrong Hordak and Emily were also there, although Hordak was doing his best to avoid making eye contact with Adora.

It was still very awkward for the two of them to be in the same room together, after everything.

“Patience, Brother Adora!” Wrong Hordak cheered Adora up. “Brother Entrapta is working as fast as she can, all shall be revealed in due time!”

Emily beeped something in response.

“I just wanna know if I’m actually sick or not.” Adora sighed.

“Just a liiiittle more time, Adora!” Entrapta made a gesture with her hair tendrils as if she was pinching her fingers. “Just running some final calculations. Let’s see, subject’s biomass times hair follicles divided by erythrocytes, add the amount of white blood cells, subtract the subject’s age aaaaaand… Done!” Entrapta’s computer made a sound that resembled a fanfare.

“Finally!” Adora said, walking up to Entrapta. “What does it say?”

“Hmmmm….” Entrapta was intently staring at the monitor, analyzing the data it had given her until eventually she said: “Just as I suspected! You’re as healthy as can be, Adora.”

“R-really?” Adora wondered. “So there’s nothing wrong with me?”

“Nothing whatsoever!”

“Phew! Well, that’s a relief.” Adora said happily, before getting confused. “But wait, then where’s my nausea coming from? Why do I keep feeling sick when I wake up…”

“Oh, that would just be the additional organic lifeform that’s currently gestating inside of your womb.” Entrapta said very nonchalantly while typing on her computer, before adding: “Congratulations on the baby, by the way!”

"Uhhhh, *what* baby?" Adora tilted her head with a puzzled expression, not knowing what Entrapta was talking about. "And a lifeform is doing *what* in my *where?"*

"Oh wait, you didn't know? *Ohhhh,"* Entrapta chuckled nervously. "Haha, oopsie! My bad!"

After a few seconds of processing, Entrapta's words finally set in for Adora and she had a realization.

"Wait…" Adora gasped, staring at her hands as she yelled: *"I'm* ***pregnant?!****"*

"Yup!" Entrapta said in her usual, carefree tone. "For about four weeks, in fact!"

A stunned silence overtook the lab. Hordak looked even more uncomfortable than he already had, Wrong Hordak was nervously glancing between Adora and Entrapta while biting his nails, Emily quietly beeped something and Entrapta was taken back by the sudden, awkward change in atmosphere.

Adora, however, was so overwhelmed by the news that she almost fell to her knees, tears in her eyes.

"I'm… **Pregnant...**" Adora mumbled to herself. "I-I'm, I'm gonna be… *I'm gonna be a-"*

Adora covered her mouth with her hands, tears streaming down her face as she wept softly.

"Oh no, i-is this bad news?" Entrapta worried. "I'm sorry, I-I can never tell with these kinds of things, I-"

"N-no, it's just…" Adora managed to say, then looked at Entrapta. The smile on her face was brighter than a thousand suns. "I'm, *I-I'm so* ***happy*****.** I didn't, I-I didn't even think it was *possible!* That this could ever happen…"

Entrapta sighed out of relief, before asking Adora: "Had you never tried for a child?"

"No." Adora shook her head. "Because I, I didn't think Catra could even *get* me pregnant! I-I kinda figured we'd be… *Incompatible."* Talking about Catra reminded her: "Ohhh, I've gotta tell Catra about this, she's going to be so happy! We, *we're gonna be moms!"*

Adora jumped up and down, barely able to contain her excitement as she squeed with delight.

“Oh, I am so happy for you Brother!” Wrong Hordak congratulated Adora bombastically. “You will have the unique opportunity to bring new life into this world! A new brother shall be with us soon!”

Emily beeped happily at Adora.

“Thanks, you guys.” Adora said fondly, then turned to Entrapta. “Hey Entrapta, I uh… Could you keep this a secret, for now? I want to make sure I tell Catra first, I want her to hear the news directly from me.”

“You got it!” Entrapta gave Adora a thumbs up, then pulled out her recorder and spoke into it: “Note to self, don’t accidentally blabber about Adora’s pregnancy to anyone!”

Adora giggled. However, soon she got more serious again as something dawned on her.

“But wait… What is this gonna do to me?” Adora worried. “To She-Ra? Is it safe for me to fight, or even transform? That new enemy is still out there, but I can’t risk getting the baby hurt. If I can’t fight…”

“It should be safe! Mostly.” Entrapta claimed, then typed something on her computer that caused it to pull up a graph of Adora and She-Ra. “See, when you transform, She-Ra forms this

protective barrier of pure, magical energy around you, shielding your physical body from harm!”

“Which means?” Adora wondered.

“You and the baby should be perfectly safe!” Entrapta clarified, then added: “But you miiight want to avoid getting any direct blows to the stomach, even as She-Ra. Concentrated attacks towards it could be a *teensy* bit risky for the fetus.”

“Got it.” Adora nodded. She then looked down, held her stomach and whispered to it gently: “Don’t worry, little one. Mom is gonna keep you safe. I promise.”

“What will you be doing now?” Entrapta asked her.

“I think I’m gonna head back home.” Adora stated. “I need to tell Catra about this. And Bow and Glimmer, and… And everyone! Aahh, I can’t wait!”

“Okie dokie! See you around!” Entrapta and Wrong Hordak both waved to Adora as she walked towards the door out of the lab.

Hordak was standing by the door, arms crossed and still avoiding making eye contact with Adora. However as soon as Adora passed by him, she heard him utter one single word to her:

"...Congratulations."

"Huh?" Adora looked at Hordak to make sure if she had heard him right, and the embarrassment on Hordak's face sealed the deal for her. Adora smiled at him gently and said: "Oh. T-thank you."

The corners of Hordak's mouth tugged ever so slightly upward, but he remained silent as Adora walked out of the door, making her way out of the castle to find Swift Wind there waiting for her.

"Hey, Swifty." Adora greeted her noble steed.

"Hey! What did Entrapta say?" Swift Wind asked Adora. "Are you sick?"

"Naah. I'm all good." Adora shrugged. "But I got some pretty big news back there."

"News? What kind?" Swift Wind wondered as Adora climbed on his back.

"I'll tell you once we're home." Adora said, even if she could barely contain her excitement. Swift Wind just nodded as he took off flying, carrying Adora back to Bright Moon.

Adora still couldn't believe what she had heard from Entrapta was actually real. That this was happening.

She was pregnant. She was carrying Catra's child. She would become *a mother.*

Adora and Catra would become parents.

After a while of wandering through the woods, Catra and Melog had finally managed to locate the mysterious woman. She had set up a dark green tent in a clearing within the heart of the Whispering Woods, and was currently brewing a pot of coffee over a campfire. The woman was squinting as she gazed into the flames, lost in thought.

Catra tried to sneak as silently as she could in order to avoid startling her. However she accidentally stepped on a dry branch, causing it to snap loudly.

"Hmm? *Who's there?"* The woman immediately jumped up with her claws raised, looking around her surroundings alarmed. "Show yourself!"

“It’s okay!” Catra yelled, then instructed Melog to uncloak her. “It’s just me.”

“Huh?”

The woman saw Catra and Melog appear out of thin air in front of her, then lowered her guard.

“Ohh, there you are.” The woman said, crossing her arms. “I was worried ya weren’t gonna show up!”

“I had to think about it for a while.” Catra admitted. “But I got too curious.”

Catra remembered what the woman had whispered to her a few hours ago before she had ran off: *“Meet me in the woods, we’ll talk.”*

“Curiosity killed the cat, eh?” The woman snarked. While Catra was still on her guard regarding the woman, she was feeling a little more relaxed around her. “Well, I’m glad you trusted me enough to come, it means a lot to me.” She then suspiciously eyed Melog. “What’s with the panther?”

“Huh? Oh, this is just Melog.” Catra introduced it. “It’s uhh… My friend. Slash emotional support animal. Found it on an alien planet, it imprinted on me, we uh, we’ve been connected ever since.”

“Uh-huh.” The woman nodded, one eyebrow raised. Catra stared at her feet, trying to figure out where to begin.

“You seemed to recognize me, back there.” Catra started. “How? I’ve never met you before, or at least I have no memory of it.”

“Yeah, sorry about that.” The woman said sadly. “I got ya mixed up with someone else.”

“Who?”

“...My sister.” The woman explained. “She was the spitting image of you, except she liked to wear robes and her eyes were the other way around. That’s how I knew you weren’t her.”

“Your… Sister?” Catra muttered; There really *were* others like her. The woman nodded.

“I’ve been doing some research, looking into things.” The woman said, glancing aside. “Etheria has changed so much since I last saw it… My sister must’ve been dead for centuries by now.”

“W-what?” Catra gasped. “*Centuries?* Who, I mean how, I mean…”

“I uh,” The woman scratched the back of her head, figuring out how to explain this next bit to Catra. “I… I was, frozen. In a block of ice. For at least *a thousand years.”*

“Huh?” Catra’s jaw nearly hit the ground. She was staring at the woman with her pupils dilated out of sheer disbelief. “A-a *thousand* years?”

“Yup.” The woman sighed. “It’s a long and complicated story, but… About four weeks ago, the block of ice I was trapped in fell into the sea, carrying me to Salineas where I finally thawed. I was freed from my icy prison.”

“No way, that’s… That’s nuts!” Catra exclaimed. She then noticed the woman’s left arm, how scarred and blackened it looked. “Are, are those *burns?”*

“Hm? Oh, this?” The woman raised her left arm. “Nah. *Frostbite.* That’s what happens when your *ex* has ice powers.”

“Your ex? So you, you dated Frosta’s ancestor?” Catra was struggling to process the information that the woman had given

her, but it was starting to make sense why she had called Adora ‘Mara’.

“Yeah. Glacia.” The woman replied, looking forlorn. “We were engaged, we were so happy together, so in love… But then she betrayed me. That’s how I ended up on ice, so to speak.”

“Oh, wow.” Catra said sadly. “I-I’m so sorry.”

“Thanks, uhh…” The woman tilted her head. “What’s your name again?”

“Catra.”

“Catra.” The woman nodded at her. “Nice to meet ya!”

“L-likewise.” Catra muttered. She had so many questions on her mind as she watched the woman, how her ears flicked and her tail swooshed around. Exactly like her own often did.

“You look a little troubled, Catra.” The woman said all of a sudden, as if she could read Catra’s mind. “Something bothering ya?”

“I uh,” Catra took a deep breath before starting. “I’ve… Never met anyone like me before.”

“Really?” The woman muttered. “Huh. Can’t say I’m surprised, our people were pretty secluded even during the best of times.”

“Yeah, that’s… That’s why I came here.” Catra admitted. “My mother gave me away when I was a baby, I have no memory of… Her. Or anything else, about my kind.”

The woman didn’t say anything, she just listened to Catra with a sorry expression on her face. Catra kept going.

“I never knew my parents, I never knew my family. I,” Catra’s voice wavered and she looked away. “I-I have no idea who I am or where I came from, **what** I am. My mom left me a note when she abandoned me, I’ve been searching for years but I… I have no idea where to look. Because I know *nothing* about myself.”

“I can only imagine.” The woman said.

“For the longest time I thought I was the only one of my kind. But, you’re here.” Catra turned her gaze towards woman. “And you had a sister, and that means… *There are others.”*

“Catra-”

"I-I know this is a long shot." Catra sighed. "But you're the *only* lead I have. You're the only one who might be able to tell me what I am and where I'm from, how to find my mother. Please, uh…" She suddenly had a realization. "You never actually told me your name."

"Ah, right." The woman chuckled. "Those are some good questions to have, kid! And while I don't know about your mother, I can provide you answers for the rest."

"R-really?" Catra's anticipation hit the roof. She would finally get the answers she'd spent her entire life looking for.

"But first, allow me to introduce myself. Ahem!" The woman cleared her throat. "Name's Pyra. I'm the Fire Princess. And you, my dear girl…" She walked up to Catra and placed her hand on Catra's shoulder: *"You are a Magicat."*

"Catra!" Adora exclaimed as she rushed back to her room in Bright Moon. "Catra, I've got some wonderful news! You and I, we're-"

Adora looked around, only to find that Catra wasn't there.

"Catra?" Adora called out. "Catra, where are you?"

She searched the entire room, but Catra wasn't anywhere to be seen.

"Where is she?" Adora wondered. She walked out of the room and into the hallway looking for Catra, but instead bumped into Bow and Glimmer.

"Adora!" Glimmer greeted her. "Good timing, Bow and I were just talking about heading to the Kingdom of Snows tomorrow."

"Huh? Oh, right." Adora muttered. "Glacia."

"You okay?" Bow wondered, slightly concerned.

"Yeah." Adora replied, before asking them: "Guys, have you seen Catra?"

"Beats me." Glimmer shrugged. "Last I saw her was when we came back from the Woods. She's not in your room?"

"Nope." Adora sighed, shaking her head. "And Melog's missing, too."

"Maybe they went for a walk?" Bow suggested. He tried to cheer Adora up: "Don't worry, Catra always lands on her feet. She's

gonna be fine!”

“Yeah, I know.” Adora nodded. “I’m just… Ahhh, I’m **dying** to tell her the news!”

“News?” Glimmer squinted at Adora inquisitively. “What’s going on?”

“I uhh…” Adora hesitated for a moment.

She really wanted Catra to know first. But Bow and Glimmer were her best friends. They deserved to know, too.

“I went to see Entrapta earlier.”

“Oh right, about your nausea.” Bow crossed his arms. “What’s up? Are you sick?”

“No, I…” Adora shook her head and swallowed nervously. “I’m uhh-”

“Adora, it’s okay.” Glimmer gently placed her hand on Adora’s shoulder and smiled at her. “We’re your friends, you can tell us. No matter what it is.”

Bow nodded in agreement. Adora took a deep breath, then grinned as she finally confessed to Bow and Glimmer:

"Guys, I'm… *I'm pregnant."*

After a few seconds of silence, Bow and Glimmer shouted in unison: *"**WHAAAT?!**"*

"Uh-" Adora started, but was cut off by Glimmer hugging her so suddenly and tight that she nearly tackled her to the floor. "Whoa!"

"Ohmygoshohmygoshohmygosh, aahh no way!" Glimmer squeed. "Adora, that's- *That's so wonderful!"*

"Y-yeah?" Adora's cheeks turned red.

"Yeah! Congratulations Adora, we're so happy for you!" Bow joined in on the hug, affectionately embracing Adora and Glimmer. After they let go of each other Bow asked Adora: "Since when were you trying for a kid? You've never mentioned it before!"

"We uh, we… We weren't." Adora awkwardly scratched the back of her head. "This kinda just uh, *happened."*

"Ohhhh." Glimmer said, her and Bow looking more concerned now. "Was this unwanted?"

"What? No, not at all!" Adora clarified. "I just… I didn't think this *could* ever happen. I'd given up on the possibility years ago."

"How come?" Bow wondered.

"I assumed that Catra… Couldn't get me pregnant, y'know?" Adora admitted. "With me being a First One and Catra being, uhh, ***not*** *that."*

"Riiiight." Glimmer nodded. "When did this happen?"

"Four weeks ago, according to Entrapta." Adora said. "Makes sense, it must've happened after…" She blushed, thinking back to the moment. *"After our date."*

"Ohhh, I see." Glimmer teased, while Bow gave Adora a knowing smirk.

"Yeah, we uh, we came back home and Catra, she was in the mood, then one thing led to another and-" Adora stammered. "Here I am now. Carrying her child. *Our* child."

“That’s how it tends to happen.” Bow snarked.

“What’s weird about this is, we’ve been together for ages now.” Adora crossed her arms. “And this wasn’t our first time, we’ve been fairly active when it comes to, umm… You know.”

“I guess all the stars must’ve aligned for you that day.” Glimmer joked, then added: “Man, I can’t believe you two got there before Bow and I did!”

“Guess we’re just gonna have to play catch up, honey.” Bow whispered to her in a flirty voice.

“Hmm, good idea.” Glimmer stood on tip toes and shared a kiss with Bow. “Got any plans for tonight?”

“Well-”

“Get a room, you two.” Adora said snarkily. Bow and Glimmer blushed and stepped back from one another, Bow cleared his throat while Glimmer awkwardly scratched behind her ear.

“So uh,” Glimmer started. “Have you decided yet?”

“Decided what?”

“What you’re gonna do with the baby.”

“Oh uhh,” Adora paused for a second, her left hand over her stomach. “I, I wanna keep it. I-I think I’m ready to become a mother, but… I still wanna talk this through with Catra first, make sure we’re on the same page. You know how much family means to her ever since she found the note her mom left, I’m certain this is gonna make her so happy!”

“Just remember, the choice is ultimately yours.” Bow reminded her. “You’re the one that’s going to be giving birth, after all.”

“Bow’s right.” Glimmer agreed. “It’s your body, regardless of what happens don’t let Catra or anyone else pressure you into anything. You get final say on what you wanna do about this. And no matter what happens, Bow and I will do everything we can to help you every step of the way!”

“Yeah, I know.” Adora nodded, thankful of how supportive her best friends were before adding: “But I still want to talk with Catra about this first. I wanna do right by her, it’s… It’s her child too, just as much as it is mine.”

"I'm… I'm a ***what?"*** Catra asked, looking completely stumped.

"A Magicat." Pyra repeated herself.

"W-what the heck is a Magicat?"

"Why, only the most proud and noble race in all of Etheria!" Pyra claimed, gesturing with her hand while walking in a circle around the campfire she had made as she explained to Catra: "Once upon a time our people practically ruled the entire planet, perfectly attuned to its magic with a sophisticated understanding of technology as well! Warriors, scholars, scientists…"

"You sure you're not making this up?" Catra tilted her head. "Because all this, it just sounds so-"

"I know it sounds crazy." Pyra sighed. "Looking at the state the planet's in currently. But I can assure you, at its peak Magicat Kingdom spanned more or less half of Etheria. Our people prospered, and so did the planet."

"Really…" Catra muttered.

She had a hard time picturing it: All of Etheria being populated by other catlike beings just like her, it sounded so unreal seeing how Catra had never met anyone like herself until today with Pyra. But

she could tell from her eyes, her voice… *Pyra was telling her the truth.*

"If that's true, then," Catra had one burning question on her mind. "What happened? To the rest of the Magicats?"

"Disaster struck." Pyra said hesitantly, sounding serious and almost bitter. "Our people had things good for so long, we lived in peace and harmony… Until ***they*** showed up. They ruined *everything."*

"Who's they?" Catra asked.

Pyra spat on the ground, her voice dripping with disgust and venom as she told Catra:

"The savages. The *colonizers. The* ***First Ones."***

Chapter End Notes

> For those who don't know, magicats are a race of cat people from the original 1985 She-Ra. I always liked the interpretation that Catra in the reboot was this universe's version of a magicat, since it's pulling from something directly from the original source material!
>
> Also I'm aware Pyra shares her name with a Fire Emblem character, I was trying to come up with a fire-related pun name for the princess and out of the options I had I ended up liking how 'Pyra' sounded the most so I went with that.

Chapter 4: It's Over

Chapter Summary

> Pyra tells Catra what happened to the Magicats, asking for her help in setting them free and promising to help Catra find her mother in return. Adora and Catra have a fiery argument over what Pyra said about the Magicats and the First Ones and whether she can be trusted, with things eventually coming to an impasse.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“The… The First Ones?”

Catra was taken back by the information Pyra had just told her. Was it true? What had Adora’s ancestors done to the Magicats?

“That’s what they called themselves.” Pyra scoffed. “They were nothing more than conquerors, *tyrants.* They feared what the Magicats were capable of, what this planet was capable of. They-”

“Turned Etheria into a weapon.” Catra said.

“Huh?”

“The First Ones, they… They stored Etheria’s magic in the planet’s core. The Heart of Etheria.” Catra explained. “They, they

converted it into a planetary superweapon."

"Hmph. Makes sense." Pyra remarked. "They colonized a lot of planets, made a lot of enemies. Figures they'd want to have a contingency plan."

"Pyra, what… What happened?" Catra asked. "What did the First Ones *do* to the Magicats?"

"I…" Pyra hesitated for a moment. It seemed that thinking about what had happened to her people was a great source of pain for her. "Are you *sure* you wanna know?"

Catra nodded. Pyra sighed and told Catra:

"The First Ones, they… Tried to *eradicate* us. They used their weapon, their *She-Ra,* to wipe the Magicat Kingdom off the face of the planet, they…" Pyra sniffled, tears in her eyes.

"A-and the She-Ra who did that…" Catra was horrified by the realization. "It was-"

"Mara." Pyra nodded. "We, we were friends. I *thought* we were friends. But she turned on me, she… She betrayed me. *Us.* She managed to convince Glacia to join her cause, too. They rounded up all the surviving Magicats and they, *and they-"* Her voice broke, and she was unable to continue.

“No way…” Catra mumbled. How could Adora’s predecessor have done something so monstrous? And Adora had always looked up to Mara as a hero… “Wait, but you said you were a princess? Did you try to-”

“Fight back? I did.” Pyra answered. “But I wasn’t strong enough. Mara managed to sever my connection to my runestone, and I lost most of my powers. That’s how Glacia was able to freeze me all those years ago.”

“Most of your powers?”

Pyra snapped her fingers, causing a small flame to light up over her index finger like a candle.

“This is pretty much all I can do now.” She grabbed a branch off the ground and used the flame to light it on fire, then tossed it into the campfire she had set up. “Not good for much, but… At least I can still light fires.”

“Wait, so when you set the Woods on fire-”

“I was trying to smoke Mara out. I wanted to make her pay for what she did to me, to our people. But seems I was about a millennium too late, she’s not around anymore.”

"Yeah." Catra glanced aside. "Adora's a First One, she's… She's the current She-Ra."

"Adora, huh?" Pyra crossed her arms. "You know her?"

"Y-yeah, you could say that." Catra blushed. "We uh, we grew up together. We've been through a lot over the years, we're…We're in love."

"Wait," Pyra's pupils narrowed out of shock. "You're dating *She-Ra?* You're in love with the weapon that the First Ones used to destroy our entire civilization?!"

"Adora isn't like that!" Catra said defensively. "She's a hero, she's nice and kind and- and… She's the love of my life."

"Just like Glacia was mine."

"Eh?"

"Catra," Pyra said gravely. "Don't make the same mistakes I did, don't let your emotions cloud your judgment. *Be careful around Adora.* You might be on the same page right now, but if she ever flips like Mara did…"

“But-”

“Please. You know what she’s capable of, what *her kind* are capable of. You can’t trust a First One.”

Catra felt incredibly uneasy. She loved Adora, more than anything in the world. She trusted Adora with her life. But deep down, on some level, she knew that Pyra had a point: The Heart of Etheria came close to wiping out a significant chunk of the universe. And She-Ra had been the key to activating it.

Adora fought back against Light Hope to stop it from happening, though. She was just as shocked by what the First Ones had done to Etheria, what the weapon could do. She never wanted to use it.

But… What if something changes? What if one day, Adora snaps? What if she decides to weaponize Etheria’s magic, what if the Heart of Etheria happens again?

No. Adora would **never** do that. Not after everything.

Catra, not wanting to think about this any longer, decided to change the subject and asked Pyra: “...Why did you want me to come here?”

“Ah, right.” Pyra smiled. “Remember what I told you about She-Ra and Glacia rounding up all the Magicats?”

“Yeah.”

“Well, they trapped ‘em inside a chasm deep beneath the Kingdom of Snows, locked them down there. Isolated from the rest of Etheria, completely encased in ice. I want to set them free, but for that… I need your help.”

“Me?” Catra raised an eyebrow. “What can I do? I’m not exactly capable of melting massive chunks of ice, y’know.”

“You’re a Magicat. And that means you’re the only one here I can trust.” Pyra claimed. “Please Catra, I want to save my people. I-I owe it to them.”

“I…” Catra muttered. She wanted to save the Magicats too, but she was still unsure if she could trust Pyra.

“If you do it,” Pyra walked up to Catra, placing her hand on her shoulder. “I’ll help you find your family. I promise.”

Catra gasped. This was finally the lead she’d been searching for, the opportunity she never thought she’d have.

She wanted to do this. But-

“What do ya say?” Pyra asked. “You in?”

“I… I need to think about it. Sorry.” Catra muttered apologetically.

“Of course, by all means!” Pyra said, gently smiling at Catra. “Take your time. The Magicats have been frozen for centuries, what’s a few more days gonna do eh?”

“T-thank you.” Catra cautiously smiled back, then gave Pyra a pleading look as she asked: “I, I want to help, but… Is it okay if I tell Adora about this first?”

“Catra-”

“I-I know what you’re thinking, but she can help!” Catra assured Pyra. “Adora may be a First One, but she’s an Etherian first and foremost. She loves this planet and its people, she… She’s the hero type. As soon as she hears what happened to the Magicats, she’ll **want** to help save them! I’ve seen her do some crazy stuff with her powers-”

“Indubitably.” Pyra scoffed sarcastically.

“Pyra, *please.”* Catra whispered. “I… I **love** her. And I don’t wanna hide this from her. Please?”

Pyra thought about Catra's words for a moment, and while still visibly uncomfortable with the idea she eventually asked Catra: "Do you vouch for her?"

"Yes." Catra said without hesitation.

Pyra grit her teeth, sighed deep and relented: "Fine. You can tell her. See if she's willing to help."

"R-really?" Catra asked hopefully, her eyes sparkling.

"Yeah." Pyra gave Catra a slight smirk. "I can't say 'no' to that face."

"Oh, thank you thank you *thank you!"* Catra was so elated she hugged Pyra. This surprised the older Magicat at first, but soon she hugged Catra back.

"Run along now, kid." Pyra said fondly. "I'll be waiting for ya here."

"You got it!" Once Catra let go of Pyra she grinned wide and said: "I-I'll go get her right away! *Melog!"*

Melog mewled something and turned around, allowing Catra to climb onto its back.

"I'll be right back!" Catra waved at Pyra, then Melog took off running to carry Catra back to Bright Moon.

"Heh." Pyra stared at the direction Catra and Melog went, one hand on her hip. "She's a good kid. Determined, sweet, a bit stubborn but her heart's clearly in the right place. It's almost a shame…"

She shifted her gaze towards the sky, holding out a flame over her index finger.

"I wonder if she's descended from one of yours… *Petra."*

After returning to Bright Moon's courtyard, Catra jumped off of Melog's back. She was about to have Melog turn her invisible so she could sneak back into the castle without being seen, but-

"Catra!"

A familiar voice called out her name. Catra turned her head and saw Glimmer standing there behind her, arms crossed and a

weirdly *knowing* look on her face.

"Oh, hey Sparkles." Catra said. "Didn't see you there."

"Where were you?" Glimmer wondered. "You've been gone for a while."

"Just getting some fresh air." Catra lied, shrugging. "Been one heck of a day, needed a timeout."

"Yeah, I get what you mean." Glimmer nodded.

"Is Adora home yet?" Catra asked her. "Or is she still with Entrapta?"

"Oh, she's home alright." Glimmer replied with a smug grin on her face.

"I hate it when you do that." Catra said dryly. "What's going on?"

"Adora came back hours ago. She's been waiting for you to show up, she's got something she wants to tell you!" Glimmer claimed, doing her best to contain her excitement so she wouldn't spill the beans to Catra.

“Oh, huh. What a coincidence.” Catra muttered. “I uh, I have something I wanna tell her as well. Something big.”

“What is it?”

“Some other time, Sparkles. I need to talk to Adora about it first.”

“Fine.” Glimmer sighed. “She’s waiting in your room. Good luck with… Whatever it is you’re gonna tell her!”

“T-thanks.” Catra said. Glimmer pat her on the back and gave her a wink before teleporting away, as Catra and Melog made their way inside of the castle.

When she reached the door to her and Adora’s room, Catra held her hand on the door handle and sighed. She thought about everything Pyra had told her; About the Magicats, the First Ones, She-Ra… It was going to be a lot for Adora to process. Catra didn’t know where to begin.

But Catra had promised Pyra she would do this.

Catra took a deep breath, then pulled down on the handle.

Meanwhile, Adora had been pacing back and forth around her and Catra's room, her arms crossed and extremely worried. Impatient.

"Where *is* she?" Adora muttered to herself. "C'mon Catra, you had to choose *now* of all days to pull off another one of your disappearing acts-"

Adora froze in place as she heard the door to her room open. Then, she saw-

"Catra!"

"Hey, Adora." Catra said quietly. Adora immediately ran up to Catra and hugged her tight.

"Where have you been?" Adora asked after letting go of Catra. Afterwards she pet Melog, who had walked up to her meowing softly. "I've been worried sick!"

"S-sorry about that." Catra looked aside and scratched the back of her head. "I uh, I was-"

"Listen, I have something to tell you." Adora said. She smiled lovingly as she continued: "Catra, I'm-"

“I was in the Whispering Woods.” Catra cut Adora off. “I, I went to see her.”

“Her?”

“The woman who set the woods on fire.”

“W-what?” Adora’s smile turned to shock. “A-and you went there by yourself? *Why?!* Did you, did you find her?”

“Adora-”

“Are you okay? She didn’t hurt you, did she?”

“Adora, I’m fine.” Catra reassured her. “Relax.”

“Why did you go there without any backup?” Adora asked, exasperated. “We could’ve caught her!”

“I didn’t wanna scare her off.” Catra explained. “I… I needed to talk to her.”

“About *what?”* Adora’s confusion grew by the second.

“When you guys were putting out the fire, and I tackled her,” Catra started. “Her hood fell off. And I saw her face.”

“Wait, but you said you didn’t see-”

“She looks like *me,* Adora.” Catra explained. “The ears, the eyes, the tail… They were all just like mine. And I, I’ve never met anyone who was like me before. I-I’d always thought I was the only one of my kind. But then she shows up, she… She-”

“Catra.” Adora said sympathetically, seeming to soften somewhat.

“She told me to find her in the woods.” Catra continued. “And she told me a lot of things. About herself, about our kind… About me. Her name is Pyra, she’s the Princess of Fire.”

“A princess?” Adora gasped, then added: “Of fire? Well, that explains the forest.”

“Pyra told me what I am.” Catra muttered. “I, I would’ve never known without her. I always wondered if there were more like me out there, if there was a word for it, a-and-”

Adora noticed that Catra’s hands were shaking and she gently held them to comfort her. With Adora smiling reassuringly at her,

Catra took a deep breath to calm down and then told her:

"Adora, I'm… I'm *a Magicat."*

"A Magi- what now?" Adora tilted her head.

"Right? That's what I thought too." Catra chuckled. "According to Pyra our kind even had their own kingdom, but-"

She paused for a moment, deciding not to tell Adora about the First Ones' or She-Ra's involvement just yet.

"It was wiped out centuries ago. As were most of the Magicats."

"Whoa." Adora said quietly, shocked by this reveal.

"Pyra, she uh…" Catra looked Adora in the eyes. "She was frozen in ice for a thousand years. She, she managed to get out just recently."

"Really?" Adora whispered. "So wait, when she mentioned Mara-"

“Adora,” Catra smiled. “The other Magicats, they’ve been trapped for centuries. Pyra wants to set them free and she needs my help, and in exchange…” Her voice was a little shaky out of excitement as she finished: *“She said she’s gonna help me find my mother.”*

“Catra…”

“I’ve been waiting so long for this, Adora. All the time I spent searching for her, looking for answers. Pyra, she’s the first proper lead I have, I-I have to see it through! Please,” Catra gently cupped Adora’s cheeks. “I, I need your help. **We** need your help, to save the Magicats.”

Adora remained quiet for a moment, before eventually asking Catra: “How does Pyra know all this?”

“Huh? B-because she’s also a Magicat, Adora!” Catra said. “She was there to witness when their kingdom fell, she-”

“And you’re just... Gonna believe her?” Adora questioned her. “Take her at her word? Just like that?”

“W-what?”

Catra was so confused, so troubled. This wasn’t the reaction she had expected out of Adora.

“Catra,” Adora started. “She set the Whispering Woods on fire, she attacked us, she tried to *kill* Frosta! She’s clearly up to something sinister.”

“Adora-”

“Besides, if she’s really been frozen for a thousand years…” Adora shook her head. “How would she know *anything* about how to find your mom?”

“I…” Catra muttered. She felt so let down and disappointed. “I thought you’d *want* to help. That you’d wanna save the Magicats.”

“I *do* wanna help, Catra!” Adora stated. “I just don’t trust Pyra, she’s bad news.”

“This is for **me,** Adora!” Catra cried. “You know how much I’ve wanted to find my mother!”

“I know! And we’re gonna find her, together!” Adora placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder. “But I’m sorry, this… This isn’t the way.”

Feeling frustrated and angry, Catra slapped Adora’s hand away and coldly said: “Why did I think you would understand? How important finding my mom is to me? **You** were always Shadow

Weaver's *favorite,* after all. You already know what it's like to have someone who cares about you."

"What?" Adora felt incredibly hurt by this comment. "What are you- Catra, *she hurt me too!* All Shadow Weaver ever did was use and manipulate me, the both of us! She *never* loved me or cared-"

"At least she ***PRETENDED TO!"*** Catra shouted. "That's more than she ever bothered showing ME!"

After a period of extremely uncomfortable silence, Catra sighed deep feeling really ashamed of herself for what she had said, for lashing out at Adora. For having slid back into her old, toxic habits of trying to hurt people.

"I'm sorry." Catra closed her eyes. "I-I shouldn't have. It was a low blow."

"Yeah. It was." Said Adora, who still felt upset.

"I'm just… I feel *so close* to finally figuring out why I was abandoned." Catra reopened her eyes, which now looked misty. "Why mom never wanted me. Why she left me with *Shadow Weaver.* You… You at least know **why** you're here, Adora."

"Catra, Light Hope *kidnapped me* when I was a baby!" Adora countered. "I never got to know anything about my family, either!

And I'm… *I'm good with that."*

"You are?"

"Yes." Adora gently held Catra's hand. "I'll never know anything about my family or where I came from, and I've made peace with that years ago. And frankly, I don't **need** to know. Because I have everything I could possibly want, right here."

"Adora…"

Catra knew that Adora meant well. But her unwillingness to see things from Catra's point of view was making the anger and bitterness within her grow further.

"Catra, I have you." Adora tried to reason with her. "And you have me. And Bow and Glimmer, and everyone else. We… *We've got each other."* She cautiously smiled at Catra. "Isn't that enough?"

"...Easy for *you* to say." Catra hissed, unable to hold herself back anymore. "After what *your people* did to mine."

***"'My** people?'"*

Adora was getting heated now too, her brows furrowing and her smile turning into a frown. Melog was nervously glancing between Adora and Catra, quietly meowing something.

"Pyra told me." Catra glared at Adora. "What the First Ones did. They persecuted the Magicats, rounded them up and destroyed their kingdom. Drove them to near extinction!"

"They would've ***never*** done something like that!" Adora raised her voice.

"Oh yeah?" Catra poked Adora's chest with her index finger. "What about the Heart of Etheria? What the First Ones did to the planet? You and I both know fully well what they were capable of!"

"What, and is that somehow *my fault?* You're blaming *me* for what my ancestors did a thousand years ago?"

"I never said I was blaming you!"

"Then what ARE you saying?!" Adora asked, full on shouting by now. "Because it sounds like you're trying to pin the First Ones' actions on me!"

"You're *She-Ra!"* Catra yelled. "You *owe it* to the Magicats to save them!"

"What do you mean?"

"You wanna know who rounded up the Magicats?" Catra asked. "She-Ra did! **Mara!** She's the reason they've all been trapped for over a thousand years!"

"What? That's *ridiculous!"* Adora exclaimed, completely incredulous. "Mara was a hero, she wouldn't have **ever** done something so evil! She, *she was a victim!"*

"Pyra said-"

"Pyra's lying to you! Obviously!" Adora wildly gestured at Catra with her hands. "The way she's slandering Mara just goes to show she can't be trusted! She was probably lying to you about helping you find your mom too, Catra! She, she was just telling you what you wanted to hear so you'd do what she says."

Catra clenched her fists, doing her best to contain her rage. She closed her eyes for a moment and took a deep breath, then reopened them with fierce determination on her face.

"I am going to find the other Magicats." Catra said, trying to sound calm even if she was shaking with fury on the inside. "With… *Or **without** you."*

"Ugh!" Adora groaned, her blood boiling. "You're such a stubborn **bonehead** sometimes!"

"Yeah?" Catra coldly stared at Adora. "Well, at least ***my*** *ancestors* never tried to pull off a **genocide."**

Melog looked so anxious: It had never seen Catra and Adora argue to this degree, and its anxiety just grew as it witnessed the way Adora's face was warped by anger after Catra's comment.

"You watch your MOUTH." Adora snarled at Catra through gritted teeth.

"Or what?" Catra taunted her. "You're gonna *kill* me? Finish what the First Ones started?"

"SHUT UP!" Adora shouted at the top of her lungs. "Urgh, you're always pulling stuff like this! Throwing a temper tantrum any time you don't get things your way!"

Catra laughed mockingly. *"Oh I'm REALLY sorry, Miss 'Look at me I'm She-Ra, I'm beloved and popular and always get everything I want!'"*

"Grow up." Adora scoffed, shaking her head. "You're acting like a child."

"'Grow up?!' All I wanna do here is find my parents!" Catra was on the verge of tears and desperately begged: "Adora, *please*. This, this might be my one and only chance! Help me and Pyra with this! ***Please!"***

"No!" Adora declined. "I'm not doing *anything* to help Pyra! She's obviously evil!"

"She's **not!"** Catra's anger rose to the surface once more. "She's just misunderstood! If anything, Mara's the one who was evil the whole time!"

"I can't believe we're even having this discussion!" Adora was nearing her breaking point. "Catra, PYRA CAN'T BE TRUSTED! How *stupid* do you have to be to think-"

"I'm not *ASKING YOU* to trust **Pyra!"** Catra shouted. "But would it kill you *FOR **ONCE** IN YOUR LIFE TO TRUST **ME,** ADORA?!"*

Adora, losing her patience and completely fed up with Catra's attitude, bellowed: ***"IT'S A LITTLE HARD AFTER EVERYTHING YOU'VE DONE!"***

Silence.

Catra could feel her entire life shattering before her very eyes, her heart being crushed into a million pieces. Adora was breathing heavily and hadn't fully processed what she had just blurted out, until she saw the sheer heartbreak and devastation on Catra's face, the tears streaming down her cheeks.

"Oh no." Adora gasped, covering her mouth with her hands and utterly horrified by her own words. "Catra, I-I didn't-"

"Oh." Catra's voice sounded completely empty and drained as she wiped the tears from her eyes. "So **that's** what this is about."

She sniffled and turned her back on Adora, unable to even look at her anymore. Adora was so riddled with shame and disgust for herself, for what she had said. For having let things get to this point.

"Catra, Catra I'm s-sorry, I-I'm so sorry," Adora apologized frantically. "I-I was angry, I didn't mean it like that, I-I didn't mean to…"

When Catra said nothing, Adora finally remembered that she hadn't told Catra. If she didn't do this now…

"Catra." Adora started. "Catra, I'm pr-"

"I'm leaving."

“W-what?” Adora mumbled. She witnessed Catra opening the door that led to the balcony in their bedroom. “Catra-”

“I’m not coming back.” Catra said quietly, her voice trembling.

“No!” Adora teared up herself now, realizing the gravity of Catra’s words. “C-Catra, don’t go! Please, I’m sorry! I-I didn’t mean what I said, w-we can talk this out, I… Y-you can’t leave me like this, please! I-I *need* you, Catra!”

Catra didn’t respond, she just gestured at Melog to come to her. Melog gave Adora a sad meow and then very hesitantly walked up to Catra, clearly not wanting to do this.

“Please!” Adora sobbed, desperate to stop Catra from doing what she was about to do. “I-it can’t just end like this! N-not after everything we’ve been through! Catra,” She grabbed Catra’s arm. Her voice broke as she whispered: *“Catra, I* ***love*** *you.”*

“...I love you too.” Catra managed to say. “But, if you don’t trust me, then-” She turned her head to face Adora, who was mortified by how resigned and hurt Catra looked. *“What are we doing here?* What’s the point, why keep up the charade?”

“Please.” Adora begged. “Please, Catra. I-I'm so sorry, p-please don’t go! Please don’t do this to me-”

"Adora." Catra said. *"It's* ***over."***

"B-but- No, y-you can't, you- Catra, please..."

Catra wrenched her arm out of Adora's hands, then climbed on the balcony railing. She was staring towards the Whispering Woods.

"Catra, listen to me, I'm-" Adora tried one last time to tell Catra, to stop her from leaving her, but the latter had already made up her mind.

"Goodbye, Adora." Catra sighed. "Sorry about all the things I did... Sorry I couldn't be the *perfect, flawless girlfriend* for you."

"NO! Catra, WAIT!" Adora tried to stop her, but Catra had Melog turn her invisible as she leapt off the balcony, landing on the patch of grass on the other side and running off into the woods beyond.

"No, nononono! NO! *CATRA!* ***CATRAAAAAAA!"***

Adora cried after her, but it was too late. Catra was gone.

Catra had left her. *For good.*

"No…" Adora fell to her knees, screaming in anguish before completely breaking down crying her eyes out. While the tears kept flowing she placed her hand over her stomach, thinking of her baby and sobbed: "P-please no, I-I can't do this alone! I can't, I-I-"

"Adora!"

Just then, Glimmer appeared out of nowhere with Bow, having teleported to Adora's room.

"Adora, we heard you scream. What happened?" Bow walked up to Adora and crouched down in front of her.

"I…" Adora immediately hugged Bow as tight as she could, wailing against his shoulder.

"Adora, what's going on?" Glimmer felt extremely concerned seeing Adora in this state.

"C-C-Catra…" Adora eventually managed to get out. "We, w-we had a fight, a really bad one a-and… *C-Catra **left** me."*

"She *what?"* Bow gasped.

"No." Glimmer clenched her fists, outraged. "Is this because of the baby? Ohhh, when I get my hands on Catra I am SO going to give her *a piece of my mind-"*

"No, it's not that, I," Adora clarified. "I-it's all my fault, I ruined *everything!"*

"We're here, Adora." Bow said gently. "Glimmer and I, we've got your back. You can tell us what happened."

"It's going to be okay, Adora. We promise." Glimmer pat Adora on the back.

Bow and Glimmer stood by Adora's side for the rest of the day, letting Adora pour her heart out to them while she explained what had happened, and doing everything they could to try and comfort her.

Meanwhile, Catra was making her way deeper into the Whispering Woods without looking back. It was taking all of her remaining strength to not completely break down, the pain and heartache inside of her was agonizing, overwhelming… But she was going to remain strong.

Catra had tried so hard to change, grow. Move on from the many, *many* mistakes she had made in the past. The consequences of her actions were going to haunt her forever, but despite everything Catra had always thought that, even if nobody else would be willing to believe in her… *At the very least Adora would.*

Adora would trust her. Adora would count on her.

Adora would believe Catra had become better.

Catra didn't care what anyone else thought of her. As long as Adora had been willing to give her a second chance, that was all she needed.

But even Adora hadn't been able to let go. Despite how long they had been together, Adora was always going to hold Catra's past against her. Adora would never be able to trust her again.

If even *Adora* couldn't believe that Catra was capable of changing… Then what was the point in even *trying* to become better? If everybody still thought Catra was a villain and a monster, if nobody trusted her or believed in her, she might as well do whatever she pleases. Whatever her heart tells her to do.

Melog was desperately trying to wrench Catra away from this train of thought, from her own self-destructive tendencies that had

been resurfacing. It meowed frantically at Catra and tried to nudge her to get her to go back, but Catra wasn't breaking her stride.

"Go away." Catra mumbled when Melog pushed Catra's thigh with its snout. "Leave me alone."

Eventually Melog walked up in front of Catra, staring her down and blocking her path forward.

"Move." Catra glared at Melog.

Melog's eyes narrowed and it arched its back. It looked ready to pounce on Catra at any moment.

*"I SAID **MOVE!"*** Catra roared, raising her claws. However, as Melog kept meowing at her and didn't budge, Catra eventually gave up the facade and let out a dejected sigh. She gave Melog a sad, pleading look as she said: "Melog. Please. Go home."

Melog meowed trying to argue back and convince Catra to also return home, but Catra shook her head.

"I can't go back." She whispered. "Not anymore. I… I need you to look after Adora for me while I'm gone, okay pal?"

Catra walked up to Melog and gently pet it's head. Melog let out a sad whimper, and Catra just smiled at it.

"I'll be fine." Catra assured. "I promise. Adora, she... *She needs you right now."*

Melog, with its tail tucked between its legs, finally relented and moved out of Catra's way, slowly making its way back towards Bright Moon. Catra looked on as Melog disappeared out of sight, then continued her trek deeper into the woods.

Eventually, Catra made it back to Pyra's campsite where the older Magicat was sitting with her arms crossed, staring into the fire she had made. Pyra's ears perked up as she heard the sound of Catra's footsteps and she turned her head.

"You're back!" Pyra ran up to Catra to meet her halfway. "How'd it go? What did Adora say?"

Catra didn't respond. Then, Pyra saw how completely and utterly *devastated* Catra looked, and grew concerned.

"Catra?" Pyra asked, placing her hands over Catra's shoulders and very gently shaking her. "Catra, what's wrong? What happened-"

Before Pyra could finish, Catra had hugged her tight. Pyra noticed how shaky Catra's breathing was as she clinged onto her.

“It’s okay.” Pyra whispered into Catra's ear while she held Catra in her arms, trying to soothe her. “It’s okay. I’m here.”

Eventually Catra let go of Pyra, then with tears in her eyes she said to her:

“I’m in.”

Chapter End Notes

And that's a wrap on act one!

Next chapter might take a little bit longer to come out as life's currently kicking my ass at the moment, but keep your eyes peeled!

Chapter 5: The Raging Inferno

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra are coping with the aftermath of their breakup, being supported by Bow, Glimmer & Micah and Pyra respectively. Adora resolves to finding out more information about Glacia and figuring out what Pyra is really up to, while Catra asks Pyra how they're going to set the other Magicats free.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora, breakfast is ready."

Glimmer had just teleported into Adora's room, holding a tray of fried eggs, croissants, orange juice and coffee. Adora was laying on her side on the bed, facing away from Glimmer. Bow had sat down at the foot of Adora's bed trying to keep her company, while Melog had also placed its head on the bed purring gently.

"I'm not hungry." Adora mumbled. Her voice was hoarse, tired and completely devoid of emotion, having spent all of her energy crying herself to sleep over what had happened yesterday.

"Adora, you haven't eaten anything since last morning." Bow reminded her. "It's not healthy."

"I'm *fine."* Adora claimed, without bothering to even look at Bow.

“No, you’re not fine.” Glimmer sighed, setting the tray on the nightstand by Adora’s bed and gently placing her hand on Adora’s arm. “And you’re allowed to not be fine. I understand you’re heartbroken over Catra, but-”

“Oh, you do huh?” Adora shot a bitter, resentful glare at Glimmer which made the latter gasp. “You understand? You’ve been through this before? Had the love of your life walk out on you while you’re *pregnant with their child?!”*

“N-no, but I-”

“That’s what I thought.” Adora said coldly. “Stay in your lane. You, you two have ***no*** *idea* what I’m going through right now.”

“Adora,” Bow said as Glimmer backed away. “Starving yourself won’t bring Catra back-”

“NOTHING *WILL!”* Adora sat up and shrieked at the top of her lungs with tears in her eyes, causing Bow, Glimmer and Melog to all flinch. “You hear me?! **Nothing!** There’s not a thing I can do or say that would bring her back! Catra, s-she’s, she’s *never* going to forgive me, a-and it’s all my fault!”

After waiting for a moment to let Adora get her emotions out, Melog placed its head on Adora’s lap. Adora pet its head, calming

down slightly.

"I... I'm sorry." Adora muttered, regretting the way she had lashed out at her best friends.

"It's okay." Glimmer assured her. "We know you're on edge right now."

"I just, I just want her back." Adora cried. "I-I miss her so much, I… I should've never said those things, i-it's my fault Catra's gone and-"

"Adora, you're not being fair on yourself." Bow claimed. "You and Catra were both really worked up and said some hurtful things you didn't mean. Catra wasn't exactly fair towards you, either."

"Maybe," Adora sniffled. "But I still went too far. I-I reopened all of her old wounds, I… I don't know what to do."

"Talk to her." Glimmer encouraged Adora. "Once the dust has settled. You and Catra have been through so much together, you've managed to survive *way* worse than a simple argument!"

"It wasn't just an argument, I…" Adora stared at her hands. "I made Catra think that I don't trust her, t-that I still hold her past against her. I, I have no idea how to fix that."

"*Do* you still trust her?" Bow asked her.

"Of course I do!" Adora said without hesitation. "A-and I know Catra's a different person now, she wouldn't do those things anymore, I was just…" She slumped down on the bed and sighed. "I was so angry and lost my patience. Catra, she's had this tendency to act on impulse and make bad decisions, I-I saw she was sliding back into that with Pyra and wanted to stop her but instead I… I pushed her away. And she's not coming back. I-I've lost her, *I've lost Catra."*

"Adora, Catra loves you more than *anything* in the universe." Glimmer assured her. "She needs time to process things, but I'm sure she misses you at least as much as you miss her. She'll come around eventually, then you can talk things through."

"Glimmer's right." Bow smiled at Adora. "She sent Melog back here, I don't think she would've done that if she wasn't also planning to come back at some point. There's still time to fix things. But right now," Bow gestured at the tray Glimmer had set on the nightstand. "You should really try to eat something."

"I told you I'm not-"

"Adora." Glimmer held Adora's hand and looked her in the eye. "Please. You… You're *eating for two* now. You're allowed to be sad and upset, it's only natural you'd miss Catra, but you shouldn't punish the baby for it."

Adora gasped, realizing that Glimmer was right. She shifted her gaze to her stomach, sighed and finally relented:

"Okay. I-I'll try."

She grabbed a croissant from the tray and slowly bit into it. Bow and Glimmer both held their hands on Adora's shoulders and smiled at her as she ate.

"It's okay, Adora." Glimmer said quietly. "Bow and I are here for you. We're gonna take care of you, no matter what."

While the sun was still rising from the horizon, Pyra was hard at work brewing a pot of coffee over the campfire she had made. She kept adding dry branches and leaves to the fire, and once she saw steam coming out of the spout she took the pot, poured some coffee into her empty cup and took a sip.

"Ahh." Pyra sighed happily. "That hits the spot."

While slowly finishing her coffee, Pyra soon heard the sound of footsteps coming from the tent behind her back. She turned her head and smiled cautiously.

“Morning.” Pyra said.

Catra had walked out of the tent, looking completely miserable and her eyes bloodshot. She sat down by the fire next to Pyra, hugging her own knees without saying a word.

“Want some coffee?” Pyra asked her. “It’s freshly made.”

“...No thanks.” Catra managed to say, her voice sounding raspy and weak.

“You sure?” Pyra gave Catra a concerned look. “Because ya look like you could *really* use some.”

“Fine. Whatever.” Catra sighed. Pyra smiled, pouring coffee into another cup and handing it over to Catra. Catra took a sip without saying anything, just staring into the fire with a pained, longing look on her face.

“Did ya manage to get any sleep?” Pyra wondered.

Without even bothering to look at her, Catra replied: “Eventually.”

Pyra noticed Catra's eyes getting misty and sighed.

"You're… Thinking about Adora, aren't you?"

"Mind your own business." Catra hissed, giving Pyra a nasty glare before turning more apologetic. "...Sorry."

"It's fine." Pyra placed her hand on Catra's shoulder. "Catra, I know it hurts now, but it's going to get better with time. I went through the same with Glacia, it… *It gets easier."*

Catra gave Pyra a very meek nod, still looking forlorn.

"You made the right choice by leaving, kid." Pyra stated. "Like I said, ya can't trust a First One. Adora, she would've turned on you sooner or later. She would've *never* understood how important this is to you. But I do."

"I… I still love her." Catra whispered. "I love her so much. But, *I have to do this.* A-and if Adora and everyone else thinks I'm still a bad guy no matter what I do," Her voice turned bitter and vengeful. "I might as well do whatever I please. What my heart tells me to do."

"Exactly." Pyra nodded. She gave Catra an encouraging smile. "Listen, after we free the other Magicats and find your mom, you

could always go back and talk to Adora! See if ya can still make things work, like make amends, y'know?"

"I, I dunno." Catra said hesitantly. "If Adora can't trust me, then I don't know if there's any point in us trying. A-and… She probably doesn't even *want* me back, anyway. Not anymore."

"What do ya mean?" Pyra wondered.

"T-this isn't the first time I've done this." Catra explained. "Running away like this. I've, I've hurt her too much, so many times, all my life. S-she doesn't deserve that… Maybe, it's better this way."

"I understand." Pyra said sympathetically. "But hey, I still appreciate that you chose to come here, help me out. It… It means a lot to me."

Catra managed to muster up a very slight, weak smile. On the inside, she was still torn up. Part of her would have wanted to go back to Bright Moon, back to Adora. See if she could still give Catra another chance, if Catra could make things up with her. Go back to the way they were, in love. Together.

But… Catra had to help Pyra, help the other Magicats. She had to find her mom. *No matter the cost.*

"Us Magicats, we gotta stick together." Pyra stated. "No matter what happens, I want you to know that I've got your back, Catra. Just like I know you'll have mine."

"I… Yeah." Catra mumbled.

Pyra smiled proudly at Catra. It was weird, the way Pyra acted towards her… Catra had never experienced something like this before. It was a closer bond than merely being friends, but not quite the same that one might have with a parental figure.

The best way Catra could describe it, as far as she was able to tell, was that Pyra treated her like *an older sibling* might have.

Is this what it would have been like? To have a sister?

"You and I," Pyra said. "We're gonna restore the Magicats to their former glory."

"Feeling better?" Bow asked Adora.

"A little." Adora muttered.

Adora had finally been able to get out of bed, dress up and get back on her feet. She was walking down the corridors of Bright Moon with Bow and Glimmer by her side.

"We're gonna head to the Kingdom of Snows soon." Glimmer stated. "To help Frosta out at the library, see if there's any information we can find about Glacia or Pyra, or the Magicats. If you feel up for it." She added after seeing how depressed Adora still was.

"Sure." Adora muttered. While her mind was mainly occupied by thoughts about Catra and how much she missed her, there was something else; A fear that she hadn't been able to vocalize yet.

"Really?" Bow wondered. "Because you look really bothered by something. Hey, Glimmer and I can do this by ourselves if you don't-"

"No, I wanna do it." Adora clarified, having stopped walking. "I just…" She let out a deep sigh. "There's, there's *no way* Mara could be responsible for what happened to the Magicats, right?"

"Of course not!" Glimmer replied. "We all know Mara was a hero. If anything, she would've wanted to *save* the Magicats rather than persecute them."

"That's what I keep telling myself too. But," Adora closed her eyes. "I-I can't get the thought out of my head that… *What if Pyra*

is right? What if the First Ones and Mara *really did-"*

"Adora, based on what you told us Pyra seems *really* shady." Bow stated. "You shouldn't listen to what she says. I'm sure Catra will eventually realize it too, realize that you were right about her all along and comes back!"

"I hope you're right." Adora whispered. Her gaze wandered down to her navel. "But if she doesn't I… *I-I'm gonna have to raise this child alone."*

"You won't be alone." Glimmer comforted her. "Bow and I are gonna support you in every way we can. Dad as well, he's great with kids!"

"It's gonna be alright, Adora." Bow said gently. "We won't let anything bad happen to either of you."

"...Thank you." Adora muttered, finally managing to smile slightly. "I'm so glad to have you guys, I-I don't know what I'd do if-"

"Adora?"

Adora, Bow and Glimmer all turned around after hearing Adora's name being called. King Micah was standing there, giving Adora a sad, sympathetic smile and looking really thoughtful.

“M-Micah…” Adora said quietly.

“Hey, dad.” Glimmer smiled, greeting her father.

“Hey, baby girl.” Micah affectionately ruffled Glimmer’s hair, then turned to Adora and asked her: “How are you holding up?”

“I uh… A bit better than yesterday, I guess.” Adora shrugged. “Still not great, though.”

“I understand." Micah nodded sadly. "Is it okay if I talk to you for a second? Alone?”

“Sure, but uh, we’re heading to the Kingdom of Snows soon and-”

“It’s fine.” Glimmer said. “Bow and I will be waiting in my room, we’ll get going once you’re done.”

Bow and Glimmer then departed, leaving Adora and Micah standing in the hallway by themselves.

“Micah, I… I'm…" Adora sighed.

“Come here.” Micah spread his arms. Adora hesitated for a second, before accepting the gentle hug from Micah. “It’s going to be okay. Losing someone you love always hurts, but eventually it’s going to get better. One way or another.”

“Y-yeah.” Adora sniffled. “I know.”

“Have you heard anything from Catra?”

“She sent Melog here, but…” Adora shook her head, dejected. “I don’t think she’s coming back. You know how Catra is, she-”

“She can be real stubborn sometimes.” Micah finished, then encouraged Adora: “But you two have gone through so much, you were enemies for years and you still managed to find each other! You’re going to get through this too, it might just take a little while. She loves you, Adora.”

“I don’t know if I did the right thing, Micah.” Adora admitted, glancing aside. “What if Catra was right about Pyra, if I should’ve gone with her? To help her find her family, if nothing else? She’s been searching so desperately ever since she found the letter from her mom… It’s been eating away at her.”

“I know.” Micah replied. “Catra’s told me a lot about how much she wants to see her mother. Get some answers.”

“I’m so scared I’ve lost her forever.” Adora whispered. “Especially now, with me being… Ugh, I should’ve just *told her* when I had the chance!”

“Things happened so fast.” Micah said sympathetically. “You can tell Catra the next time you see her.”

“I want to, but… I also don’t want her to come back *only* because of the baby.” Adora confessed. “I-I want to make things right with her first, so she doesn’t feel *obligated* to stay, y’know?”

“That’s completely understandable.” Micah smiled at her. “Adora listen, I was thinking… I could go talk to Catra for you, if you’d like.”

“Huh? But-”

“Not about the pregnancy, of course. But in general. Catra and I are pretty close, I could try to convince her to come back. See if she’d be willing to talk things through with you!"

“Thanks, but… You don’t have to.” Adora turned him down. “Catra would just think that I sent you and assume I don’t have the guts to face her myself. You know how she is.”

“Right. Sorry.” Micah awkwardly rubbed the back of his head.

“It’s fine.” Adora steeled her resolve. “Catra made her choice. Right now I’m gonna focus on trying to figure out what Pyra is up to and how to stop her. See what she’s *plotting.”*

“Alright.” Micah nodded. “Be safe, Adora.”

“I will.”

Adora began making her way towards Glimmer’s room. While she still missed Catra, she couldn’t let anything distract her from her duty.

She was She-Ra. The Hero of Etheria. And right now, Etheria had a new enemy that she needed to defend it from.

Adora had to find out. *What was Pyra planning?*

“So… How do we free the Magicats?”

Catra had finished eating the soup that Pyra had made them for lunch, and was staring inquisitively at the Fire Princess who was still busy chowing down her own portion.

"Oh, right!" Pyra swallowed. "So, remember what I told ya yesterday? Mara raised her sword against the Magicats, I tried to stop her but then Glacia interfered."

"Yeah, I remember."

"Like I said earlier," Pyra set her plate down. "Mara forced the Magicats into a crevice deep underneath the Kingdom of Snows, with Glacia sealing the entrance shut with ice that formed a massive glacier. With my control over fire it'd be a cinch to melt the ice and set 'em free, but I lost most of my powers when Mara severed my connection to the Sunstone. My runestone."

"Right." Catra crossed her arms. "See, that's the part I don't get. I don't think simple flames would be enough to thaw an entire iceberg."

"Ah, but who said anything about *simple* flames?" Pyra smirked.

"Huh?"

"The Sunstone is… A bit *different* from the other runestones. See," Pyra gestured at Catra with her hand. "The princesses of Magicat

Kingdom always had a particular proficiency with magic. My predecessors, they tinkered with the Sunstone and boosted it's capabilities."

"That sounds similar to the Heart of Etheria." Catra muttered. "How the First Ones tampered with the other princesses' runestones, supercharging their powers…"

"Where do ya think they got the idea from?" Pyra chuckled. "The Fire Princess has traditionally had a special ability, called *the Raging Inferno.* To tap into it I can absorb the stored energy of my ancestors from the Sunstone itself and use it to conjure *an everlasting fire,* one that cannot be put out by water or any other ordinary means! Legend has it that one of my predecessors used it to turn a lush jungle into a desolate wasteland, which is how the Crimson Waste came to be."

"R-really?" Catra wondered. Pyra nodded and continued:

"At its peak, the Inferno can reach temperatures which rival that of several *suns.* THAT is how we're gonna free the Magicats."

"Uhhh, you sure that is safe?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow. "Because that sounds **incredibly** dangerous."

"No worries, kid!" Pyra assured her, dismissively waving her hand. "I'll be in total control of the fire, and once the Magicats are safe I

also know how to put the flames out in a way that's completely harmless."

"Well then, what are we waiting for?" Catra jumped up excitedly. "Let's go do it!"

"Hold your horses." Pyra settled her down. "It ain't that simple, otherwise I'd have done it already."

"Why not?"

"During the time I've been frozen, the Sunstone has gone missing. I went to the ruins of Magicat Kingdom when I thawed out, but it's not there anymore."

"Oh." Catra sighed, sitting back down. "So then, what do we-"

"There were no signs of it having been destroyed." Pyra explained. "Runestones in general are indestructible, far as I know. So the only option is that Mara must have *moved it* somewhere else after Glacia put me on ice."

"Hmmm…" Catra began thinking out loud. "Any ideas where she could have taken it?"

"Your guess is as good as mine."

"Someone from the past would probably know where it is."

"Well, Mara and Glacia definitely would, but I can't exactly go and ask them." Pyra snarked.

"If they went through the effort of hiding the stone, they definitely would've marked the location down *somewhere."* Catra speculated. "And they might've passed that information down to future generations."

"Even if they had, how would we even access said information?" Pyra questioned. "Without that knowledge, finding the Sunstone's whereabouts would be more or less impossible. It could be literally anywhere."

"Maybe *WE* don't **need** to find it." A devious smirk formed on Catra's face. She was returning back to her old mindset from when she was still a Force Captain, coming up with schemes to undermine the Rebellion. "Perhaps *someone else* could do the job for us!"

"Oh?" Pyra tilted her head.

"I think I might have an idea." Catra stood up, brimming with confidence. "But we're gonna need some help to pull it off. And I

know *exactly* who can help us!”

“You do?” Pyra wondered.

“You stay here.” Catra turned around. “I’m gonna go visit *an old friend of mine.”*

“Alright. Be safe, kid!”

Pyra looked on as Catra walked away, being both proud of her while at the same time feeling slightly guilty.

“Cunning, confident and clever.” Pyra remarked to herself. “She’s a Magicat, that’s for sure. An exemplary member of our race…”

She sighed, bitterly staring at her left arm that had been blackened by frostbite.

“I *really* wish I didn’t have to lie. I wish I could tell her the whole story. But, she would never understand me. Understand why I *have* to do this. I’ve waited for so long… *Too long.”*

Pyra clenched her fist and lost herself in deep thought, reminiscing about events that had happened a long time ago, yet only felt like a few weeks to her.

Over a thousand years in the past.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter is going to mark the start of a series of flashbacks, shedding some more light on Pyra's backstory. We might see a few familiar faces from that time period, too!

I went with 'Sunstone' for the name of Pyra's runestone, simply because the Moonstone already existed and I figured that would make for a nice thematic counterpart.

Chapter 6: Fire & Ice

Chapter Summary

> Pyra flashes back to a thousand years ago, reminiscing about her past with Glacia and Mara and the events that preceded the fall of Magicat Kingdom. In the present, Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta are going through the library in the Kingdom of Snows, finally managing to find a lead regarding Glacia.

Chapter Notes

> Story takes a bit of a darker turn starting from this chapter, so the content warning has been updated just in case.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Pyra took in the cold winter air as she wandered through the Kingdom of Snows. There was vapor coming out of her mouth as she breathed and the snow and ice underneath her feet were freezing, but she was managing to remain completely warm. Part of it was thanks to the ball of fire she was holding in her left hand, but she was also feeling warmth for a very different reason.

Pyra fiddled with a necklace she was wearing with her right hand. The necklace had a silver pendant in the shape of a snowflake, which she had gotten from-

"Glacia!"

When she reached the kingdom's castle courtyard, Pyra saw a blue-haired woman who was busy using her powers over ice to

make an ice sculpture. The woman was wearing traditional clothing typical to the Kingdom of Snows, but on her left hand she had a black bracelet made out of obsidian.

"Oh!" The woman turned her head when she heard Pyra calling for her, and an excited grin formed on her face as she ran towards the Magicat. "Hey, Pyra!"

Glacia embraced Pyra tight and shared a loving kiss with her.

"Did ya miss me?"

"A little. C'mon, look what I made!"

"Hmmm…" Pyra observed the ice sculpture; It was of herself and Glacia wearing ornate dresses and dancing together, holding hands with their fingers intertwined. "That's very cute, Glacia! Buuuut, my nose ain't THAT big." She paused for a second and asked Glacia: "...Is it?"

"Catty as always, I see." Glacia snarked affectionately, wrapping her arms around Pyra's neck.

"You knew what you were getting into when we got engaged." Pyra smiled at her with nothing but admiration and love on her face, and the two shared a tender kiss. "Speaking of, we should probably start planning the wedding soon."

“Oh, right!” Glacia nodded. “Dad’s been so excited about it already, just looking forward to the day he can walk *‘his little girl’* down the aisle!”

“Yeah, Petra as well!” Pyra laughed. “She really wants to be my maid of honor, but I was already thinking of asking Mara and-”

“Wait,” Glacia interrupted her. “***I*** was gonna ask Mara to be *my* maid of honor!”

“You were? Oh…” Pyra looked slightly awkward, but then had a realization: “Wait, but then that means I can ask Petra! Oh, she’s gonna be so happy about it, and I’m sure Mara will-”

“What are you two plotting behind my back?” A snarky voice asked. Pyra and Glacia turned their heads and saw a tan-skinned woman in blue clothing with long, brown hair tied in a braid, who was carrying an ornate sword in her hand.

“Mara!” Glacia let go of Pyra and ran up to Mara to hug her. “It’s been too long, so good to see ya!”

“Likewise!” Mara said happily, then waved at Pyra and greeted her: “Hey, Pyra!”

“Heya, *She-Ra.”* Pyra crossed her arms with a playful grin on her face, causing Mara to blush a little. “I kinda figured you’d be too busy to hang with us regular princesses anymore!”

“I’m never too busy to see my two best friends.” Mara fired back, looking equally playful.

“Well? How’s your new duty as She-Ra gone so far?”

“Eh, I’m still learning.” Mara shrugged. “But I’m catching on more every day!”

“I bet!” Glacia said. “You always were the smartest of the three of us, Mara.”

“Light Hope says my training will be complete soon.” Mara stated. “Then I can properly fulfill my responsibility and protect Etheria from-”

“Hmmm…” Pyra had managed to swipe the sword from Mara's hand without the latter even noticing, and was now inspecting it curiously. “Wonder if *I* could become She-Ra? Let’s see…”

“What the- Hey!” Mara grumbled, slightly annoyed. “That’s mine!”

"Something something, Grayskull!" Pyra exclaimed, raising the sword into the air. "Nothing, huh? Hey Mara, how did that chant go again?"

"Give it back!" Mara tried to grab the sword from Pyra's hands, but Pyra managed to jump away from her. Glacia giggled as she watched her two friends playfully bickering.

"You're gonna have to *come and take it."* Pyra said cockily.

"Oh yeah?" Mara scooped up some snow from the ground and compressed it into a sphere, then threw the snowball at Pyra where it hit her squarely in the face. "Gotcha!"

"Owie!" Pyra groaned, while tossing the sword back to Mara. "Fine, here, take it!"

Mara grabbed the sword while it was still flying towards her, and afterwards all three of the princesses shared a hearty laugh.

"I'm so happy the three of us can still be friends." Glacia remarked. "Even with you being She-Ra and everything!"

"Of course!" Mara beamed, then sarcastically added: "Although I kinda feel like a third wheel at times, what with you two making out and being so sickeningly in love all the time."

“Oh, don’t be a sourpuss Mara!” Pyra slapped Mara on the back. “You’ve always got *your hologram girlfriend,* dontcha?”

“W-wha- No!” Mara stammered, her cheeks turning red. “L-Light Hope’s not my *girlfriend,* s-she’s just- Just a friend, thats all!”

“Suuuure she is.” Pyra victoriously crossed her arms. Glacia giggled as Mara’s cheeks turned more red by the second.

“Ahh.” Glacia sighed, feeling content. “Things are so great now. Etheria’s at peace, our kingdoms are prospering…”

“If only my people were doing so well.” Pyra blurted out, only realizing what she had said out loud when she saw how guilty Mara looked. “Ah heck, s-sorry! Didn’t mean it like that, I just-”

“I’m sorry, Pyra.” Mara sighed. “I know that what my administrators are doing has been really invasive and I wish I could tell ‘em to stop, but… They assured me it’s for the good of Etheria, that they’re just doing research. Nothing more.”

“I know, I know.” Pyra glanced aside. “But I still don’t like it. These lands, they’ve been sacred to us Magicats for eons, y’know?”

“Yeah.” Mara hung her head. "I know."

“So uh,” Glacia wanted to defuse the awkward situation and asked Pyra: “Are you going to be staying the night, honey?”

“Wish I could.” Pyra gave Glacia a slight smile. “But I have to head home to my kingdom. I haven’t seen Petra in a while, I wanna make sure she’s doing okay.”

“Alright.” Glacia gave Pyra a kiss. “I love you.”

“Love ya too, Glacia.”

“I have to get going as well.” Mara said. “I promised I’d have tea with Razz later. Hey uh,” She approached Pyra, looking a little unsure of herself. “Are… Are things still okay? Between us?”

“I…” Pyra had to think for a moment. “I don’t care for what your superiors are doing. But,” She gently pat Mara’s shoulder. “You’re still my best friend, no matter what.”

“Pyraaa!”

As soon as Pyra had made her way to Magicat Kingdom, she heard someone running towards her: A younger Magicat in her early twenties wearing a burgundy-colored robe. She had brown hair, freckles and a pair of mismatched eyes, with her left eye being blue and her right eye being yellow.

"Hey, Petra!" Pyra greeted the younger Magicat who had hugged her tight. "How's my favorite sister doing?"

"Your *only* sister." Petra corrected her with a snarky expression.

"How have things been around here?"

"Good, if a bit boring." Petra yawned. "I've pretty much just been holed up in the castle, waiting for you to show up. I've missed you, y'know!"

"Yeah, sorry about that." Pyra said apologetically. "I've missed ya a lot too, I've just… Been so busy being in love with Glacia that I hadn't found the time, and-"

"I'm just teasing you, ya dummy!" Petra giggled, punching her sister on the shoulder. "I'm happy for you, I'm glad you've managed to find such a reliable partner for yourself Pyra."

"She's so great." Pyra claimed, blushing a little while thinking of her fiancée, then ruffled Petra's hair. "And so are you. You and

Glacia… You two are the most important things in my life. And I’m never gonna let go of either of you, I promise.”

“Sappy.” Petra teased her with an affectionate smile. "Sooo... When's the wedding?"

"Uhh, we're still in the planning stages." Pyra admitted, scratching the back of her head. "But I actually had something I wanted to ask you about it."

"What is it?" Petra wondered.

"Well, I'm in need of a maid of honor." Pyra explained. "And I can't ask Mara because she's gonna be doing it for Glacia, so I was wondering if you, as my sister, would be willing to, well..."

"Y-you want **me?** To be *your* maid of honor?" Petra gasped, her eyes sparkling out of excitement. When Pyra nodded, she squealed with delight and hugged her older sister again. "Oh, thank you thank you *thank you* Pyra! I-I'd love to!"

"Then it's settled!" Pyra grinned. "Thanks sis, I knew I could count on ya. Hey, wanna see some cool new tricks I’ve learned?”

Petra gave her an enthusiastic nod. Pyra began showing off her magical powers, shooting fire out of her hands and morphing them into various shapes, twirling them around midair and

eventually forming a large circle that she interlocked with another circle before dissipating both flames.

"Woooo!" Petra cheered and applauded her sister. "So cool!"

Pyra bowed, satisfied with her display, then noticed that all of a sudden Petra was pouting.

"Hey, what's wrong sis?"

"Nothing, just… Jealous." Petra muttered begrudgingly. "I wish I could do all that stuff, but the Sunstone chose you and-"

"Hey hey, it's okay kid." Pyra walked up to Petra, placing her hand on her shoulder. "One day, you'll get to have these powers too! I promise."

"Maybe." Petra mumbled, still feeling somewhat inadequate compared to Pyra.

"C'mon, you shouldn't pout like that." Pyra chuckled. "It's unbecoming of a princess!"

"Look who's talking." Petra fired back, cheering up a little. "*That haircut* is unbecoming of a princess, if ya ask me!"

“Ohh, why you little-” Pyra held Petra’s head in a lock and gave her a noogie. The two Magicat sisters laughed, when suddenly-

“P-Princess Pyra! Princess Petra!”

A Magicat soldier holding a polearm was frantically approaching Pyra and Petra, giving them a salute once he caught up with them.

“At ease, soldier.” Pyra said. “What’s up?”

“T-there’s been… Y-you have to see it for yourself! It’s an emergency!” The soldier explained.

“An emergency?” Petra gasped. She and Pyra shared worried glances, then followed the soldier off to the coast of Magicat Kingdom.

“What’s going on-” Pyra started, then stopped dead in her tracks when she saw *it.*

A large, drill-like structure had been installed on the shore. It was whirring loudly, digging into the ground beneath.

“W-what *is* that thing?” Petra asked, stunned.

“We don’t know.” The soldier shook his head. “These drills, they began popping up here a week or so ago. We have no idea what they are or who built them-”

“Wait.” Pyra launched a massive fireball towards the drill, blowing it to smithereens. Petra yelped and her tail puffed up from the sound of the drill exploding, then Pyra inspected the debris. Among the remains she found a metallic panel that had foreign writing engraved on it. “Just as I suspected.”

“I-is that-?” Petra gasped.

“First Ones’ writing.” Pyra said quietly.

“N-no…” Petra whispered. "I-it can't be! They promised..."

“...This is going too far!”

Pyra was furiously pacing back and forth inside Mara’s ship, confronting Mara and Light Hope about the drills the First Ones had installed.

“Pyra, I-I swear I didn’t know about this!” Mara stated. “I had no idea my people were drilling into Magicat Kingdom, I’m just as shocked as you are!”

“Princess Pyra, please contain yourself-” Light Hope started.

“We had a deal!” Pyra shouted at Light Hope. “We allowed you lot to do your *‘research’* on the rest of Etheria, on the condition that you leave our island alone! You’ve violated the terms!”

“Pyra-” Mara reached out to her, but Pyra angrily slapped her arm away.

“The First Ones must leave.” Pyra said, glaring at Light Hope. “Take your drills away from Magicat Kingdom. *Or else.”*

“I am a program.” Light Hope sighed. “My administrators hold all of the power, they make the decisions. I am unable to assist you in this matter. I’m sorry.”

“So that’s it, huh?!” Pyra lashed out. “Your people have already desecrated our sacred lands, now you’re defiling *my* kingdom and I’m supposed to just twiddle my thumbs and do ***NOTHING ABOUT IT?!****”*

“Princess Pyra, I assure you, this is for the good of Etheria.” Light Hope tried calming her down. “We are only doing this to protect everyone, including the Magicats. You-”

“SHUT UP!” Pyra angrily tossed a fireball at Light Hope’s face, but it harmlessly phased through her and hit the ship’s wall behind her. “Don’t you give me any of that *bullsh-”*

“Pyra, stop!” Mara begged. “Light Hope’s my friend, she would **never** lie about something like this!”

“So you’re just gonna believe what *a machine* says, huh?” Pyra asked, her voice dripping with disdain.

“Everything will become clear soon.” Light Hope stated. “I can promise you that.”

Pyra scoffed, giving Light Hope an ultimatum: “Those drills are coming down. *Or I’m taking them down myself.”*

She then stormed out of the ship, Mara following after her.

“Pyra, I’m really sorry about this.” Mara apologized to her friend. “Listen-”

“Mara. Please.” Pyra begged her. “Help me. Help me take down the drills. You’re *She-Ra,* I-I know you can do it!”

“I…” Mara sighed. “I want to, Pyra, I really do. But, my people, they told me that-”

“I knew it.” Pyra hissed. “Fine. If you’re not gonna help me, I know Glacia will.”

“Pyra, listen to me!” Mara grabbed her arm. “I-I’ll try talking with Light Hope, see if there’s any way we could convince my superiors to stop this! I, I don’t like what they've been doing, either.”

“...Whatever.” Pyra mumbled. She wrenched her arm out of Mara’s grasp and then walked away.

Mara felt horrible seeing Pyra this angry and distressed. She wanted to help her. Mara sighed, then returned to her ship to see Light Hope.

“I’m sorry, Mara.” Light Hope apologized when she saw Mara coming back. “I know you and Princess Pyra are close-”

“Hope.” Mara whispered. “Please, tell me what’s going on. I know that you know. What are my administrators doing to the Magicats' home?”

“I…” Light Hope hesitated, looking extremely uncomfortable.

“Please, Hope!” Mara begged her. “Pyra’s my friend, just like you are. If there’s any way I can possibly help her… I wanna know.”

Light Hope remained silent. For a second it appeared as if she had glitched, before she finally relented and spoke gravely to Mara:

“Magicat Kingdom is going to be destroyed.”

“W-what?” Mara gasped out of shock. “Destroyed?”

“We have been analyzing their land.” Light Hope stated. Her voice sounded ever so slightly off to Mara, but she didn’t question it. “A great cataclysm is going to befall their kingdom. At this point… I fear it is too late to stop it.”

Mara’s shock soon turned to determination as she held onto the Sword of Protection.

“I, I have to go.” She stated. “The Magicats need to be evacuated!”

“Mara-”

“I-I’m She-Ra! It’s my duty to protect Etheria, all of Etheria, and that includes the Magicats! *I have to save them!”*

“Mara, wait!” Light Hope yelled, but Mara had already turned on the ship’s engine, setting course towards Magicat Kingdom.

“...I just can’t believe they’re doing this.”

Meanwhile, Pyra was in the Kingdom of Snows pouring her heart out to Glacia, who was gently holding her hand.

“Mara’s people are *defiling* my home,” Pyra muttered bitterly. “And I can’t do anything to stop it.”

“It’s gonna be alright, darling.” Glacia said, placing a kiss on Pyra’s cheek. When Pyra remained unconvinced she asked her: “Listen, what if Mara and Light Hope are right?”

“Don’t you start, too.” Pyra glared at her.

"I'm just saying, what if they really are just looking out for your people? Protecting Etheria? Those people have a lot of higher knowledge, it's entirely possible that the drills are just-"

"I don't buy it." Pyra said. "They, they look too suspicious. Everything those people have done since they've arrived here has given me the creeps."

"I know." Glacia sighed. "And I understand why you're so *heated,* but Mara is your friend, we both know that. You should really try to *cool down* a little, Pyra."

"Temperature puns? *Really?"* Pyra chuckled, managing to smile again. She sighed and then admitted to Glacia: "...Maybe you're right. Mara, she's never lied to me before. But, I still don't know."

"Listen, how about you stay the night here?" Glacia suggested. "Things will seem clearer after a good night's sleep. And maybe," She blushed and whispered seductively: *"We could do something else as well."*

"Oh?" Pyra's own cheeks turned lightly red as well. She carefully stroke Glacia's hair and said: "Sure, t-that sounds like a good idea."

"When I have ever had bad ideas?" Glacia snarked. Pyra laughed, then passionately kissed her fiancée.

“I love you so much.”

“I love you too, *Princess Pyra.”*

The next day, feeling much more refreshed, Pyra decided to head back to Magicat Kingdom. She wanted to talk with Petra about the drills and what to do with them. Overnight, she had come to the conclusion that Glacia was most likely right about Mara and Light Hope, that they had been telling the truth and it was all going to be just-

“W-WHAT?!”

Pyra’s pupils dilated and she froze in utter fear when she reached her homeland.

Magicat Kingdom had been completely *decimated.* All of the buildings, including the castle, had been leveled, reduced to nothing more than rubble. There were bodies of dead Magicats everywhere, their blood staining the ground.

“No…” Pyra gasped. She fell to her knees, barely able to breathe as she observed the carnage surrounding her. “Nonono, no, t-this, this can’t be… This isn’t real, t-this is-”

"Py… Ra..?"

Pyra heard a weak, faint voice calling for her. She looked to her left and saw-

"Petra!" Pyra cried as she saw her sister gravely injured under some rubble, barely clinging onto consciousness. "Petra, a-are you- AHH" She rushed up to Petra, looked down and noticed that Petra's left arm was completely missing from the elbow down, with only a bleeding stump where her forearm should have been.

"Y-you… Came…" Petra mumbled.

"D-don't die on me, Petra! Hang on, I've gotta-" Pyra conjured a ball of flame in her right hand, then steeled her nerves while looking at Petra's missing left arm. She had no other choice; Her sister would bleed out otherwise. "This… This is gonna hurt a little, okay?"

"W-what are you-"

Pyra used the ball of fire to cauterize Petra's arm in order to stop the bleeding. Petra screamed out in agony, almost passing out from the pain while Pyra frantically apologized to her.

"Petra," Pyra eventually asked her, in tears. "Petra, w-what… *What happened?* W-who did this?"

“I-I…” Petra hesitated with great fear in her eyes. Tears running down her face and just before losing consciousness, she whispered to Pyra:

“S… She… Ra… She-Ra.”

“You guys find anything yet?”

Bow, Glimmer, Adora and Frosta had been staying in the library of Frosta’s castle, combing through dozens if not hundreds of books. They had been searching for a long while now, seeing if they could find any information about Glacia, but so far the group had no success.

“Ugh, this is *hopeless!”* Glimmer whined. “At this rate it’s gonna take us **months** until we find anything!”

“I had no idea there were this many books here.” Bow said to Frosta, sounding impressed. "It almost rivals my dads' library!"

“Yeah, me neither.” Frosta shrugged. “I uh, was never much into reading anything other than comic books so I’ve never gone

through all these. But I swear I've seen the name 'Glacia' *somewhere* before… I just can't remember where!"

"You having any luck, Adora?" Glimmer asked. She noticed how distracted and spaced out Adora was and carefully nudged her: "Adora?"

"What?" Adora muttered. "O-oh, right. Sorry. Kinda zoned out for a second there."

"I know you've got a lot on your mind," Glimmer said gently. "But try to focus, okay?"

"Yeah, I-I'll try." Adora sighed. She had been completely lost in her thoughts about Catra: Where she was, how she was doing… If she missed Adora. *If she wanted to come back.*

"Man, I almost wish Light Hope was here."

"Light Hope?" Glimmer wondered.

"Yeah. She probably knew about Pyra, and what happened to the Magicats." Adora said, before bitterly adding: "Not that she ever bothered giving *me* any information…"

Adora thumbed through the book in front of her, which detailed population growth in the Kingdom of Snows, marriages and births of children. Feeling uneasy she closed the book and put it away, but her mind had already started wandering again.

Adora held her hand over her stomach, thinking about her baby. What she would do in the event that Catra never comes back. Would she still be capable of raising it on her own? Could she handle being a single mother, even with Bow and Glimmer supporting her? Or should she give it up for adoption, so it can grow up in a loving home with both parents?

No. Adora was going to raise this child, no matter what. What had happened with Catra, how her mother had given her away as a baby… Adora knew that Catra wouldn't want her own child to have the same fate as her.

Adora sighed and grabbed another book off the table, opening it to a random page. It was detailing events from centuries ago, and on the next page she read a paragraph and spotted-

"Hey, this one's about Glacia!" She hollered. Bow, Glimmer and Frosta all gathered around Adora, excited to have found something.

"Finally!" Glimmer cheered. "What does it say?"

“Let’s see…” Adora began reading the passage out loud. “Glacia, the Ice Queen, was a cold and ruthless ruler who led the Kingdom of Snows through some tough times a thousand years ago. Most people who came across her thought that her heart had been frozen, due to how cruel and emotionless she could be to her subjects and enemies alike-”

“Whoa, sounds like your ancestor was quite the character.” Glimmer remarked to Frosta, who looked uneasy.

“Her contemporaries have alleged that Queen Glacia had not always been like this, that she used to be warm, loving and kind, but that something in her had changed slightly before the birth of her only daughter, Lumira. She was never the same since.” Adora continued. She paused for a moment, thinking of her own child and if its birth would cause her to change in similar ways.

“Is there any mention of Pyra or the Magicats?” Bow asked.

“Not by name, at least.” Adora squinted. “But wait, there’s something about a *‘Raging Inferno’* that threatened to burn down all of Etheria. It was said that Glacia had worked together with *Mara, She-Ra of Etheria,* and it was thanks to the two's efforts that the fire was quelled and the planet was saved!”

“A raging inferno, huh?” Glimmer stroke her chin. “You think that was Pyra?”

“The timeline would check out.” Adora muttered. “So Glacia knew Mara too…”

“Wait, there’s mention here of something called ‘the Sunstone.’” Bow pointed to a sentence in the next paragraph. “Wonder what that is?”

“I can tell you.” A familiar voice said.

Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta all turned their heads; Adora was both shocked and extremely elated to see who the speaker was.

“C-Catra!”

“Hey, Adora.” Catra was standing in the doorway, playfully waving her hand. “Didn’t think you’d see me again?”

“Wait, how did you get past my guards?” Frosta scratched her head. “They should’ve alerted me if I had visitors!”

“Oh it was *easy,* you really oughta pay 'em more!” Catra chuckled. “Seems they’re not motivated enough to do their job- Whoa!”

Adora had rushed to Catra with a huge grin on her face and tears in her eyes, and hugged Catra so tight she nearly tackled her to

the floor.

"Catra, I-I'm so sorry! About everything!" Adora profusely apologized to her. "I missed you so much! I-I thought I'd lost you forever, I-"

"Hey hey, it's okay Adora." Catra gently smiled at her. "Did you seriously think I could stay away from you, after everything we've been through together?"

"Catra…" Adora whispered. She couldn't believe that Catra had actually come back to her. "Can, can you ever forgive me for what I said? During the argument? It was so awful of me, I-"

"It's alright." Catra stroke Adora's cheek. "Everything's good now."

"It's good to have you back, Horde Scum." Glimmer crossed her arms. "See Adora, I told you things would work out in the end!"

"What made you change your mind, Catra?" Bow wondered.

"I uh-"

"Catra listen," Adora held Catra's hands and smiled. "I have something big to tell you. I'm pr-"

“No time for chitchat.” Catra interrupted her, looking serious. “We’ve got bigger fish to fry. I figured out what Pyra is planning!”

“Y-you did?” Adora asked her.

“You were right about her, Adora. She really *is* bad news.”

“What is she up to?” Glimmer stared inquisitively at Catra, as did Bow and Frosta, wanting to hear the answer.

“Pyra is looking for the Sunstone. Her runestone. She’s the Fire Princess.” Catra explained. “She lost her powers when she got frozen and she’s trying to get them back. She… *She plans to take control over Etheria.”*

“I *knew* she was up to something shady!” Adora grumbled.

“How do we stop her?” Frosta asked.

“She doesn’t know where the Sunstone is.” Catra smirked. “It’s been moved somewhere during the time she’s been on ice. That’s our advantage.”

"Let's see…" Bow took the book Adora had read earlier and followed up on the mention of the Sunstone. "According to this, the Sunstone was the catalyst for the Raging Inferno, and to prevent it from endangering Etheria ever again Mara and Glacia had it moved to a safe location."

"Does it say where?" Adora asked.

"Something called the Brimstone Cave." Bow kept reading. "Which is located in… *The Crimson Waste!"*

"So then, that means…" Adora realized. "If we can find the stone before Pyra, we can try to destroy it and prevent her from ever using it again!"

"Great!" Glimmer raised her fist. "We've got a plan! We should head to the Waste as soon as possible."

"I'll come with you!" Frosta said. "This kinda feels like my responsibility, with the Glacia of it all."

"Of course." Adora nodded. "Catra, are you- Hey, where are you going?" She noticed that Catra had turned around and was getting ready to leave.

"I need to go back to Pyra." Catra explained. "She's gonna get suspicious if I'm gone for too long. Plus, I can come up with

something to throw her off our trail!”

“Good thinking.” Bow said, but Adora looked hesitant.

“Catra wait, I have to tell you that I’m-” Adora started.

“I’ll meet you at the Crimson Waste!” Catra waved them goodbye.

“Catra! *Wait!”* Adora yelled, but Catra had already ran off. Adora sighed deep. “Ugh, I *hate* it when she does that.”

“Catra is as Catra does, I suppose.” Glimmer shrugged. “At least you’re on speaking terms again!”

“Yeah.” Adora muttered. “I just… *Really* wanted to tell her about the baby, y’know?”

“You can still tell her!” Glimmer cheered her up. “But, Catra has a point. We should focus on making sure Pyra can’t get the Sunstone, you can tell Catra about your pregnancy after we’ve stopped Pyra once and for all!”

“I guess.” Adora nodded. But something about Catra’s behavior seemed ever so slightly *off* to her.

Bow took out his tracker pad and said: “I’m gonna contact Huntara. We don’t know *where* exactly the Brimstone Cave is, we need a guide.”

“Probably for the best.” Glimmer agreed. "Ugh, I thought I'd never have to set foot into that place again..."

Adora looked out the library window, seeing Catra in the distance leaving Frosta’s castle and making her way out of the Kingdom of Snows.

What Adora couldn’t see, however, was the positively *devious* grin Catra had on her face as she gave one last quick glance behind her to make sure nobody was around, before pulling out her own tracker pad. Catra turned it on and whispered to herself:

*“Aaaand… **Scene.”***

Chapter End Notes

> When a couple gets engaged/married on Etheria, instead of exchanging rings they typically exchange an accessory that belonged to the other person, such as Spinnerella and Netossa having swapped their chokers, so the necklace is what Pyra got from Glacia and the obsidian bracelet is what Glacia got from Pyra.
>
> 'Petra' doubles as both just a regular name and also following Catra's naming scheme, just replacing "cat" with "pet".

Meanwhile, 'Lumira' is named after the Finnish word for snow, "lumi".

Chapter 7: Reunions

Chapter Summary

Micah tracks down Catra and Pyra's campsite and tries to convince Catra to come back to Bright Moon and talk with Adora. The next day, the Best Friend Squad and Frosta meet up with Huntara and begin their journey through the Crimson Waste to find the Sunstone. In the past, an enraged Pyra is trying to find Mara, while Mara is seeking comfort from Glacia and telling her what had happened to Magicat Kingdom.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pyra made her way towards the First Ones' settlement near Mara's ship, her fists clenched and fury in her eyes. It was difficult for her to contain her emotions, she wanted nothing more than to just explode in a fiery rage.

"Hm? Halt!" One of the First Ones spotted Pyra approaching the settlement and held out their halberd. "You have no clearance to be in this sector, Magicat- AAAHHH!!"

Pyra tossed a large fireball at the First One, incinerating them instantly. The other First Ones were horrified by this display and began panicking.

"Quick, sound the alarm! The Magicat princess has gone berserk!"

Some of the First Ones retreated, others attempted to fight back by firing arrows and bolts at Pyra. Pyra was laying waste to the entire settlement, launching fireballs and burning down anything and everything she saw on her way.

These *animals…* Pyra was going to make them pay for what they had done to her kingdom. *Her people.*

Completely overtaken by her anger and need for revenge, Pyra bellowed out:

*"**WHERE IS MARA?!**"*

"So, this plan of yours… Think it'll work?"

Pyra was crouched down with her legs crossed in front of her tent, rolling up smoke bombs with her hands as she observed Catra, who was sitting on a rock holding her tracker pad.

"It already has. They took the bait." Catra replied victoriously, putting the pad away and walking up to Pyra. "Man, I'd almost forgotten how *easy* it is to trick these guys! Now we just have to wait until tomorrow."

“And this friend of yours?” Pyra asked. “Can they be trusted?”

“Oh, I’ve worked with them before.” Catra said while checking her claws. “They’re a doublecrossing backstabber who has no morals and is willing to work for *anyone* as long as you pay ‘em well!”

“Well, they sound like a completely upstanding citizen.” Pyra remarked sarcastically.

“Trust me, Pyra.” Catra chuckled. “When it comes to scheming, they are absolutely *invaluable.* You’re gonna get your hands on the Sunstone tomorrow!”

Pyra pondered for a moment, then smiled at Catra and said: “You definitely are a Magicat, through and through. Okay, if you say we can trust ‘em then I will. I have full faith in your judgment, kid.”

“T-thanks.” Catra muttered, her cheeks turning lightly red as she smiled back at Pyra. “I uh, I don't... *Like* deceiving my friends this way, but it’s been kinda fun. Working with you.”

“Aww, likewise! It’s been… Very nostalgic.”

“Huh?”

“Petra and I,” Pyra started. “We used to get up to *so much mischief* when we were growing up. All the tricks we’d pull, all the pranks we planned… We were total brats, and we had so much fun!”

“That uh, sounds familiar.” Catra admitted. “Adora and I were like that too, back when we were kids at the Horde. I managed to get her, both of us, into a ton of trouble!”

“Heh, seems to be the Magicat way.” Pyra joked, causing Catra to giggle in a way that sounded all too familiar to the princess. “You remind me so much of Petra, y’know? Even your laughs are the same!”

“R-really?” Catra wondered. “I, I really wish I could’ve met her. You’re always speaking so fondly of her.”

“You’re about a thousand years too late, I’m afraid.” Pyra snarked, before warmly adding: “Petra, she… She was the best sister I could’ve possibly had, she and Glacia were the two most important things in my life. But then Glacia betrayed me, and Petra-”

Pyra paused, looking very somber before telling Catra:

“Family matters most. I want you to remember that, Catra.”

“Huh?” Catra stared at her, unsure what she meant.

“Friends, love… Those come and go. They’re replaceable, *disposable.”* Pyra stated, determination in her eyes. “But family? *Family’s forever.* Ya gotta hold onto it, no matter what.”

“R-right.” Catra mumbled. “Not that I *have* any family, aside from my mom who I don’t even know where she is. Let alone if she’s *alive…”*

“What’re you talking about?” Pyra raised an eyebrow, before gently punching Catra’s shoulder and winking at her. “Far as I’m considering you’re *my* family, kid.”

“Eh? What do you-”

It took a second for Pyra’s words to truly set in for Catra. Once they did, Catra was stunned; She had no idea Pyra considered the two of them to be so close. And while she hadn’t known Pyra for longer than a couple days, Catra couldn’t deny she had gotten increasingly attached to her. Something about being with another Magicat, it was oddly comforting to Catra. Almost as if it had unlocked some sort of subconscious, primordial memories within her.

Maybe, even if she never ends up finding her family… Things would be okay. Pyra was here, and she was looking out for Catra. Just like Catra would look out for her.

“Pyra, I-”

“Catra?”

Catra and Pyra were startled by the sudden appearance of a familiar figure. Catra couldn’t believe her eyes.

“M… *Micah?”*

King Micah was standing several feet away, waving and gently smiling at Catra. Pyra, however, immediately jumped up on her feet and raised her claws, ready to fight.

“Who are you?!” Pyra hissed. “And what are you doing here?! Get lost, before I’ll-”

“Pyra, it’s okay.” Catra assured her. “He’s… *He’s a friend.”*

“Really?” Pyra asked, then backed down and lowered her guard while still glaring at Micah.

“I promise, I come in peace.” Micah said calmly, raising his hands.

“What do you want?” Catra wondered.

“I came to see how you’re doing.” Micah stated, then asked Catra: “Can I speak with you for a moment?”

Catra opened her mouth, but Pyra placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder in a protective way and stared Micah down.

“Whatever you’re gonna say to her,” The look in Pyra’s eyes was fierce. “You can say it in my presence. I-”

“It’s fine.” Catra said. “I’ll handle this, you can go wait inside.”

“You sure?” Pyra double checked. When Catra nodded she relented and took a step back, pointed at her eyes with her index and middle finger and then pointed them towards Micah to signify she’s watching him. “If you try anything…”

“I’m only here to talk.” Micah crossed his arms, completely unphased by Pyra’s threats. Pyra sneered at him, then retreated into the tent leaving only Catra and Micah standing there. Micah turned to Catra and said: “She seems to have taken a liking to you-”

“How did you find me?” Catra immediately questioned him.

“Location spell.” Micah explained. “First thing they teach you in Mystacor. Plus, no offense but these woods are a pretty poor hiding place from me to begin with. I holed up here for weeks during Horde Prime’s invasion, I know this place like the back of my hand.”

“Hmph.” Catra grumbled, then asked: “Did anyone follow you?”

“Just one.” Micah snapped his fingers, and Melog made itself visible next to him. It ran up to Catra and happily meowed at her.

“Hey, buddy!” Catra said to Melog, elated to see her companion again, and affectionately pet its head.

“As soon as it saw what I was doing, Melog wanted to come with me. I think it missed you.” Micah claimed. “And I figured you didn’t want to be found, so it’s cloaking capabilities also came in handy to make sure I wasn’t followed.”

“Right.” Catra muttered, secretly thankful that Micah had brought Melog with him. “Why did you come here, Micah?”

“I…” Micah sighed deep. “Catra, please come home. There’s people who need you right now.”

“Adora sent you, didn’t she?” Catra scoffed. “Didn’t have the guts to face me herself, so she sent you to do the dirty work-”

“I came here out of my own accord, Adora actively asked me not to talk to you.” Micah stated. “Specifically because she knew you’d react this way.”

“O-oh.” Catra mumbled, feeling embarrassed for having assumed things. *“Good.”*

“Is it?”

“What’s ***that*** supposed to mean?!”

“Catra, I can see it on your face!” Micah gestured at her. “I can tell how much you miss Adora, just like she misses you. And… She’s not the only one who does so.”

“I-” Catra hesitated, still stroking Melog. Its purring helped calm her nerves. “I do, I do miss her. A-and I still love her, but… I can’t go back.” She shook her head. “Adora, she doesn’t trust me. And I can’t even blame her for that, I’ve messed up too many times, I-I’ve hurt her too much, all my life... It’s too late for me, for *us.”*

“It’s never too late. Catra,” Micah walked up to Catra and carefully grabbed her shoulders. “You should try to talk things through with Adora. *Please.* I, I know what it’s like, to lose the one person in

the world that you love more than anything. And I can't stop thinking that, if I had done things differently… Would Angie still be here?"

"M-Micah…" Catra could feel the sting of guilt over her having opened the portal, once again.

"I'll never get to have that chance. To see her again." Micah said sadly. "But you do. You haven't completely lost Adora, she still loves you and I know she's more than willing to take you back and make amends. But only if you talk to her. You two still have a chance to make things right, I don't want you to throw that away."

"I'm…" Catra muttered. She knew that Micah had a point, and deep down she did want to go back, talk with Adora. See if they could still make things work. But, she couldn't. "I-I need to do this, Micah. I *have* to do this. You know that."

"I do." Micah nodded. "I know how much finding your family matters to you, you spent so long looking for your mother ever since you found her letter. And I just want you to know, I'm fully willing to do everything I can to help you find her, if you want me to. If you come home."

Catra felt so torn, thinking of Micah's words. She knew how much Micah cared for her, and over the years of knowing him she'd come to really look up to him as a parental figure. Catra knew that Micah meant every word he said, that he was willing to help her if she just asked.

But Catra shifted her gaze to the tent behind her. She had already promised to help Pyra out. She couldn't go back on that promise. And while Catra knew that both Micah and Pyra cared for her and looked out for her, there was one crucial difference in her mind:

Pyra was a Magicat. She was the closest lead Catra had to finding her people. And Micah, while he had treated Catra with so much kindness and understanding…

"You... You're not my dad, Micah." Catra muttered, with a hint of an apologetic tone to her voice. She couldn't bear to look Micah in the eye anymore.

"Yeah. I know." Micah stepped back, unable to fully conceal the hurt on his face. Melog meowed sadly at Catra, then walked back up to Micah as the sorcerer turned around and got ready to leave. "I must be going now, otherwise Glimmer might start wondering where I've been. And I don't want to blow your cover."

"R-right."

"It was good to see you, Catra. And to see that you're holding up well, considering the circumstances."

"Mm-hmm."

“And, for what it’s worth,” Micah shot a really bright smile towards Catra right as Melog was about to cloak him. “You’ve always been like a daughter to me.”

Catra gasped, her pupils narrowing.

“Micah-” By the time Catra tried to look for him again, Micah had already disappeared with Melog. Catra was left standing outside the tent trembling, with her breathing being rapid and shaky. She was so overwhelmed by so many mixed feelings and thoughts, she didn't know what to do anymore. What to *think.*

“Catra?” Just then, Pyra walked out of the tent. As soon as she saw how on edge Catra was, she immediately hugged her tight. Catra hugged her back, doing her best to hold back her tears as Pyra whispered to her: “Hey, it’s okay. I’ve got you.”

Once the two Magicats let go of one another, Catra sniffled and said:

“We… *We’ve got a lot of work to do tomorrow.”*

The next day, Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta had gathered by the edge of the Crimson Waste, getting ready to find the Sunstone. The scorching heat, the arid desert air, the massive

dunes of sand everywhere… It was oddly nostalgic for Adora in a way, as she thought back to the time they had been here searching for Mara's ship.

"The Waste is just as much of an oven as I remembered it being." Glimmer stated, taking a swig out of her water bottle.

Frosta, however, was less than enthused. If the other three were feeling sweaty already, Frosta was on the verge of collapsing from heatstroke underneath her parka.

"So… Hot…" Frosta panted with her tongue out. "Perfuma was right, t-this place is awful! Feels like I'm being *cooked* here."

"That's what deserts are like, Frosta." Bow said, slightly amused. "Guess you're more used to the colder climate in the Kingdom of Snows."

"First thing I'm doing when I get back home: Hop in the freezer and don't come out *for a week!"* Frosta groaned.

"Why aren't you using your powers?" Glimmer wondered. "You have control over ice, you should be able to keep yourself cool no problem!"

"Air's too dry, can't get enough moisture out of it to make any ice." Frosta sighed, then demonstrated by using her powers and

managing to only generate one ice cube in the palm of her hand. "This is pretty much all I can do right now." She rubbed the ice cube all over her face, attempting to cool down as much as possible before the heat of the Waste would melt it down.

"Just try to hang on." Glimmer pat Frosta on the back. "We've still got a long trek through the desert ahead of us."

"Speaking of, why do we gotta *walk?*" Frosta asked. "Couldn't you just teleport us to the cave?"

"I've never been to or even seen the cave before, so teleporting there wouldn't really work." Glimmer admitted. "And blindly teleporting around the Crimson Waste trying to find it… Wouldn't exactly be the smartest idea, there's sandstorms and sandsnakes and sand-"

"Which is why we need a guide." Bow stated. "Plus, no harm in getting some extra exercise, right Frosta?"

"I-I guess." Frosta mumbled.

"Where *is* Huntara?" Adora was pacing back and forth with her arms crossed, waiting impatiently. "She should've been here by now. What's taking her so long?"

"I dunno." Bow shrugged. "Maybe she got held up by something?"

“No sign of Catra, either.” Adora muttered. “I really hope she’s okay…”

“I’m sure she’s fine, she’s just making sure Pyra won’t follow her.” Glimmer cheered Adora up. “But Huntara really should get here soon, we’ll never find our way to the Brimstone Cave without her!”

Bow pulled out his tracker pad and said: “I’m gonna try to give her a call, see what’s up-”

“No need, I’m already here.”

Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta saw a familiar, muscular woman with purple skin and pointy ears walking up to them.

“Huntara!” Adora greeted the woman, offering her hand. “Long time no see!”

“It’s been a while, Blondie.” Huntara said, shaking hands with Adora. “Almost thought you’d forgotten about old Huntara!”

“Yeah, sorry about that.” Adora awkwardly scratched the back of her head. “I-I’ve been meaning to pop in for a visit, but uh… Better late than never, I guess?”

“Well said.” Huntara chuckled. “Sorry I’m late, was preoccupied. Had a bar fight I needed to settle.”

“A bar fight?”

“Yeah, Tung Lashor was mouthing off and I had to put him in his place, then things escalated from there and I also had to pay for damages done to the bar, it’s a long story. But, I’m glad to see you’re doing well!” Huntara then waved at Bow and Glimmer: “Glad to see you guys too, Boy and Glitter!”

“Bow and Glimmer.” Glimmer corrected her.

“And uh,” Huntara stared at Frosta with a curious expression, one eyebrow raised. “Don’t think we've been introduced before, squirt.”

“‘Squirt?’ I’m *seventeen and three quarters,* thank you very much!” Frosta crossed her arms, giving Huntara an annoyed glare.

“That’s younger than I was when I first met you!” Glimmer teased Frosta. “And you’re still a full head shorter than me.”

“Hrrmmph…” Frosta pouted, her cheeks turning red.

“So, you know the way to the Brimstone Cave, Huntara?” Bow asked.

“I do.” Huntara stared off into the distance. “It’s quite the trek away, on the other end of the Crimson Waste. The journey there is treacherous already, and the cave itself… Let’s just say, not many are crazy enough to wander there. It’s a dangerous place.”

Bow and Glimmer both gave Adora concerned looks.

“What?” Adora wondered.

“Uhh, m-maybe you should sit this one out, Adora?” Glimmer suggested.

“*What?* No way!” Adora argued. “This is important, we need to find the Sunstone! I’m not going back home when I already came all the way here.”

“But it’s a dangerous mission, are you sure you wanna put the baby at risk-”

“I’m *fine.”* Adora insisted. “I’ve got She-Ra, she’s all the protection I need. Entrapta said that as long as I avoid getting any direct blows to the stomach while transformed, it’ll be safe.”

“Waitwaitwait, you’re *preggers* Blondie?” Huntara asked, dumbfounded. “Okay your friends are right, the Brimstone Cave is no place to bring a kid!”

“I said *I’m fine!”* Adora yelled, exasperated. “I know what I’m doing, I just- We need to find the Sunstone. We have to stop Pyra, so Catra and I can go back to… The way we were.” She sighed.

“...Alright.” Huntara relented. “Your body, your choice, I suppose.”

“Thank you.” Adora muttered, grateful that Huntara wasn’t trying to argue further or stop her from doing what she needed to do.

“So, you guys ready to get going?” Huntara asked the group.

“Oh, we’re still waiting for one.” Bow replied. “She should be here any second now…”

“Over here!” The group heard a voice from the dune near them, turned around and saw Catra standing on top of it, waving at the group.

“Catra!” Adora exclaimed happily. “Finally!”

“Sorry about that.” Catra slid down from the dune and walked up to the others. “Took me a while to shake Pyra off my trail. Had to point her in the wrong direction.”

“All good.” Glimmer said, then asked: “What did you tell her?”

“That the Sunstone’s been moved to the bottom of Salineas.” Catra smirked. “She’s gonna be busy for a while, figuring out how to drain an entire ocean-”

Catra was cut off by Adora walking up to her and kissing her out of the blue. Catra’s cheeks turned red as Adora pulled back.

“H-hey, Adora.”

“I’m so glad you’re here.” Adora smiled lovingly at Catra. “I was worried you weren’t gonna show up!”

“Of course, I’m done running now.” Catra held Adora’s hand. “I won’t be going anywhere anymore, I promise.”

“Catra,” Adora started. She was getting ready to do this. “There’s something I’ve been meaning to tell you, something big. I’m-”

"We should get going." Catra stated, once again interrupting Adora before she could get the chance to tell her the news. "We've got a long journey ahead of us, and Pyra's gonna figure out sooner or later that I lied to her."

"B-but-"

"Catra's right." Bow agreed. "Getting to the Sunstone is our biggest priority right now."

"Let's get going, while there's still daylight to burn." Huntara said.

"B-but, but… Urrgh!" Adora groaned, frustrated that she still hadn't been able to tell Catra about the pregnancy.

"You guys go on without me…" Frosta whined, having fallen on her back on the sand. "I'm just gonna lay down here and **die.**"

"Frosta, c'mon-" Glimmer sighed, trying to help Frosta off the ground.

"Ahh, let her sulk." Huntara said dismissively. "If *Shorty* here doesn't wanna come, that's fine by me. She'd just slow us down."

"...'Shorty?!'" Frosta jumped up, looking positively incensed. "Ohh, I'm gonna show **you** who's *slow,* you big old ogre! I'm gonna make it to the Brimstone Cave *before* you!"

"That's the spirit." Huntara grinned, amused by Frosta's sudden change in attitude. "But you're gonna want to stay behind me, you don't wanna end up walking into quicksand do you?"

"Q-quicksand?" Frosta gulped.

"Welcome to the Crimson Waste, Frosta." Glimmer chuckled. Then, she heard a strange noise and paused. "Hmm?"

"What's up?" Bow wondered.

"I just…" Glimmer held her hand behind her ear, trying to listen. "I could've sworn I heard something *beep* just now."

"Beep? Oh, that must've been my tracker pad." Bow said, inspecting his pad. "It was on pretty low charge when we left Bright Moon. I hope it has enough battery to last the trip…"

"Let's get going, you guys!" Catra impatiently tapped her foot on the ground. "The sooner we get the Sunstone, the sooner we can also get outta here!"

“Hmm, your girlfriend’s in quite the hurry, huh?” Huntara teased Adora. “Alright. Follow my lead!”

“Yeah. She is…” Adora mumbled.

She didn’t know why. But she couldn’t shake the feeling from yesterday that something was… *Off* about Catra. How antsy and distant she seemed, how she didn't want to hear what Adora had to say.

Adora shook her head. She’s just being paranoid, that’s all. But still, something about this mission didn’t sit quite right with her.

Following Huntara’s lead, the group began making their long journey through the Crimson Waste. Towards the Sunstone.

“Ghaah… Haah… Ngh…”

Pyra was limping towards the Kingdom of Snows, exhausted and having sustained several injuries. She had razed the First Ones’ settlement to the ground, but they had brought backup and Pyra had barely been able to escape with her life. Pyra was holding her left shoulder, staring at the ice castle in the distance.

“G-Glacia…” Pyra mumbled. “I, I need, to find, Glacia… W-we, we need to stop… Mara…”

What Pyra did not know, however, was that Mara had already made it to the Kingdom of Snows before her. She was extremely distraught and pouring her heart out to Glacia, who was doing her best to console Mara.

“I-I failed…” Mara cried. “I-I couldn’t save them, Glacia, I was too late, I… *I…”*

“It’s going to be okay.” Glacia said softly, patting Mara’s back. “Mara, what exactly happened there?”

“I-I don’t know, I,” Mara sniffled. “L-Light Hope told me Magicat Kingdom was going to be destroyed, that there would be… A cataclysm. I-I went there to evacuate them, I wanted to save as many as possible. I, transformed into She-Ra, I figured I’d at least be able to protect them if I couldn’t stop the disaster from happening. I reached their kingdom and yelled at the Magicats to run, to leave the island, b-but then…” She clutched her head, trying to remember.

“What happened?” Glacia asked again.

“I-I’m not sure.” Mara muttered. “I remember seeing this bright *flash,* like an explosion of light, and it knocked me out. When I woke up…” She felt so overwhelmed. Glacia held Mara’s hand, and

she was able to continue: “The entire kingdom, it was just… *Gone.* Destroyed. All the buildings were reduced to rubble, a lot of the Magicats, they, t-they died. The bodies…”

“Oh, no…” Glacia whispered, horrified. “W-were there any survivors?”

“Yeah. Some.” Mara nodded. “But they… The surviving Magicats, *they thought **I** was the one who caused it.”*

“Did you?”

“No! At least, I don't... I don't *think* I did. But," Mara sighed. "It doesn’t really matter. Because the end result is the same, I **failed** them.” She stared at her hands, tears rolling down her cheeks. “W-when Pyra finds out… S-she’s *never* going to forgive me.”

“Hey,” Glacia said warmly. “Pyra can be a real stubborn hothead at times, but she’s also your friend first and foremost. She knows you tried to save her people, and I'm sure she’ll understand.”

“Y-you think?” Mara wondered. Glacia nodded and smiled.

“I know you could never do something like that, Mara.” Glacia affirmed. “I trust you. And if you want, I can talk to Pyra about this, vouch for you. Make sure she understands that you were trying to protect the Magicats from the disaster.”

“I… Thanks, Glacia.” Mara said with a grateful smile. “I-I don’t know what I’d do without you.”

“Don’t mention it!” Glacia grinned. “You’re my best friend, and I love you.”

“Hehe. Love you too, Glacia.”

Mara and Glacia shared a very comforting, tender hug. The two princesses held each other in their arms for a moment, when suddenly-

*“**What the hell are you two doing?!**”*

“Ah!” Mara and Glacia both gasped, having been startled by a voice roaring at them, and immediately backed away from one another. They looked towards the direction that the voice had come from.

Pyra was standing there, breathing heavily. Her eyes were brimming with tears, and her expression was one of unyielding, murderous rage.

“Pyra…”

"Hmm, nothin' yet."

Pyra was observing the tracker pad Catra had given her, displaying a map of Etheria. On her right hand she was fiddling with something else Catra had brought with her yesterday.

A Horde Force Captain badge.

"Hard to believe these lil' things would be capable of tracking *anything."* Pyra muttered skeptically, inspecting the badge. She yelled over her shoulder: "Your friend should've already caught up with them but there's nothing here, kid. I think this plan was a bust-"

Suddenly, Pyra heard loud beeping coming from the tracker pad. Then, she noticed a blinking red dot on the map, near the edge of the Crimson Waste and zoomed in.

It was moving.

"Well well well," Pyra smirked, having been pleasantly surprised. "I stand corrected!"

“Told you so.” Said Catra, who was standing next to Pyra with her arms crossed and a smug smile on her face.

“Now let’s get going. We’ve got a long trip to the desert ahead of us.”

Chapter End Notes

Happy Halloween! There's no spooky happenings in this chapter, just happened to put it out today 🎃🦇

The comment about Frosta's age was my way of concretely giving a timeframe for when this fic is set, had to of course throw in the "three quarters".

Speaking of Frosta, when I was the initial planning stages for this fic I hadn't planned for Frosta to have a larger role, but during the drafting process I decided this would be a good opportunity to give her more to do, as Frosta in the actual show was pretty underutilized and didn't get too much development compared to Mermista, Perfuma and Scorpia.

The flashback towards the end of the chapter with Mara and Glacia was originally going to be the beginning of the next chapter, but I decided to move it here for pacing reasons as the next chapter is going to be quite long already!

Chapter 8: The Sunstone

Chapter Summary

> The Best Friend Squad, Frosta and Huntara continue their journey through the Crimson Waste to reach the Sunstone before Pyra can get her hands on it. Adora grows suspicious of Catra's behavior and fears that Catra might still be upset with her over their fight.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Adora? You okay?”

Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Catra and Frosta were making their way down the Crimson Waste, with Huntara guiding them towards their destination. They’d already traveled for an hour, yet there was still a long way to go before they’d get to the Brimstone Cave.

“H-huh?” Adora looked at Glimmer, who had gently nudged her to catch her attention.

“You seemed to have spaced out there for a sec.” Glimmer stated. “Something bothering you?”

“It’s uh, it’s nothing.” Adora muttered. “Don’t worry about it.”

“Hey, if you’re having second thoughts about this I can teleport you back to Bright Moon and-”

“It’s fine.” Adora asserted. “Just my imagination running wild, that’s all. I think the heat’s getting to me.”

“Yeah, I feel ya there.” Glimmer sighed, wiping her brow. “I did **not** expect this place to be even *hotter* than before!”

“Me neither.” Bow agreed, taking a swig from his water bottle. “I really hope we’ll come across an oasis or something soon, my bottle’s gonna need a refill…”

“It’s gonna take a while before we get there, Boy.” Huntara stated. “Conserve as much water as you can.”

“Way ahead of you.” Grumbled Frosta, who had tied her parka around her waist by its sleeves and had resorted to using her own sweat to channel her ice powers so she could try and stay cool, to limited success. “Man, remind me to stay home next time you guys wanna come to the Crimson Waste!”

“It’s not too late to go back, Shorty.” Huntara told her. “You can still tap out if you want!”

“Oh no way, old lady!” Frosta fired back. “I’m not backing out now, in fact I can go twice as far as you!”

“You’ve got attitude, kid.” Huntara smiled. “I like that. You’d fit right in here at the Waste!”

“Eat sand.” Frosta flipped Huntara off, giving her a cocky grin.

“We’re all getting pretty heated here.” Glimmer said. “We should find some shade soon, a place to rest. Take a break, you know?”

“Yeah.” Adora mumbled under her breath. “All of us…”

Something was bothering Adora. Herself, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta were all pretty exhausted and struggling with the heat. The only ones who seemed to not be bothered by the high temperature were Huntara… *And Catra.*

Huntara, Adora understood why. She’s spent her entire life living in the Crimson Waste, it made sense she’s used to the climate. But ***Catra?*** Something wasn’t adding up here.

“C’mon, this is no time for slacking off.” Catra waved her hand dismissively. “We’ve got a job to do, we need to stay focused.”

“Easy for you to say, Catra.” Adora glared at her, before asking: “How come the heat’s not getting to you at all?”

“Huh?” Catra stopped dead in her tracks, confused. “What do you mean?”

“Bow, Glimmer and I are all sweating our backs off here. Frosta too.” Adora elaborated. “But you seem to be doing just fine, and I figured with all that fur it’d be a struggle.”

“Eh,” Catra shrugged. “Guess I’m just used to it, after basically living here for a while-”

“Huh?” Glimmer wondered. “What’re you talking about? You’ve spent your entire life living in either the Fright Zone or Bright Moon!”

“I was referring to the time Scorpia and I were sent here to look for First Ones’ tech.” Catra clarified. “Remember?”

“...Catra, that was like, ***a day*** *at most.”* Adora stated, raising an eyebrow.

“Guess I just acclimated to the desert heat quickly during that day!” Catra chuckled, brushing off Adora’s questioning. Adora, however, was growing more suspicious by the second as they continued their journey through the Waste.

Ever since Catra had come back yesterday, there was something odd about her behavior. She and Adora had a massive fight that nearly tore their relationship apart, yet Catra came back acting like nothing had happened? And she was completely dismissive and distant towards Adora, not wanting to talk with her or even listen to her any time she tried to tell her about the pregnancy.

Either something fishy was going on behind the scenes, or… *Catra was still mad at Adora.*

That would make sense, Adora thought. The way Catra seemed to be avoiding her. While Catra had caught on to what Pyra was doing, and even if she had said yesterday that everything was fine now, she obviously must've still held a grudge towards Adora for what she had said during their argument.

Now, Adora was filled with uncertainty again. Once they've found the Sunstone and stopped Pyra… What was going to happen after that? Would Catra be willing to talk things through then? Or would she end up leaving Adora, just like before?

She had to make sure.

"Alright." Huntara stopped, turning to address the group. "This should be a good place to stop for a bit."

"Huh?" Bow looked around. "But… This is just empty desert?"

“Two reasons.” Huntara said, holding up two of her fingers. “One-”

“Looks like *grandma* here’s ready to tap out!” Frosta taunted Huntara and kept walking. “Fine, we can get to the cave without you!”

“Uhh, I *really* wouldn’t do that if I were you, Shorty.” Huntara tried to warn her.

“Why not?” Frosta shrugged dismissively. “There’s nothing here except sa- AAAAAHHHHHHHH!”

After taking a few more steps forward, Frosta had walked onto a patch of quicksand and sank into it.

“Frosta!” Glimmer quickly teleported to rescue her. After bringing Frosta back to the surface, she asked: “You okay?”

“So, that’s reason number one.” Huntara snarked. “There’s a big field of quicksand here, I need to find us a safe path forward.”

“Blegh!” Frosta coughed and spat out a mouthful of sand. *“Duly noted.”*

“I’ve been there before.” Adora said to Frosta, patting her back.

“So… We’re just gonna sit here? In the scorching sunlight?” Catra asked impatiently, crossing her arms. “We don’t have much water left, we should get to the cave before-”

“Don’t fret, Puss.” Huntara said. She tapped the ground underneath with her staff a few times at different spots, listening intently. “I think there should be a… There!”

Huntara thrusted her staff into the sand, and after pulling it out water began spouting out of the hole in the ground like a fountain.

“Water!” Bow exclaimed, hastily opening his near-empty water bottle and refilling it.

“Knew there was an underground current somewhere about here.” Huntara remarked. “Y’all can get a refill, and also wash the dirt outta your eyes.”

“Oh, yes!” Frosta yelled excitedly. She used her powers to freeze some of the water coming from underground, and encased herself in an armor made of ice. “Ahh that’s so refreshing, feels like home!”

“Ooo, could you make me some ice cubes?” Bow asked her, eagerly holding out his water bottle.

“Hm?” Adora noticed that Catra was walking off to the side. “Catra, where are you going?”

“Oh uh,” Catra paused for a second, then pointed towards a large boulder in the distance. “Since we’re stopping here anyway, I’m gonna go use the bathroom real quick.”

“All the way over there?” Glimmer asked with her eyebrows raised questioningly. “We’re basically in one giant litterbox, you could just go *anywhere.”*

“Geez, give a girl some privacy will ya?” Catra chuckled. “I’ll be right back.”

“O-okay.” Adora watched as Catra walked away, then once she was out of earshot she turned to Bow and Glimmer. “Guys, do you think Catra’s acting a bit, I dunno, *unusual?”*

“Not really.” Bow replied. “Maybe she’s just shy? I know I have a hard time going when I’m around other people-”

“What? No, not that!” Adora quickly clarified. “It’s just, she seems so antsy. Ever since yesterday she’s been so focused on Pyra and the Sunstone, she shoots me down every time I try to tell her that

I’m pregnant and in general she’s just… Staying at a distance, not talking to me. Like she’s trying to avoid me.”

“Now that you mention it,” Glimmer pondered. “That does seem a bit strange.”

“I’m worried that she’s still upset with me. About our fight, what I said.” Adora sighed. “And that’s why she doesn’t wanna talk.”

“But Catra said that everything is fine and that she forgave you.” Bow reminded her.

“I know. But she could’ve been lying to spare my feelings.” Adora feared. “Maybe… Maybe she’s still holding a grudge.”

“You think so?” Glimmer gave Adora a concerned glance. Adora nodded.

“I’m scared.” Adora whispered. “What if she still hasn’t forgiven me? What if we find the Sunstone and defeat Pyra, and then Catra just… *Leaves me again?*"

“Adora, I’m sure things are fine.” Bow gently pat Adora’s back. “Catra’s probably just worked up after learning that Pyra’s up to no good, that’s why she’s so focused on this.”

“I hope you’re right.” Adora said. “I just wish I could see into her head, know what she’s thinking, you know?”

“Hey, I could go ask her what’s up if you want.” Glimmer suggested. “Catra usually confides in me when she’s got something on her mind that she doesn’t wanna bother you with, I’m sure she’ll tell me if there’s anything wrong!”

“R-really? You’d do that for me?” Adora asked, and Glimmer nodded. “Thanks, Glimmer. You’re the best!”

“I’ll be right back!” Glimmer teleported towards the boulder where Catra had walked to, deciding to keep a little bit of distance in case Catra was still doing her business. She called out: “Hey, Catra?”

No response. Glimmer peered behind the rock and saw Catra crouched down with her back turned. She was holding something in her right hand that Glimmer couldn’t see, and for a second it almost looked like she had been talking into it.

“Catra?”

“Oh, hey.” Catra turned around. “Check what I found!”

Catra raised her right hand, showing Glimmer what she was holding in it: A large, brown tarantula that was wriggling its legs.

“AAHHHH!” Glimmer screamed, recoiling and jumping back out of fear and disgust. “K-keep that t-thing away!”

“What? Oh c’mon, it’s harmless!” Catra laughed. “Can’t even bite you or anything. Here, wanna hold it?”

“Ew ew ew ew ew!” Glimmer stumbled backwards as Catra tried to offer the tarantula to her. “T-that’s so gross!”

She instinctively teleported back to Adora and Bow, sweating and breathing rapidly and generally looking freaked out.

“Glimmer?” Adora wondered. “What happened? How’d it go-”

“I HATE SPIDERS!” Glimmer shouted.

“Huh?” Adora and Bow shared confused looks.

“Guess she wasn’t fan of this!” Said Catra, who had returned while still holding onto the spider. “Found this lil’ guy just wandering around the desert.”

“Aww, it’s kinda cute!” Adora squeed.

“You two have a ***twisted*** understanding of what’s cute!” Glimmer grumbled, hiding behind Bow’s back glaring at the tarantula in Catra’s hand. “I-it’s so hairy and wriggly, and it has an unnatural number of eyes and legs and, and-”

“Pfft, you should have seen the spiders I fought back at the Crystal Castle.” Adora reminisced. “They were like, the size of that boulder where you two just came from!”

“I fought those too, y’know!” Glimmer cried. “And right now, I-I don’t wanna think about mega-sized spiders, or even regular sized ones!”

“It’s okay, Glimmer.” Bow comforted Glimmer, hugging her and gently kissing her forehead. “I’ll make sure to keep you safe from any creepy crawlies.”

“Heh, y-you promise?” Glimmer smiled, managing to calm down as she lovingly gazed into Bow’s eyes.

“Come on Glimmer, there’s nothing to be afraid of with spiders.” Catra claimed, with a smug smirk on her face. “If they bite you, you just gotta bite ‘em back!”

Glimmer just stuck her tongue out at Catra in response. However, Adora gasped quietly as soon as she realized what Catra had just

said.

Glimmer.

Catra *never* refers to Glimmer by her name when talking directly to her, it's always *'Sparkles'.* She's only ever used *'Glimmer'* when she is referring to her in passing while talking to other people.

What was going on? Adora *needed* to talk to her.

"Catra-"

"Guys, Huntara's found us a safe path forward!" Frosta exclaimed. "Let's get going!"

"Ah, good." Catra lowered the tarantula to the ground, where it quickly scurried away. "Time to get a move on, gonna be a while still before we get to the Sunstone."

"B-but, Catra wait-" Adora stammered, but Catra was already heading to follow Huntara's lead with Frosta, Bow and Glimmer. Adora sighed and muttered dejectedly to herself as she followed the others: "...She *hates* me."

After a long journey through the Crimson Waste that consisted of avoiding more quicksand, evading a sandstorm, fighting off bandits and running away from sandsnakes, the party had finally reached their destination.

"Well, here we are." Huntara stated. She gestured towards the massive mouth of a cave that appeared to be leading into a mountain that concerningly resembled a volcano. "There's the Brimstone Cave."

"Whoa, it's *huge."* Bow gasped in awe. He inspected the outside of the cave and said: "This looks to be made entirely out of igneous rock, like lava that has cooled down!"

"Would check out." Huntara nodded. "Legend has it that the cave was formed after a volcanic eruption some tens of thousands of years ago."

"That's… *So cool!"* Frosta squeed, her eyes sparkling.

"Cool, and very dangerous. Haven't ever gone in myself. Blondie," Huntara turned to Adora. "Last chance for you to stay out here, I'm serious. The cave's not safe."

"Even more of a reason for me to come with you guys." Adora said. "We might need She-Ra in there."

"As you wish." Huntara shrugged. "Alright, ready to go in? Just remember: *Watch your step."*

"What's that mean?" Glimmer whispered to Bow, who shook his head.

"Let's go." Catra said, staring at the entrance of the cave. "We're almost done here."

"Right."

The group gathered their bearings, then cautiously entered the Brimstone Cave.

Inside of the cave felt practically like a sauna: The temperature was even hotter than outside, and there was the foul stench of something that resembled rotten eggs that permeated through the entire cave, causing Frosta to gag and Glimmer to plug her nose.

"The stalagmites here are pretty cool." Bow observed as he looked around the cave. "Kinda reminds me of Krytis!"

"Hmmm…" Glimmer looked behind her back, seeming suspicious.

“What’s up?” Bow wondered.

“It’s just… For a second I thought I heard something. Like we’re being followed.” Glimmer said quietly.

“Might just be the echo here.” Catra snapped her fingers, causing the sound to bounce around the cave walls. “We’re hearing our own footsteps.”

“Maybe.” Glimmer glanced back again. “Just a feeling I had, that’s all.”

“So aside from the awful smell,” Frosta looked around and asked: “What makes this place so danger- Ah!”

Just a few feet away from her a geysir shot out of the ground, spitting out sulphuric gas and a tiny amount of-

“I-is that *lava?!”* Glimmer yelled.

“Yup.” Huntara nodded. “The whole cave’s basically sitting atop an ocean of magma, and the layer separating us from that isn’t particularly thick. Not to mention there’s some pitfalls out here, so if you fall down… **Don’t fall down.**”

Bow, Glimmer and Frosta all gulped nervously. Adora still only had one burning question on her mind.

"Hey uh, Catra?" Adora started.

"What is it, Adora?" Catra sighed, sounding really disinterested.

"C-can I talk to you, for a sec? In private?"

"Adora, this really isn't the time-"

"Please." Adora grabbed Catra's wrist to stop her, begging her to not go. "Stay. T-this will only take a minute, I promise."

"...Okay." Catra relented, then told the others: "Go on ahead without us, we'll catch up with you."

"Alright. Don't take too long!" Huntara told them as she led Frosta, Bow and Glimmer deeper into the cave, leaving Adora and Catra to stand there by themselves.

"What's up?" Catra asked Adora, again sounding impatient.

“I uh… What you said yesterday.” Adora tried to formulate her thoughts into words. “When you said that everything’s good now.”

“Yes?”

“Did you… Did you mean it?”

“Huh?” Catra tilted her head and stared at Adora confused. “What are you talking about?”

“Are you still mad at me?” Adora asked. “For what I said during our argument? I-I know I shouldn’t have lost my cool or brought up your past, I just-”

“Adora, everything is fine!” Catra assured her. “Where is this coming from?”

“You’ve been acting so strange, ever since yesterday.” Adora muttered, holding Catra’s hands. “A-and it feels like you’re intentionally avoiding me, you shoot me down any time I try to talk to you and… Look, just, tell me if you’re still upset over our fight, I’ll understand, I just wanted to say that I'm-”

“Adora.” Catra said firmly. “I promise you. Everything is fine, whatever happened is in the past. I forgive you.”

"R-really?" Adora asked hopefully, and Catra nodded.

"I'm sorry if it feels like I've been neglecting or avoiding you." Catra apologized. "I've just been so focused on this mission, it… It was a real shock to me to learn what Pyra was up to, that you had been right about her, and I just want to stop her before she can hurt you or anyone else. I assure you, after we've taken care of the Sunstone we can talk things through for as long as possible and you can tell me whatever has been on your mind. Sound good?"

"You promise?" Adora gave her a cautious smile.

"Of course." Catra stroke Adora's cheek and gave her a soft kiss. "I promise, darling. Everything is going to be alright. Now, let's get going before the others get too far ahead and we lose 'em in this pit!"

Catra turned around and walked off towards the direction the others had gone, brushing Adora's hand with her tail as she did.

Darling.

Alarm bells were ringing loudly inside Adora's head. She froze up.

Catra had many affectionate nicknames for Adora: Dummy, Idiot, Dork, Stupid, Jerk… *But 'Darling' was* ***not one of them.***

Either someone had done something to Catra, and that's why her behavior was so unusual. Or… *That's **not** Catra.*

"You coming?" Catra asked, snapping Adora out of her thoughts.

"...Yeah." Adora mumbled, following Catra and deciding to keep a close eye on her now that her suspicions had reached a critical point.

After a while of trekking inside of the Brimstone Cave the group came across a massive, open chamber inside the heart of the cave. There was a raised rocky platform in the middle of the chamber, with a pedestal in the center of the platform.

"Whoaaa…" Glimmer gasped. She laid her eyes on the pedestal, atop of which floated a huge, orange-red gemstone that was crudely in the shape of a star. "I-is that what I think it is?"

"The Sunstone." Adora said, with a hint of triumph to her voice.

The stone itself looked different from the other runestones, in that it was completely dormant and lifeless. Adora presumed this was due to Pyra having lost her connection to it a millennium ago.

"We, we did it!" Bow stated happily.

“Yes!” Frosta cheered. “Now we can stop that Fire Princess!”

“Uh, how’re you planning to destroy that thing?” Huntara wondered. “Looks pretty durable, and I don’t think you guys brought dynamite with you or anything.”

“Oh, right!” Glimmer remembered. “I tried destroying the Black Garnet to stop the Heart of Etheria from fully activating, but even a barrage of my attacks didn’t so much as scratch it…”

“She-Ra could probably do it.” Catra thought out loud, turning her gaze towards Adora.

Adora gave Catra one quick suspicious look, then summoned her sword and shouted: *“For the Honor of Grayskull!”,* transforming into She-Ra in a flash of light.

“Alright,” She-Ra pointed her sword at the Sunstone with both arms. “Here goes nothing.”

“You know what you’re doing?” Bow asked.

“Nope.” She-Ra replied curtly, before grunting as she shot a beam of light out of her sword. As soon as the beam made contact with the Sunstone She-Ra could feel something happening, magic

coursing through the cave and flowing around her. The Sunstone began glowing brightly, lighting up the entire room and eventually releasing a burst of magical energy that nearly knocked everyone to the floor.

"Whoa!" Glimmer yelped.

"C'mon, c'mon…" She-Ra grit her teeth, trying to keep the beam focused until she eventually buckled, feeling exhausted.

The Sunstone didn't look dormant anymore, there was a light inside of it that was flickering similar to a flame.

"D-did that do anything?" Frosta wondered.

"I-I dunno." She-Ra shrugged. She noticed that Catra was anxiously shooting discreet glances towards the entrance to the chamber. "Gimme a minute."

"Hmmm… Nothing." Catra tapped her foot on the ground as she looked back at the Sunstone. "Adora, maybe you should give that light show another try and- AH!"

"**GRAAH!**" Suddenly She-Ra swung her sword, launching a wave of energy at Catra that coiled around her, binding her and knocking her to the ground.

“A-Adora!” Bow and Glimmer yelped. “What the heck are you doing?”

“Nghh…” Catra grunted, as She-Ra walked up to her. “Adora, what’s the meaning of this? Why are you- Ah!”

She-Ra grabbed Catra by her collar and lifted her up.

“Where’s Catra?!” She-Ra shouted angrily. “What have you done with her?!”

“Huh?” Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara all shared confused glances, then stared at She-Ra in stunned silence.

“W-what are you talking about?” Catra asked frantically. “Have you lost your mind or something?”

“Adora, what’s going on?” Glimmer wondered, not having any idea why She-Ra would turn on Catra like this.

“You…” She-Ra muttered. “I don’t know who you are, but you are NOT Catra. *Where is she?!”*

“Good observation, dummy!” A voice taunted her from behind. She-Ra, Bow, Glimmer, Huntara and Frosta all turned their heads towards the sound of the voice coming from the chamber’s entrance.

At the entrance were standing a very victorious and smug-looking Pyra… *And Catra.*

“Hey, Adora.” Catra playfully waved her hand.

“N-no…” She-Ra mumbled, not believing her eyes.

“What?! How in the-!” Glimmer exclaimed out of shock at this development. “But wait, if Catra is there, then who-”

She noticed that the other Catra She-Ra had been holding onto had somehow managed to escape her grip and the binds, and was now casually walking towards Pyra and Catra at the entrance while whistling.

“So,” The other Catra asked with a cocky grin. “How did you like my performance?”

“Bravo!” Pyra applauded, while the other Catra bowed.

“No way,” She-Ra finally figured it out. “That’s-”

Her suspicions were confirmed as the other Catra shapeshifted in front of everyone, transforming into…

“Double Trouble?!” Bow exclaimed.

“Who else, darling?” Double Trouble cackled.

“Y-you!” Frosta whispered angrily. Huntara just snarled as she stared at the shapeshifter with disdain in her eyes.

“Aww, you all don’t sound so happy to see me!” Double Trouble said in a sarcastic voice. “Figured it was about time for a comeback tour, when Kitten here approached me with an… *Interesting* business proposal.”

“Good work.” Catra said, handing a small bag of gold to Double Trouble. *“As always.”*

“I aim to please.” Double Trouble snarked.

“S-so someone really **was** following us!” Glimmer realized. “How, how did you manage to hunt us down?!”

“Does *this* ring any bells?” Catra chuckled as she pulled a Force Captain badge out of her pocket, tapping it with her index finger. “Scorpia had a bunch of these just laying discarded at the Fright Zone, went to borrow a couple and handed one over to Double Trouble here. We were able to keep track of your *every* move.”

“How- no, *why?!”* She-Ra demanded to know. “*Why* did you do all this?”

“Oh, that’s easy!” Catra gloated. “See, Pyra told me how Mara and Glacia must’ve had moved the Sunstone some time after she had been frozen, and I reasoned that either Mara or Glacia would’ve passed that information down somewhere. And based on what Double Trouble relayed to me from your little book club, it seems I was right!”

“So, at the library…” She-Ra muttered, realizing how badly she had been duped. “That was still just… *Them?”*

“But if you knew the Sunstone was here, why go through with all this?” Bow wondered. “Why didn’t you come get it right away?”

“Two reasons.” Catra held her index and middle finger up. “One: We needed a safe passage through the Crimson Waste to even reach the cave, and you all had a very experienced and trusty guide to do the job for us!”

“Grrr, oh I am gonna have your *head,* you scheming little-” Huntara growled.

“And two: We needed *you* to reactivate the Sunstone’s powers, Adora.” Catra continued. “Since She-Ra was the one who had severed Pyra’s connection to the stone by deactivating it, She-Ra also had to be the one to turn it back online!”

“N-no…” She-Ra gasped, turning her head towards the shimmering Sunstone. “But then, that means-”

“You played right into our hands… ***Adora.”*** Pyra concluded.

“I guess you won’t be needing me here anymore.” Double Trouble sneaked their way past Catra and Pyra. “I’m just gonna go, catch y’all later!”

Double Trouble ran off before anyone could be bothered to stop them. Pyra placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder and said: “You did good, Catra. Now, after all these years…” She greedily laid her eyes on the Sunstone. “The Sunstone shall again be ***mine!”***

“Oh, no you don’t!” She-Ra, while shocked and angry, still kept her focus as she charged towards Pyra and swung her sword. Before it could make contact, Catra had intercepted the blow with her own claws and was now staring She-Ra down. *“C-Catra!”*

“I’ll hold her off!” Catra barked to Pyra. “Get to the stone!”

“Got it! Thanks, kid!” Pyra nodded, running past She-Ra and Catra towards the center of the chamber. She-Ra tried to run after her, but Catra kept her from reaching Pyra.

“Don’t you even think about it!” Glimmer said as she, Bow, Frosta and Huntara all blocked Pyra’s way to the Sunstone, ready to do battle.

“Nghh… Catra,” She-Ra grumbled while trying to get past Catra. “Catra, listen to me! I’m-”

“Sorry? Yeah, I *bet* you are!” Catra scoffed. “I told you Adora, I am finding the Magicats *with or* ***without*** *you!”*

“Ugh, would you just for once *stop interrupting me?!* I’m trying to tell you that I’m pre-” She-Ra was cut off by Catra swiping at her with her claws, being forced to block another attack.

“I don’t care!” Catra hissed, teary-eyed. “Whatever it is, you’re not stopping me from doing this! Not when I’m *this close* to finally finding my parents!”

“Catra…”

Meanwhile, Pyra was ready to face off against Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara, all of whom had raised their weapons or fists at her.

"Hmph. *Please."* Pyra jeered, staring the group down. "Y'all know how this ends."

"You're outnumbered!" Bow stated, aiming an arrow at Pyra. "Give it up!"

"Funny." Pyra smirked. "Could've sworn I heard that somewhere before, back at the Woods. *Where I kicked all of your butts."*

"You're not getting away this time!" Frosta yelled, raising her fists that were encased in ice.

"You might've fought these kids before," Huntara stepped forward. "But you haven't faced the might of Huntara!"

"E-eh? Granny, wait! She's dangerous!" Frosta tried to warn her. Huntara charged towards Pyra swinging her staff horizontally, which Pyra dodged by sliding under it.

"W-what the- URGH!" Huntara was kicked to the ground by Pyra from behind her back.

“Huntara!” Frosta cried, running up to Huntara to help her back on her feet.

“Ngh… I’m fine, Shorty.” Huntara assured her.

“Heh. Lesson number one,” Pyra taunted. “Don’t run your mouth unless you can back it up with-”

Before she could finish, Glimmer had teleported diagonally above her and managed to land a sucker punch squarely across Pyra’s face.

“Grah!”

“Gotcha!” Glimmer gloated. Pyra slowly stood back up, rubbing her cheek.

“Hmph. Not bad, *Sparkles.”* Pyra said dryly. “But you’re gonna pay for that one.”

“Ah!” Glimmer barely managed to dodge as Pyra swiped her claws at her.

“Glimmer!” She-Ra yelled. She angrily said to Catra: “Catra, move out of the way!”

"Sorry Adora, *no can do."* Catra muttered, glaring at her.

"Catra…" She-Ra was so conflicted. She had to stop Pyra before it would be too late, she had to help her friends… But *she couldn't hurt Catra.*

"Hey, leave my bestie alone!" Frosta shouted at Pyra. She tried to use her ice powers to freeze Pyra's left arm, but the Magicat effortlessly freed herself from the ice by shattering it.

"**Pathetic.**" Pyra's voice was dripping with disgust. "Glacia would be ashamed by how much of a *weakling* her descendant is!"

"I'm NOT WEAK!" Frosta roared, throwing a massive ice fist at Pyra who dodged it, then kicked Frosta in the face knocking her aside.

"F-Frosta!" Glimmer cried. Pyra turned her attention back to Glimmer.

"Don't think you can escape my- GRAAH!" Pyra had raised her right hand to strike Glimmer, but just then Bow had fired one of his sticky trick arrows to bind Pyra to the floor by her arm.

"Hands off my love." Bow was readying another arrow while keeping a close eye on Pyra.

"Good save, honey!" Glimmer smiled at her boyfriend gratefully.

"Grrr…" Pyra growled, managing to free her right arm from the glue trap and get back up on her feet, only to discover that she had been surrounded by Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara. "Hmph, you people are so **annoying**. Fine, so be it."

"Ah! Guys, look out!" She-Ra saw from the distance that Pyra was reaching into her pocket. "She's got a-"

Before she could finish, Pyra had tossed a smoke bomb to the floor, enveloping herself, the four surrounding her and the entire central platform where the Sunstone laid in a smokey veil.

"D-damn it! Where'd she go?!" Glimmer coughed, trying to look around the smoke.

"I-I dunno, I can't see anything!" Glimmer heard Huntara's voice answering.

She-Ra saw a pair of hands reach out from the smoke, inches away from the Sunstone.

Pyra's hands.

"NO!" She-Ra's fears were confirmed as the smoke dissipated and she saw Pyra getting ready to reconnect with the Sunstone. Needing to act fast, She-Ra forcefully shoved Catra to knock her out of the way and desperately tried to reach Pyra, but it was already too late.

"At last." Pyra's hands made contact with the Sunstone.

She-Ra, Catra, Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara observed as magical energy consumed both the Sunstone and Pyra, emanating an orange glow that once again bathed the entire Brimstone Cave in light. The energy lifted Pyra off the ground and she spread her arms to her sides, her eyes glowing in an ethereal way as the stored magic of her ancestors flowed out of the Sunstone and into her own body.

Pyra roared, and what appeared to be flames were shooting out of her mouth and both arms. Then, she was lowered back to the floor and the orange glow slowly dimmed.

"No…" She-Ra mumbled in despair. "We, *we failed…"*

Pyra breathed in and out slowly while staring at her hands, before snapping her fingers and conjuring a large ball of fire in her right hand.

The Fire Princess had returned.

Chapter End Notes

When I was in the initial stages of drafting this fic, Pyra getting her powers back was originally the end point of chapter 2 so that goes to show how much this story expanded in scope as I started writing the outline for it!

Had a lot of fun writing Frosta and Huntara's interactions in particular, I always imagined they'd have a fun dynamic based on their personalities and how they're both kinda brash and cocky :)

Like I mentioned in the notes for the previous chapter, originally the latter flashback in that chapter was supposed to be the start of this one but I moved it for better pacing so this chapter kinda stands out with having no flashbacks. There'll be more starting next chapter!

Chapter 9: Betrayal

Chapter Summary

> Having failed their mission to stop Pyra from regaining her powers, the Princess Alliance gathers in Bright Moon to discuss Pyra's next move and Entrapta has a shocking revelation for everyone. In the past, Pyra snaps after thinking Glacia is having an affair with Mara, vowing revenge on those who have wronged her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pyra managed to finally make it to Glacia's castle. There was no time to waste, she had to find her fiancée soon and tell her what had happened, what Mara had done to the Magicats. They had to stop her.

As she approached the castle courtyard, she could hear Glacia's voice speaking in the distance: *"...I love you."*

"H-huh?" Pyra mumbled. Had she heard her right? Who was Glacia talking to?

Then, Pyra heard another voice. *Mara's voice.*

"Hehe. Love you too, Glacia."

No.

This couldn't be happening. Glacia and Mara… They wouldn't do this to Pyra. At the very least *Glacia* wouldn't, she loved Pyra. They were engaged, they're going to get **married.**

She wouldn't do this to her. *Right?*

Then, Pyra reached the courtyard and her heart sank as she witnessed Glacia and Mara standing there, holding one another in a gentle embrace. A *loving* embrace, as it appeared to Pyra.

Pyra felt her entire world come crashing down, tears streaming down her face out of sheer heartbreak and anguish. She was already enraged and on edge mentally after what had happened to Magicat Kingdom, but learning that Glacia had what looked like an affair with *Mara…*

Pyra completely snapped. She was out for blood, she… *She wanted to kill.*

*"**What the hell are you two doing?!**"* Pyra roared. Mara and Glacia both gasped and immediately backed away from one another, before turning around and seeing Pyra staring at them with murderous rage.

“Pyra…” Glacia muttered, shocked to see Pyra in this state. “You’re here. What’s-”

“I can’t believe this.” Pyra growled. “The love of my life, my fiancée… With the person who I *thought* was my best friend.”

“Pyra-”

“HOW LONG?!” Pyra shouted, baring her fangs. “How long have you two kept this going behind my back?!”

“W-what?” Glacia and Mara shared utterly confused glances. Glacia tried to calm Pyra down: “Pyra, I-I have no idea what you’re talking about-”

“YOU ***SLUT!”*** Pyra bellowed. The fact Glacia was trying to deny everything just made her angrier. “Not only have you been CHEATING on me, but you also just **had** to do it with this, this- This *MURDERER!!”* She pointed at Mara. “And now you’re playing dumb that you were caught red-handed!”

“W-what the- Pyra, I haven’t cheated on you!” Glacia yelled, hurt by Pyra’s accusations. “Mara and I haven’t done *anything,* she was reaching out for help after what happened to the Magicats and I was just comforting her, that's all!”

"I saw you!" Pyra shouted, stepping closer to Glacia and Mara. "I heard you saying you love each other, I saw with my own eyes you two hugging it out in broad daylight! And you're expecting me to believe you have *nothing* going on?!"

"Pyra, please calm down." Mara raised her hands. "Nothing happened, we can talk this out without-"

"Oh, don't *you* give me any of that crap!" Pyra hissed. "You, you… *You're a monster!* I **saw** what you did to Magicat Kingdom, Petra told me it was you! S-she lost an arm, she nearly lost her life! **ALL BECAUSE OF YOU!**"

"Pyra, it wasn't me!" Mara pleaded. "I promise you, I can explain everything-"

"GRAAHH!!" Pyra tossed a fireball at Mara, who was just barely able to jump out of the way. "You destroyed my home, you slaughtered my people… And now, you've been courting my fiancée this entire time?!"

"Pyra-"

"I'M GONNA FUCKING ***KILL YOU, MARA!"*** Pyra kept launching fireballs towards Mara, who pulled out the Sword of Protection from her back and used it to deflect them.

"F-for the honor of Gray- Ah!" Before she could transform into She-Ra, Pyra had knocked the sword out of Mara's grasp with a fireball, burning her hand.

"Pyra, stop!" Glacia begged, tears in her eyes. "Mara was trying to *save* the Magicats, she didn't-"

"Silence, *harlot!"* Pyra snarled. "I'll deal with **you** later."

"Pyra!" Glacia sobbed. "Y-you have to believe me! I, *I love you!"*

Pyra completely ignored Glacia, threateningly approaching Mara who was trying to reach her sword. Pyra launched another fireball that hit Mara in the stomach, causing her to scream in pain as she fell backwards nearly losing consciousness.

"Mara!" Glacia yelled.

"Ngh…" Mara tried to get up, but she was too injured from the fireball to move. Pyra grabbed Mara by her collar with her right hand while raising the claws on her left, ready to strike.

"Pyra, no!" Glacia tried to reason with the Magicat. "Stop!"

“Any last words?” Pyra asked Mara while steadying her left hand. “Before I rip your throat out?”

“P-Pyra, please…” Mara whispered weakly. “D, don’t, don’t do this…”

“Die.”

Mara closed her eyes, bracing herself for what was about to come. But before Pyra was able to finish her off-

*“I SAID **STOP!**”* A desperate Glacia shouted, and with no other options left she used her powers to completely freeze Pyra’s left arm, encasing it in ice.

“GYAAARHH!” Pyra screamed in agony, letting go of Mara and clutching her arm. The pain was excruciating, worse than any burn she could have ever experienced as the cold ice bit into her skin.

“Mara!” Glacia ran up to Mara, tending to her and making sure to shield her from Pyra. “Mara, you okay? Don’t die on me! Pyra, what is *wrong with you-”*

Glacia turned her head and saw the devastated look Pyra was giving her, causing her to gasp.

"I… I *loved* you!" Pyra cried, pain and hatred in her voice as she stared at Glacia. "I loved you more than *anything* in the world! How, how could you DO THIS TO ME?!"

"Pyra," Glacia muttered. "Pyra, listen to me, I-"

"This… *This isn't over."* Pyra growled. She got up, still clutching her left arm as she stormed out of the castle.

"Pyra, wait!" Glacia yelled after her, but Pyra had already ran away. "PYRA! No… *Why?"*

"Glacia…" Mara mumbled. Glacia turned back around, tending to Mara's burns with her ice powers.

"Mara, are you okay?" Glacia asked her, concerned.

"I'll live." Mara said, then gave her a very sad, apologetic look. "Glacia, I'm so sorry. I… I've ruined *everything."*

"This isn't your fault." Glacia assured her. "But I've never seen Pyra like… *That,* before. It's like she's totally lost her mind."

Glacia had no idea how correct she was. By the time Pyra made it back to the ruins of Magicat Kingdom she had gone completely berserk, her pupils having narrowed to vertical slits. She stared at her left arm which had thawed by now, but it was still in agonizing pain; The frostbite had scarred it and completely turned it black from the elbow down.

"Ngh…" Pyra clenched her hand. She thought about the events of that day.

She lost her kingdom. She lost her home. She lost her people. She lost someone she thought had been her best friend. And now… She's lost her fiancée. The one person she had loved more than anything in the entire universe.

She had lost **everything.**

Pyra's mind had been completely broken by her rage, filled with nothing but thoughts of revenge. Mara and Glacia had to pay- No, *all of Etheria* had to pay for what it had done to Pyra. For all of the pain it had caused her.

"P-Pyra?" A recovering Petra spotted Pyra approaching her. "A-are you alright? Did you find Mara? Listen, the others discovered a vast cave system beneath our island, we're gonna form a new settlement there and-"

“Out of my way.” Pyra hissed, harshly shoving Petra aside and walking towards the Sunstone, which had survived the onslaught on Magicat Kingdom and looked as pristine as ever.

“Pyra, what's wrong?” Petra asked, following after Pyra. “What did Glacia-”

*“**DON’T SAY THAT NAME!**”* Pyra screeched, causing Petra to flinch. She looked utterly deranged. “Don’t say that, that **whore’s** name in my presence *EVER AGAIN!”*

“W-what are you-” Petra gasped out of horror after seeing what had happened to Pyra’s left arm. “Oh my god… What *happened,* Pyra?”

“She did this.” Pyra said. Her eyes were welling up with tears again. “She and Mara, they’ve been having an affair. Fooling around behind my back for who knows how long. Caught 'em in the act.”

“No…” Petra whispered in complete disbelief. “T-that’s impossible…”

“I loved her. And this is how she repays me.” Pyra, realizing she was still wearing the necklace Glacia had given her when they got engaged, angrily ripped it off her neck and incinerated it with her fire powers. “And now, I-I have *nothing.* I’ve lost it all.”

“That’s not true!” Petra asserted, holding Pyra’s hand with her good arm. “Y-you’ve still got me, sis!”

Petra smiled gently at Pyra, attempting to comfort her and get her to calm down, but Pyra was too unstable by this point to be receptive towards her. She wrenched her hand out of Petra’s hold.

“Pyra-”

“Mara and Glacia, the First Ones…” Pyra growled. “They need to pay for what they’ve done. If this world wants to screw me over,” Her eyes gazed at the Sunstone with fury and determination. *“It shall feel the wrath of the Raging Inferno.”*

“The Inferno?! Pyra no, y-you can’t!” Petra cried, horrified by Pyra’s decision. “You know what mom told us about the Raging Inferno, we’re not supposed to unleash it under *any* circumstances, no matter what! You, you’ll destroy all of Etheria if it goes out of control-”

*“**I DON’T CARE!**”* Pyra roared, lashing out at her sister. “I don’t give a crap what happens to this *miserable* rock, as long as I get to have my vengeance on Mara and Glacia! And if the rest of Etheria goes down in flames with them… *So be it.”*

"You… *You're crazy!*" Petra yelled, appalled. "You'd seriously risk burning down the entire planet just for revenge? Are you *that* petty?!"

Pyra glared at Petra, then coldly retorted: "...Ya can't make an omelette without breaking a few eggs."

She then turned around, heading towards the Sunstone. Petra gasped, realizing that her sister was too far gone. She grabbed Pyra's wrist to stop her and said sternly:

"I'm not letting you do that, Pyra."

Pyra stood still, her back turned so Petra couldn't see her expression. At first she remained silent; Then, she let out a quiet chuckle that eventually erupted into maniacal laughter, unsettling Petra even further.

"Pyra-"

"I should've known." Pyra said, turning around and giving Petra a very irreverent, malicious grin. "Even **my own sister** turns against me."

"I'm not turning against *anyone!"* Petra yelled. "I'm just stopping you from making the worst mistake of your- AH!" Petra barely

managed to dodge as Pyra aimed a fireball directly at her face. "W-what is *wrong* with you?!"

"Stay out of my way." Pyra warned her. "Or you'll burn down with the rest."

"No!" Petra shouted defiantly. "You're not doing this! I won't allow it!"

"Hmph. By all means," Pyra hissed at her sister with utter contempt and derision, glancing at her missing left arm. "If you think you can stop me with only one arm then *go ahead and try."*

Petra, devastated to hear her sister insult her about her lost limb, completely lost her patience.

"Go to hell!" Petra lunged at Pyra and swiped her claws, scratching Pyra's right eye and leaving a scar over it.

"GYAARRHH!" Pyra screamed in pain, holding her hand over her eye. *"Motherfu-"*

Petra threw a punch at Pyra, which Pyra blocked with her left hand. Pyra took advantage of Petra being wide open and headbutted her.

“Ah!” Petra grunted in pain as she fell to the ground, nearly losing consciousness. “Ngh… Pyra, Pyra please don’t-”

“And stay down.” Pyra chopped the back of Petra’s neck with her hand, knocking her out cold. Pyra breathed heavily, and seemed to be momentarily coming back to her senses as she realized what she had just done to her little sister, horrified and ashamed of her actions.

“Petra… Petra, no! Wake up! Oh no, w-what have I done…”

Pyra crouched down and wanted to wake Petra up. Then, she caught a glimpse of the Sunstone in her peripheral vision and remembered what she had come here for.

“Hmph.” Pyra stood back up, coldly leaving her sister to lay unconscious on the ground. She walked up to the Sunstone and touched it with her hands, absorbing the magical power that her predecessors had contained within it. The Sunstone glowed bright, transferring that bright glow into Pyra who now had a flamelike aura around her.

She truly had nothing left anymore. Her kingdom, her people, Mara, Glacia… Even Petra had turned on her now.

Etheria had taken everything from her. And now, it was going to face the consequences.

"Ha, haha…" Pyra chuckled. She launched a stream of fire out of her hands, then began cackling triumphantly. "AHAHAHA! Yes! My powers are back, I… **I have returned!**"

"You did it, Pyra!" Catra cheered, witnessing Pyra's fire powers in awe. Everyone else was just fearfully staring at the Fire Princess, unsure of what was going to happen next.

"It's all thanks you to, kid." Pyra said gratefully. "I could've never done this on my own. Thank you, Catra." She then turned to Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara, flashing them a threatening grin. "Now then… *This is the part where you all lose."*

"In your dreams!" Huntara stated. She took a stance, ready to fight. "Fire or no fire, no way I'm gonna lose to a *pussycat* like you!"

"Your funeral." Pyra shrugged, then launched a fireball towards Huntara who was charging at her.

"Huntara, look out!" Frosta used her magic to form an ice barrier in front of Huntara, just barely managing to shield her from the fireball.

“Whoa!” Huntara fell to the ground backwards from the impact, then looked at Frosta. “T-thanks, Shorty.”

Frosta and Glimmer fired ice and sparkle attacks at Pyra, who effortlessly incinerated them with her flames.

“She’s too strong…” Glimmer muttered. She then glanced at She-Ra and Catra in the distance, remembering whose fault it was that Pyra was able to find her runestone, and lost her patience. She shouted angrily and teleported to where Catra was, tackling her to the ground.

“Whoa!” Catra yelped. Glimmer climbed on top of her, grabbing her by the collar with her left hand and raising her right hand that was clenched into a fist.

*“**You!**”* Glimmer yelled at Catra. “You lying, conniving, backstabbing..!”

“Glimmer,” She-Ra tried to calm Glimmer down, even though she was mad at Catra as well. “Glimmer, let her go, there’s no point-”

“I thought we were *friends!”* Glimmer’s fist was shaking. “How could you *do this* to us? *Betray us* like this?!"

“What, you think I *liked* doing this?!” Catra fired back. “I had no choice, Sparkles! Pyra and I are gonna save the Magicats, Pyra

needs her powers to do it! And since Adora wasn't going to help I-"

"Wait, her powers?" She-Ra interrupted. "W-what do you mean?"

"The Magicats, they're…" Catra muttered. "Pyra told me they're trapped, under the Kingdom of Snows. Mara and Glacia, they imprisoned them down there. We're going to set them free!"

"The Kingdom of Snows?" Frosta gasped, overhearing from the distance. "No way, why would they…"

"And you actually *believed* her?!" Glimmer jeered. "Catra, how *stupid* do you have to be to- AH!"

Glimmer was struck by a fireball from Pyra that hit the left side of her face, knocking her away and badly burning her.

"Hands off my sister." Pyra said threateningly, having extended her right arm.

"GLIMMER!" She-Ra and Bow both cried. She-Ra ran up to Glimmer, who was laying on the ground having lost consciousness.

Catra sat up, saw the second-degree burns on the left side of Glimmer's face and gasped, her pupils narrowing out of horror and concern for Glimmer.

"No," Catra mumbled, shaking her head. "S-Sparkles!"

"You… You're gonna **pay** for that!" An enraged Bow shouted, firing a barrage of arrows at Pyra. Pyra yawned and lazily incinerated the arrows mid-flight.

"Did ya seriously think that was gonna work?" She taunted Bow. "*This* is how you do it!"

Pyra made a flame in the shape of a bow in her left hand, and fired a flame arrow towards Bow with her right. The flame grazed Bow's left shoulder, burning it.

"Bow!" Frosta heard Bow grunting in pain, and used her ice powers to help alleviate the burn on him. While she was busy tending to Bow, Pyra was slowly approaching them with her arms to her sides, pillars of fire prepared in both of her hands.

"Time to finish this." Pyra smirked. "I'll show you what happens to those who *dare to cross me-"*

"Pyra, STOP!" Frosta's scream had alerted Catra to what Pyra was doing, and she'd caught up to her and grabbed her by her wrist.

“You can’t hurt them! They’re… They’re my *friends!”*

“‘Friends?’” Pyra scoffed, glaring at Catra. “Get a grip, kid! Etherians sided with the First Ones, this lot… They’re all *traitors* to the Magicats.”

“Pyra. Please.” Catra begged. “Remember what we came here for, we… We’ve got a job to do.”

Pyra stared at Catra for a moment, then sighed and backed down, dissipating the flames in her hands.

“Alright.” She said, before turning back to Bow, Frosta and Huntara. “Looks like you got lucky… *This time.* Catra, let’s go.”

Pyra grabbed Catra’s hand and the two Magicats started running towards the exit of the chamber.

“You okay, Glimmer?” She-Ra had used her powers to heal Glimmer’s injuries. Glimmer slowly regained consciousness and sat up.

“Ngh… Y-yeah, I think so.” Glimmer muttered, holding her head. She then spotted Pyra and Catra running past her and She-Ra. “Hey, they’re getting away!”

“Stop!” She-Ra was about to give chase to the pair, but stopped when she heard Bow calling her name:

“Adora, the Sunstone! If Mara was able to deactivate it, you should be too!”

“You, you’re right!” She-Ra realized and turned back around, pointing her sword at the Sunstone. However, before she could do anything she heard Pyra cackling and asking:

“Did ya really think I was just gonna *let you do that?”*

“W-wha- AH!”

Pyra launched a gigantic fireball at the ceiling of the chamber, sending rocks tumbling down as the entire cave began shaking violently.

“T-the ceiling’s gonna collapse!” Huntara yelled. “We gotta get outta here!”

“What?!” Catra screamed, turning to Pyra. “Are you *nuts?* Why did you-”

“And, just to make sure…” Pyra launched two more fireballs at the sides of the cave walls, blowing massive holes in them from which lava began pouring out, slowly filling the chamber containing the Sunstone.

“Ohh, this ain’t good.” Bow gulped nervously.

“This place is going to be filled with lava and rubble.” Pyra stated. “The Sunstone will remain safe here forever, now **nobody** can repeat what Mara did!"

“NO!” She-Ra screamed. She rushed up to the Sunstone and desperately tried hitting it with her sword, to no avail.

“By all means, try to destroy it!” Pyra taunted her. “But you’re gonna have to be quick about it, *or you’ll die trying.”*

“Adora…” Catra muttered. Feeling a sting of remorse she was thinking of going back, when Pyra grabbed her shoulder.

“Catra, let’s get going.” Pyra hurried her. “We gotta get outta here, quick!”

“R-right.” Catra nodded.

"It's no use!" Frosta tried using her ice powers to keep the flowing magma at bay, but the temperature was too much. "We're gonna end up either crushed or cooked alive!"

"C'mon, c'mon…" She-Ra still kept hitting the Sunstone out of sheer desperation, trying to destroy it or deactivate it somehow. "Ugh, this is hopeless!"

"Adora!" Glimmer teleported to the platform where the others were. "There's no time, we have to go! **Now!**"

"B-but…" She-Ra wanted to argue back, when a large rock crashed to the floor right next to her. She finally relented and gave Glimmer a nod; While the others gathered around Glimmer to be teleported to safety, She-Ra gave one last angry, resentful glare to Catra and Pyra by the chamber's exit.

"This… **This isn't over.**" She said sternly.

Catra gasped as she saw the look on She-Ra's face: *The exact same look she had given Catra after she opened the portal.* Regret and guilt were filling Catra as she turned around and ran after Pyra to get out of the Brimstone Cave before it would collapse.

"Adora, NOW!" Bow shouted; A massive rock was falling from the ceiling, about to crush the group. She-Ra touched Glimmer's shoulder and Glimmer teleported everyone to safety in the nick of

time, bringing them back to the edge of the Crimson Waste where they had originally started their journey.

"Y-you guys okay?" Glimmer asked everyone.

"Yeah. Thanks, Glitter." Huntara said, wiping her brow before turning to Frosta: "And thanks, Shorty, you saved my life back there. I… I really underestimated you."

"It's fine!" Frosta grinned. "You're not so bad yourself Granny, it was pretty brave of you to charge at Pyra like that."

Huntara smiled, and the two shook hands. She then apologetically turned to She-Ra, who had transformed back to Adora. "Sorry I wasn't able to do much, Blondie."

"It's fine." Adora reassured her. "We had to at least give this a shot. Thanks for your help, Huntara."

"This mission was a complete disaster." Bow sighed. "Adora, what do we do now?"

"I'm… I'm not sure," Adora started. "But we at least now know what their target is, based on what Catra said."

“The Kingdom of Snows.” Frosta nodded, then hesitantly asked: “D-do you think it’s true? That the Magicats are… Under my kingdom?”

“There’s no way.” Adora shook her head. “Mara wouldn’t have ever done something like that. But Catra certainly seems to believe it…”

“We should gather the other princesses.” Glimmer stated. “Then, all we can do is wait for Pyra to make her move.”

“Right. Let’s get going.”

“This isn’t looking good.”

Mara and Glacia had gathered in Mara’s ship, conversing with Light Hope. A week had passed since their last encounter with Pyra; In that time, the Princess of Fire had been laying low, until two days ago when fires had started raging in various parts of Etheria. Fires that even She-Ra had been struggling to put out.

“Pyra’s set basically half of Etheria on fire.” Mara worried. “A-and I can’t do anything about it. At this rate she’s gonna burn down the entire planet!”

“I feared something like this would happen.” Glacia sighed. “After what Petra warned me about… Ugh, I should’ve tracked Pyra down when I still had the chance! We could’ve stopped this!”

“We both know how slippery she can be.” Mara said sympathetically. “If she doesn’t want to be caught, she won’t let herself get caught. Light Hope,” Mara turned to her hologram companion. “What do we do?”

“Princess Pyra has been compromised.” Light Hope stated gravely. “The data that we gathered on Magicat Kingdom showed to us that the Magicats have tampered with their runestone. The power it has given Pyra… It is dangerous to all of Etheria, including herself. She needs to be put down, and the Sunstone must be taken offline.”

“Taken… Offline?” Mara wondered. “What does that mean?”

“Mara,” Light Hope said. “As She-Ra, you possess the ability to interface with other runestones. If you deactivate the Sunstone and sever Pyra’s connection to it, she will lose her powers and the fires will vanish.”

“R-really?” Glacia was relieved. “Then there’s still time!”

“But not much.” Mara presumed. “The fires are spreading fast.”

“I fear the fire is not our only concern.” Light Hope claimed. “Even without her powers, Pyra will still be out of control and she will not stop until she has exacted revenge on you both. She needs to be subdued.”

“Subdued?” Mara asked cautiously. “But, what do we-”

“I’ll handle Pyra.” Glacia stated. “I, I’m gonna talk some sense into her. Mara, you take the Sunstone and figure out a way to deactivate it before Pyra ends up destroying Etheria!”

“A-are you sure?” Mara placed her hand on Glacia’s shoulder. “That you’re capable of facing Pyra? You-”

“I love her,” Glacia sighed. “But, if we don’t stop her then… There’s no other choice, Mara. I can do this.”

“Okay.” Mara gently hugged Glacia. “Be safe.”

“You too.”

“Make haste.” Light Hope said. “If my analysis based on what Petra told you is correct, Pyra will be heading to the Kingdom of Snows. If she manages to put her plan into motion before you catch up to her, then even if she loses her powers… *There won’t* ***be*** *an Etheria to save anymore.”*

“Got it.” Mara nodded.

And so, Mara piloted her ship towards Magicat Kingdom once more, transforming into She-Ra and getting ready to turn the Sunstone offline, while Glacia headed back to her kingdom to intercept her fiancée.

But if Glacia couldn’t talk Pyra down from what she was about to do… *What options did she have left?*

“I still can’t believe she tricked us like that!”

Glimmer had gathered in Bright Moon’s war room with Adora, Bow, Frosta, Perfuma, Mermista, Scorpia, Spinnerella, Netossa, Entrapta and her father. While the others had been discussing the imminent threat of Pyra and her next move, Glimmer was still fuming about the scheme Catra had pulled to lead her and Pyra to the Sunstone.

“You can’t?” Adora asked, raising an eyebrow. “Because hiring Double Trouble to spy on us sounds **exactly** like Catra. We all know how cunning and ruthless she could be during the war."

“That ***does*** sound like the old Catra.” Scorpia muttered, worried. “Man, I should've known something was up when she stopped by the Fright Zone the other day! I-I really hope she isn’t sliding back into her old ways.”

“Me too.” Perfuma said sadly. “We had been making such good progress with her, I really thought Catra had gotten better ages ago…”

“Meh. Once a Horde soldier, always a Horde soldier.” Mermista scoffed, then after seeing the looks Adora and Scorpia gave her she cleared her throat and hurriedly added: “But yeah, it like, sucks or whatever.”

“At least Catra’s motives are pure this time, even if her methods are questionable.” Bow said. “She thinks she’s doing the right thing and helping her people, but…”

"Pyra knows what strings to pull." Micah looked serious. "She's used Catra's desire to find her family to form a close bond with her, worming her way into her heart. Catra wouldn't have done any of this if Pyra hadn't made her think it would lead her to her mother."

"That woman's been a toxic influence on her from the beginning." Adora said angrily, then sighed deep. “This is all my fault. I drove Catra away, and now she’s gone. And Pyra has her powers back, all because of-”

“It’s too late to think about that, Adora.” Glimmer pat her on the back. “Right now, we have to focus on what Pyra is planning and how to stop her."

“Exactly.” Netossa said, her arms crossed. “You guys said something about the Kingdom of Snows?”

“Apparently, the Magicats are trapped under there.” Frosta explained. “But-”

“Oh, right! Entrapta,” Bow turned to Entrapta. “You said you had some information to tell us?”

“Huh?” Entrapta, who had been glued to her tracker pad doing calculations, looked around the room, seeing everyone giving her curious looks and then remembered: “Oh yeah! So, I’ve got good news and bad news!”

“Uh-oh.” Glimmer swallowed nervously. “L-let’s start with the good news.”

“So the good news is, I ran some calculations and I think I may have figured out what Pyra's end goal is!” Entrapta said enthusiastically.

“A-and the bad news?” Adora asked cautiously.

“The bad news is, if my calculations are correct - which they are - then,” Entrapta said very non-chalantly. “We’re all going to die!”

A brief moment of stunned silence, until everyone else in the room shouted in unison: *“**WHAT?!**”*

“Umm, y-you’re gonna have to explain that one from, like, the very beginning, Geek Princess.” Mermista said, uneasy.

“Okie dokie!” Entrapta activated the holographic table at the center of the war room, connecting her tracker pad to it so she could offer the group visual demonstration. “So, if what Pyra said about the Magicats is true and they’re trapped deep underneath the Kingdom of Snows, they’ll be under a gigantic layer of permafrost. She would need to practically melt the entire kingdom to set them free, including the surrounding glaciers!”

“S-she’s gonna *destroy my kingdom?!”* Frosta screamed in horror. “She can’t!”

“Oh, I’m afraid this goes much further than the Kingdom of Snows!” Entrapta continued. “See, such a drastic change to the planet’s cryosphere would generate a massive amount of dihydrogen monoxide, which then-” She paused, after noticing everyone staring at her dumbfounded and slowed down: “Melting that much ice would create a lot of *wa-ter,* which would then flow into the *o-cean,* causing the *sea le-vels* to rise!”

"Rise?" Scorpia gasped. "Uhh, b-by how much?"

"Well, when taking the mass of the Kingdom of Snows into account… It would submerge about ninety percent of Etheria, leaving only the tallest mountaintops dry!" Entrapta then had a realization:" Ohh, I'm going to need to waterproof my castle! And Emily!"

"Wait, so… W-we're all gonna **drown?!**" Perfuma yelled.

"I dunno, that doesn't seem *too* bad to me." Mermista snarked, shrugging.

"Oh, the flooding is just step one!" Entrapta kept going. "Since all of that water is melted ice, it will lower the temperature of the ocean by quite a bit until it eventually freezes, which causes an ice age that will basically render Etheria completely uninhabitable!"

*"**W-WHAT?!**"* Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Frosta shouted.

"T-that, that sounds bad! Like *really* bad!" Scorpia gasped, with Perfuma nodding fearfully.

*"**Uggghhh,**"* Mermista groaned. "That's like, *SUPER* not cool."

“Oh, it is going to be *extremely* cool!” Entrapta said bluntly. “So cool in fact that you’re going to want to bring warm clothing with you!” She then pulled out her recorder and spoke into it: “Edit to log: Buy a new winter jacket…”

“So,” Micah stared at the holographic display in the center of the room. “This means that Pyra, she is going to…”

“She’s going to wipe out ***all life on Etheria!”*** Adora concluded.

“Yup! That’s about the size of it!” Entrapta nodded, clapping her hands and hair tendrils together.

“That means we have to hurry.” Spinnerella said. “If Pyra manages to put her plan into motion, it’s all over for us!”

“Guys, spread the word and start looking for Pyra and Catra!” Glimmer commanded. “It’s imperative that we find them before they get to the Kingdom of Snows!”

“Adora?” Bow noticed that Adora was lost in her thoughts. “What’s up?”

“I just…” Adora sighed. “Entrapta?”

"Yes?"

"Is, is there any way that the Magicats… Could *truly* be trapped under the Kingdom of Snows?"

"Hmmm well," Entrapta reset the holographic display, which was now showing a map of the Kingdom of Snows. "There *is* this crevice directly underneath the Kingdom that theoretically could house some life in it, but the chances are *extremely* improbable."

"But not impossible?" Adora double checked.

"Adora, what are you getting at?" Glimmer crossed her arms. "You don't… *Believe* Pyra, do you?"

"I want to say that I don't. But," Adora hesitated. "I need to be ***sure*** that it isn't true. Because if the Magicats really *are* trapped under the Kingdom of Snows, stopping Pyra would feel… ***Wrong***. I'm She-Ra, if the Magicats are in trouble it's my duty to help them."

"I… I get what you're saying." Glimmer admitted. "But if we don't stop Pyra, Etheria will be doomed!"

“I know that!” Adora said. “But if we *do* stop Pyra, the Magicats will remain imprisoned forever and Catra, she… She’ll never find her family.”

“Adora-”

“I need to make sure.” Adora reaffirmed her statement. “That we’re not dooming the Magicats by doing this. I… I wish I could just ask Light Hope, about what happened to the Magicats. She’s the only other person who would know for sure, aside from Pyra, but-”

“We need someone who knows a lot about Etheria’s past. It’s *history.”* Bow surmised. Then, he had an idea. “Adora?”

“Yeah?”

“I… *I think I know who can help us.”*

Chapter End Notes

> And that's a wrap on act two! We might be seeing a few familiar faces next chapter, where we move on to the final stretch of the story.

Chapter 10: Endgame

Chapter Summary

> Pyra and Catra make it to the Kingdom of Snows, and Catra is starting to have second thoughts about the plan to free the Magicats. Bow, Adora and Glimmer visit Bow's dads to ask them about Pyra, Glacia and the Magicats. In the past, Glacia confronts Pyra and is forced to make the ultimate choice in order to save Etheria.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Pyra!"

Glacia was standing atop the highest glacier that overlooked the Kingdom of Snows. Twenty feet away from her by the edge of the glacier was Pyra, who had her back turned on the Ice Princess.

"Well well well," Pyra turned around, staring at Glacia with nothing but smug contempt on her face. "If it isn't *the harlot.* Where'd ya leave your *lover?"*

"Mara and I have absolutely nothing going on." Glacia vehemently denied Pyra's accusations. "But you and I do."

Glacia couldn't help but notice that the necklace she had given Pyra was nowhere to be seen, missing from the Magicat's neck. She felt a fierce pang in her heart.

“How’d ya know to find me here?” Pyra demanded to know.

“Petra got in touch with me. She warned me that you’d be up to something stupid like this.”

“Ah, of course. Can’t even trust my own sister.”

“She wanted me to stop you,” Glacia did her best to remain calm, but her voice was wavering. “From making the biggest mistake of your life. So I came, to talk some sense into you.”

“Oh, NOW you wanna talk, huh?!” Pyra scoffed, raising her blackened left arm. “After *this?* Look what you’ve *done* to me!”

“I-I had no other choice!” Glacia yelled. “What, should I have just let your **murder** Mara and-”

*“**YES!**”* Pyra roared. “Mara slaughtered my people, she destroyed my home! She deserves to *die* for her sins… *Just like **you** do.”*

“You, you’re *insane.”* Glacia muttered, completely mortified by Pyra’s words.

"Hmph, your fault, *wench."* Pyra stared her down. "You made me this way, Glacia! You broke my heart, and now…" She raised her hands towards the sky, with a sadistic, triumphant look on her face. "I am going to *break your* ***kingdom."***

"W-what-"

Glacia watched in horror as Pyra shot out massive, crimson-colored flames from her hands. The flames contorted in the sky up above, eventually morphing into the shape of a gigantic dragon. The flame dragon appeared to shoot out fire from its 'mouth' as it flew overhead and eventually dug into the other side of the Kingdom of Snows, erupting into an ocean of fire that was slowly eating away at the ice and snow.

"NO!"

"The other fires," Pyra chuckled. "They were nothing more than a distraction. This, THIS was **always** my endgame. I'm reducing your precious kingdom into nothing more than a puddle!"

"What the- Have you *completely* lost your mind?!" Glacia shouted. "Do you know what happens when all that water flows into Salineas? Y-you're going to destroy EVERYTHING!"

"No," Pyra shook her head. "YOU are."

“H-huh?”

“The entire planet is going to freeze, Glacia. The cause of it is *your* kingdom melting down. And it’s melting down because of what *you* did to me. *All of this happened… Because of* ***you.”***

Glacia just stared at Pyra with her mouth agape. She couldn’t believe how twisted Pyra’s mind had become, how she could delude herself into thinking *Glacia* was the one to blame for this.

Glacia steeled her resolve, covered her fists in ice and raised them before telling Pyra: “Not if I stop you first.”

“Hmph. You’ll try.” Pyra responded cockily, conjuring two balls of fire in her hands.

The two princesses were staring one another down, ready to fight. Glacia didn’t want to do this, she didn’t want to hurt Pyra. Her love. But she had to save her kingdom, she had to save Etheria.

Eventually, Pyra tossed one of the fireballs at Glacia, who countered it by firing a large icicle. The two attacks collided midair and exploded, and the princesses began their duel.

Their fight was unlike anything Etheria had ever seen before or since, as fire and ice blasts clashed and intercepted one another,

Pyra conjuring and contorting her flames into various attacks while Glacia formed ice barriers to shield herself and launched icicles and ice fists towards her former fiancée.

For the most part, the two were fairly evenly matched. However, their methods differed in one particular way; Glacia tried to be as careful as possible to not injure Pyra, while Pyra wasn't holding back in the slightest. The more Glacia stayed on the defensive, the more it seemed to infuriate Pyra.

"Pathetic." Pyra scoffed as she melted away another one of Glacia's icicles. "C'mon, is this seriously the best you can do, Glacia?!"

"Pyra, please stop this!" Glacia begged, on the verge of tears. "I-I don't wanna hurt you-"

"YOU ALREADY HAVE!" Pyra bellowed as she fired a massive stream of fire towards Glacia, who was able to jump out of the way at the last second.

"Please! Don't do this!" Glacia kept trying to reason with the Magicat. "We, we both know this isn't you!"

"Silence!" Pyra growled, tossing another fireball at Glacia. "I don't want to hear any more crap coming from a cheating *bitch* like you!"

"I have *never* cheated on you!" Glacia yelled. "There was never any affair, Mara is nothing more than a friend to me! You and I were **engaged,** why would I have wanted to ruin everything?!"

"Stop with the lies!" Pyra grew angrier by the second. "At least have the guts to own up to your mistakes!"

"Pyra, I LOVE YOU!" Glacia sobbed, blocking another one of Pyra's flames with her ice. "I have never in my life loved anyone else other than you! You're *everything* to me, I wanted to spend the rest of my life with you! I… *I still do."*

This seemed to give Pyra pause, as she stopped attacking for a brief moment. Despite how on edge and angry she was, there was a small part of her that wanted to believe what Glacia was saying. Pyra couldn't deny that she still had strong feelings for Glacia; She was the love of her life.

But…

"Prove it." Pyra said sternly. "Prove that you're still standing by my side."

"W-what do you want me to do?" Glacia wondered.

“Help me take down Mara. We can make her pay for what she did to the Magicats, together!”

“What? No Pyra, Mara is innocent! She was trying to *save* the Magicats, she didn’t-”

“I knew it.” Pyra hissed, throwing another fireball towards Glacia. “You’d rather choose Mara over me. Even if you weren’t a cheater, you’re still a traitor!”

“Pyra, it’s not like that-” Glacia started, but Pyra kept throwing flame attacks at her, forcing her back on the defensive.

“I’ve had enough.” Pyra glared at Glacia after growing tired of her not fighting back properly, then looked at the fire down below. “Looks like my Inferno is approaching your castle as we speak. Let’s speed up the process, shall we?”

She used her control over fire to launch a pillar of flame from the Raging Inferno, aiming it towards the Kingdom of Snows’ castle.

“NO!” Glacia screamed. She rushed to the edge of the glacier and used all of her powers to form a gigantic ice barrier around her castle, managing to temporarily shield it from the flame. Glacia gasped in horror as she watched the Inferno melting through her ice like nothing, inching closer to the castle from below. “Pyra, y-you have to stop- AH!”

With Glacia having her back turned, Pyra took advantage of this by striking Glacia with a fireball from behind, injuring her and knocking her to the ground.

"Ngh…" Glacia tried to get up, seeing that Pyra was approaching her with a resolute stride. "Pyra, Pyra please… Don't…"

"You and I… We're *done,* Glacia." Pyra spat on the ground, glaring at Glacia with contempt and disgust. She raised her hands up, conjuring flames in them.

"P-Pyra…" Glacia wept as she saw the flames and the expression on Pyra's face. She wanted to run, but her injuries from Pyra's attack and the heartbreak from seeing what the woman she loved so much was about to do kept her glued to the ground. Her voice broke as she whispered: "P-please… I, I love y-you…"

"Goodbye, harlot." Pyra prepared to finish Glacia off. "When you get to Hell, *tell 'em to make some room."*

Glacia, accepting her fate, hung her head and closed her eyes. Pyra moved her arms towards Glacia, ready to incinerate her former fiancée. However, just as the flames were about to make contact with Glacia-

"H-huh?"

Pyra stared at her hands in stunned disbelief. The flames… They had completely *vanished.*

"What, what is going on?!" Pyra tried conjuring more flames, to no avail: Even when using all of her concentration, the most she could muster was a tiny flicker over her index finger. She also felt somehow weaker. "What happened to my powers?"

"Ah," Glacia gasped, opening her eyes and looking at Pyra as she realized what had just happened. "Mara… *She did it."*

"It can't be!" Pyra turned around, looking over the edge of the glacier and seeing that the Raging Inferno had dissipated altogether, like it had never even existed to begin with. It had melted some chunks of the glaciers surrounding the castle, but the damages for the most part had remained minor. "No no no, This… This is impossible, this is-"

"Mara severed your connection to the Sunstone." Glacia stated, walking up to Pyra from behind. "She deactivated it. Your powers are *gone,* Pyra."

"D-deactivated…" Pyra mumbled, still unable to believe what had transpired. She had no powers anymore, she was outclassed. She was *weak.*

“Pyra.” Glacia reached out to place her hand on Pyra’s shoulder. “It’s over. Please… Give it up. I- *Ahh!”*

*“**GRAAAHH!!**”* As soon as Glacia’s hand made contact with her shoulder, Pyra turned around and swiped at Glacia’s face with her claws, leaving three claw marks on her right cheek. While Glacia clutched her cheek, Pyra grabbed her by the throat with her right hand and aimed her left towards Glacia’s stomach.

“P-Pyra…” Glacia gasped as Pyra choked her. “D-don’t, p-please…”

“Hehehe… Y-ya know what?” Pyra chuckled menacingly. With her pupils dilated and her fangs bared, she looked absolutely unhinged. “I don’t *NEED* any powers to take you out, when I can just cut your stomach open and ***EVISCERATE YOU!**”*

“NO!” Desperate, Glacia used her powers and shot ice directly at Pyra’s eyes, temporarily blinding her.

“**GYAAHH!**” Pyra screamed in pain and clutched her eyes, letting go of Glacia. Glacia frantically backed away, breathing rapidly as she observed the thrashing Pyra. “You, you *BITCH!”*

“Pyra…”

Tears in her eyes, Glacia watched as Pyra regained her eyesight and charged towards her with her claws raised. Glacia was forced

to finally face the facts: The woman she had fallen in love with was long gone. Replaced by this… *Creature.* This *monster.*

Pyra was not going to stop until she had killed Glacia.

Glacia screamed, closed her eyes and extended her arms forward while Pyra was still running at her. Realizing what she had to do to ultimately stop the woman she had loved so much, Glacia used all of her strength to launch as much ice towards Pyra as possible…

"Well, here we are."

Pyra and Catra were observing the Kingdom of Snows from its tallest point, overlooking the entire kingdom and the vast icebergs and glaciers surrounding it. The cold air filling Pyra's lungs was oddly nostalgic, in a way. Being at the site of her centuries-long imprisonment felt strange to the princess.

"How are ya holding up, kid?" Pyra asked Catra, noticing how much she was shivering. "You've been awful quiet ever since we left the cave."

"I.. I-I'm fine." Catra mumbled, her teeth chattering. While she hated the cold, there was something else that was making her feel much more uneasy.

Ever since what had happened in the Brimstone Cave, the look Adora had given her… Catra had been so unsure of herself. She started having second thoughts about all of this, what she was doing. That she had crossed a line.

Catra wanted to free the Magicats. She wanted to find her family, her parents. But, was it really worth it? To throw *everything* she had away, just to find her mother? Catra didn't even know what she was going to say to her when she would eventually meet her.

Even if Catra found her mother and decided to then go back… Would Adora even *want* her to come back anymore? Or anyone else, for that matter?

"I thought we were friends! How could you do this to us? ***Betray us*** *like this?!"*

"'Friends?' Get a grip, kid! Etherians sided with the First Ones, this lot… They're all ***traitors*** *to the Magicats."*

"This… ***This isn't over."***

Catra wasn't just ruining her relationship with Adora, she was working against her friends now, too. Bow and Glimmer had saved her from Horde Prime, they had been the first people to accept Catra as one of them after her chip had been removed… And this is how she repays them.

It wasn't just the prospect of driving away all of her friends and Adora that was eating at Catra, either. Ever since Pyra had gotten her powers back, she seemed somehow *different.* Catra remembered what had happened back in the Brimstone Cave.

Pyra had been fully willing to kill Bow, Glimmer, Frosta and Huntara. Only stopping because Catra begged her to. Catra knew Pyra could be tough and ruthless, but this…

What if Adora had been right about Pyra, all along? *What if Pyra really was-*

"Catra?"

"H-huh?"

Pyra had placed both of her hands on Catra's shoulders and shaken her gently. She was looking at Catra with a concerned, slightly restless expression on her face.

"C'mon, what's bothering you?" Pyra asked. "I can see that something's eating at ya, kid."

"Nothing, I told you I'm fine." Catra muttered. She looked aside, avoiding making eye contact with Pyra.

Pyra sighed and then asked: "Is this because of what happened in the cave? When I attacked those guys?"

"'*Those guys?*'" Catra glared at Pyra, growing upset. "They're my *friends!* And you, you tried to… You tried to *kill* them!"

"Fine, I might've gotten a little carried away." Pyra admitted. "But I don't understand why this is such a big deal to you, they were fine! She-Ra was there to heal any harm I might've caused them-"

"Might've? Pyra, you *burned* Sparkles' face!" Catra yelled. "You could've seriously hurt her!"

"She was about to punch your face in!" Pyra countered. "What, was I supposed to just let her beat ya into a pulp, huh?"

"She, she had *every* right to be mad at me." Catra said sadly. "What I pulled to get us to the Sunstone, it… It was *really* underhanded. And Sparkles, she… She's trusted me for so long, way more than I deserve. She and Arrow Boy, they're the closest things I have to best friends."

"Look, I get it. Mara was like that to me." Pyra said, feeling sympathy for Catra. "But she turned on me. And sooner or later, those friends of yours… They would've done the same to you. History is written by the winners, kid. And Etherians sided with the First Ones, they've written the Magicats out of history books."

“But-”

“Remember what I told ya, Catra. Friends are disposable. Family is what matters most. That’s why we’re doing all this, remember?”

“...Yeah. I know.” Catra nodded meekly. “But, it still doesn’t feel right. That I tricked them like that.”

“Ends justify the means, kid.” Pyra smiled. “It’s thanks to your clever thinking that the Magicats are gonna be set free, for the first time in centuries. You should feel proud of that! Speaking of,” She looked at the Kingdom of Snows down below. “We should probably get started, eh?”

“Why uh,” Catra tilted her head. “Why did we come all the way up here? You never explained that.”

“I…” Pyra hesitated for a moment. She sighed, and then confessed to Catra: “The Magicats, they’re buried DEEP underneath the Kingdom of Snows, trapped in a small crevice. We’re gonna need to melt a considerable amount of the ice away to set them free, worst case scenario… We may need to melt *the entire kingdom.”*

“W-we’re *destroying* the Kingdom of Snows?” Catra gasped. “Why, why didn’t you tell me about this sooner?!”

“Because I wanted to make sure you were in!” Pyra replied. “I was afraid that if you knew the ramifications, you’d try to talk me out of doing this.”

“You, you what-”

“I know it wasn’t fair to you.” Pyra said apologetically. “And I’m sorry. But… I *needed* you, I needed my powers back. So we could do this, free our people.”

“A-are you *sure* this is a good idea?” Catra asked, staring at the kingdom down below. “Is there really no other way?”

“If there was, we wouldn’t be here right now.” Pyra claimed. “I wanted a good vantage point of the entire surrounding area, so I can control the flames to the best of my ability, try to mitigate the damages. Catra,” She held Catra’s hand. “After we’ve done this, we’ll go find your mother. I promise.”

“I…” Catra still felt uneasy about this plan, but she had no choice. She was already committed to helping Pyra save the Magicats. “Okay.”

“That’s the spirit.” Pyra pat Catra’s shoulder, then turned back around to look over the edge. She raised her arms to the sky and

told Catra: “Now, ya might wanna stay back for a bit. Things are gonna get *heated* over here.”

Catra hesitantly stepped backwards several feet, watching as Pyra concentrated her powers into her hands and yelled as she fired out a massive amount of crimson flames that formed the shape of a gigantic dragon up in the sky: *The Raging Inferno.*

Catra gasped, stunned and in awe, as the Inferno dug itself into the other end of the Kingdom of Snows, exploding into an ocean of fire that was melting away the ice and snow from the snowy plains around it, slowly spreading around.

Catra had always been on thin ice with Frosta, after what she had done during the Princess Prom many years ago. But if she and Pyra actually destroyed her kingdom, Catra knew Frosta would never be able to forgive her.

And she feared that Adora wouldn’t be able to, either.

“At last.” Pyra whispered to herself, so quietly Catra couldn’t hear her. “I will have my vengeance… *Glacia.”*

Bow was standing at the entrance of the library that was hidden away in the Whispering Woods, with Adora and Glimmer behind

him. He knocked on the door and waited patiently, until-

"Bow!"

"Hey-" Bow barely managed to open his mouth before he was held in a tight hug by his fathers. "W-whoa, easy!"

"Oh Bow, it's so good to see you!" Lance said, elated to see his son. "It's been way too long!"

"How have you been?" George asked after he and Lance let go of Bow, equally happy to see him. "Things are going okay in Bright Moon?"

"Y-yeah, I've been doing well, thanks." Bow replied, then apologetically added: "Sorry I haven't gotten in touch in a while, I've been meaning to call you but I've been busy, and-"

"No need to apologize!" Lance pat Bow on the back. "We're just happy to see you here! Oh," He finally noticed Adora and Glimmer standing behind Bow. "Glimmer! Adora!"

"H-hi." Adora said, waving at him slightly awkwardly.

“Hey, Lance.” Glimmer giggled, also waving at Lance before turning to Bow’s other father. “Hey, George. Long time no see!”

“It’s an honor, *Queen Glimmer.”* George said playfully. “We hope our Bow has been treating you well!”

“Oh, he’s been an absolute sweetheart.” Glimmer stated lovingly, holding Bow’s hand while Bow placed a quick kiss on her forehead. “A great friend, and an amazing partner!”

“I’ve never been happier in my life.” Bow said to his dads, smiling wide. “Or more in love.”

“Aww, we know that feeling all too well!” Lance squeed, his eyes sparkling.

“So,” George cleared his throat and then nudged Bow with his elbow. “When’s the wedding?”

“W-wedding?” Bow and Glimmer blushed in unison, and Bow stammered: “W-what do you mean haha, w-we uh-”

“Yeah! When can we call ourselves the queen’s father-in-laws?” Lance asked excitedly.

“Just a warning: You’ll have to deal with our dad jokes, too.” George said to Glimmer.

“W-we uh, we haven’t really thought about it.” Glimmer said, scratching the back of her head. “Well okay, we have THOUGHT about it but we haven’t made any concrete plans or…”

Adora felt a little uneasy standing there, she had this nagging feeling like she was intruding on something and shouldn’t have been here.

“Adora!” Suddenly George walked up to Adora and gave her a quick hug, then asked her concerned: “How are you doing? You look a bit troubled.”

“Uhh,” Adora started, taken back by the looks George and Lance were giving her. “It’s… It’s been a rough week. There’s a new enemy that we’ve been fighting, she’s planning to wipe out Etheria, Catra broke up with me and-”

“Oh, we’re very sorry to hear that.” Lance said and sympathetically pat Adora on the shoulder. “Breakups can always be a hard time for anyone, even She-Ra!”

“It’s thankfully not all been bad.” Adora managed to muster up a slight smile. “I uh, I’m pregnant.”

“Oh, congratulations! That’s wonderful!” Lance and George both enthusiastically congratulated Adora. George continued: “Having a baby is such an exciting time, I still remember when Bow was a-”

“W-we didn’t come here just to catch up.” Bow hastily cut his dad off, not wanting to be embarrassed in front of Adora and Glimmer. “We need help with something related to Etheria’s history.”

“That much you told us in your message.” George remarked. “So, what exactly-”

“Oh, I’ll go make us some tea!” Lance suggested, heading back inside of the library.

“Dad, there’s no need to- Okay nevermind.” Bow sighed as his father ran off.

“Come on in, make yourselves at home.” George said, leading Adora, Bow and Glimmer into the library.

“So, how have things been here?” Glimmer wondered. “Seems like the place is doing okay.”

“Things have been good.” George replied, as the four of them sat down on the couches by the coffee table. “It took a long while to repair all the damages Horde Prime’s forces did to the library, but

we got there in the end. I think the rebuild actually helped me and Lance get even closer...”

Adora looked around the library and whistled. “It’s a miracle all of the books and scrolls survived the Horde’s onslaught.”

“We made sure to hide as many of them as we could when they attacked!” Said Lance, who arrived carrying a tray with a teapot, empty cups and a plate of cookies that he placed on the coffee table before sitting next to George. “The information we have here is the most valuable thing we own… Right after each other.” He smiled lovingly at George, placing his hand over George’s.

“Speaking of information,” George looked at Adora, Bow and Glimmer. “What did you need our help for?”

“R-right!” Bow quickly finished the sip of tea he had just taken, before starting: “So, like Adora said earlier we’ve been dealing with a new enemy. She’s… Apparently been frozen for a thousand years, from the time when Mara was She-Ra.”

“A thousand years?” Lance gasped, his jaw dropping. "My, she must be a real wealth of information then!"

“We were wondering,” Adora continued. “Have you two ever heard the name ‘Pyra’ before? She’s the Fire Princess.”

“Pyra?” George thought intensely for a moment. “We’ve studied Etheria’s history from that time period extensively, but I don’t recall having heard of her before.”

“We have heard of a Fire Princess, though!” Lance claimed. “According to legend, she was the ruler of a kingdom called Candila, and channeled her powers via her runestone, the Spirit Ember. Over time she grew mad with power, and after discovering the woman she had loved had moved on from her she ended up destroying Candila! Rumor has it, the Spirit Ember can still be found in the ruins of her kingdom.”

“Hmmm, that *does* kinda sound like Pyra.” Adora pondered. “But her runestone’s called the Sunstone, and it was hidden away within the Brimstone Cave in the Crimson Waste by Mara. Don’t recall Pyra or Catra saying anything about Candila, either.”

“It was a legend, like Lance said.” Glimmer reminded her. “Perhaps the story has changed over the course of centuries as details have gotten hazy?”

“That’s entirely possible.” Lance admitted. “Regardless, the name ‘Pyra’ has never been brought up in relation to the legend of the Fire Princess.”

“What about Glacia?”

“Glacia?” George raised an eyebrow. “The Ice Queen, who ruled the Kingdom of Snows with an iron fist a millennium ago? I cannot recall having seen her be mentioned alongside the Fire Princess, either…”

Adora, Bow and Glimmer shared concerned looks. It seems that whatever had transpired between Glacia and Pyra all those centuries ago had been lost to the sands of time.

“Alright then,” Adora took a deep breath, getting ready to ask the next question: “This might be a long shot, but… Have you ever heard of Magicats?”

“Magicats?” Lance whispered, his eyes widening slightly. “You’re more attuned to history than I thought, Adora!”

“Huh?”

“George, could you go get the-”

“On it.” George stood up and began going through the library bookshelves. “I know it’s in here somewhere… There!” He picked up a green, slightly dusty tome that he brought over to the others. “There have been seldom mentions of the Magicats in all our decades of going over Etheria’s history, but we do have some in this book here!”

“You do?” Glimmer asked, excited.

“In fact, mentions of the Magicats have been so rare most other historians have never even heard of them, either!” Lance elaborated. “Where did you-”

“Pyra.” Adora explained. “She’s a Magicat. And, apparently… So is Catra.”

“R-really?” George gasped while going through the book. “How did we never put two and two together…”

“Catra didn’t know until Pyra told her, either.”

“What does the book say about the Magicats?” Bow asked his fathers.

“The Magicats are a secretive, very reclusive race of people.” George said. “Their history is veiled in such mystery which rivals even that of the First Ones, in fact it is said that they’ve lived on Etheria long before the First Ones ever settled here.”

“Long ago, they had a kingdom on the surface of Etheria.” Lance continued. “While the Magicats mostly kept to themselves even back then, they were still living peacefully with the other kingdoms. But then, a thousand years ago…”

“What happened?” Glimmer asked quietly. Adora was getting worried that whatever had been written down in the book would corroborate what Pyra had told Catra.

“Disaster struck.” George explained. “Exact details aren’t mentioned, but some sort of cataclysmic event wiped out their kingdom and put the Magicats on the brink of extinction.”

“I-is there any mention of She-Ra having played any part in that?” Adora wondered cautiously.

“She-Ra?” Lance raised an eyebrow. “If she was the one responsible for what happened to the Magicats I’d figure *you* would know, Adora!”

“Like I said, there’s no mention of what exactly happened.” George said. “There have been theories of earthquakes, tidal waves, a volcanic eruption, a hurricane… But certainly nothing related to She-Ra.”

“What happened to the Magicats after the disaster?” Bow asked. “They couldn’t have gone fully extinct, otherwise Catra wouldn’t be here today.”

“Very astute, Bow!” Lance grinned playfully. “While many Magicats perished, there were a handful of survivors who had decided to

form a new settlement underground, isolated from most of Etheria, since they assumed the surface world wouldn't be safe for them after their kingdom fell. Eventually they managed to repopulate and formed a new kingdom in that settlement!"

"Most Magicats have chosen to remain in isolation," George continued. "But occasionally, one of them would wander to the surface. That's how people have managed to gather even this small bit of information about them!"

"Where is that settlement?" Glimmer asked, fidgeting with her empty teacup.

"We do not know." Lance shrugged. "Magicats are a reclusive bunch, and even those who've visited the outside world kept the location secret in order to protect the rest of their kind. We don't even know where their old kingdom used to be."

"Is, i-is there any chance that the location…" Adora muttered. "Could this new settlement be hidden under the Kingdom of Snows?"

"Huh?" Lance and George both looked at Adora with a confused expression. George answered Adora's question: "That seems… *Extremely* unlikely. Magicats *hate* the cold, they tend to prefer warmer climates. If anything, the Kingdom of Snows would've been the **last** place they'd have built their settlement."

“And those Magicats who’ve been to the surface… None of them ever mentioned that their people had been trapped or imprisoned there, centuries ago?”

“You’ve been reading too many conspiracy theories, Adora.” Lance snarked, crossing his arms. “From what we’ve learned the Magicats could return to the surface at any time should they wish to, only things keeping them in their settlement is generational trauma from the cataclysm and their desire to stay safe! Nobody’s keeping them trapped or locked up.”

“Yes!” Adora jumped up and cheered with great enthusiasm. “I knew it! Pyra has been lying to Catra all along!”

“Uhh, you seem… Oddly happy about that.” George remarked. “What exactly is-”

“Pyra’s been taking advantage of Catra’s desire to find her family.” Bow explained. “She told Catra that the Magicats had been trapped under the Kingdom of Snows centuries ago by Mara, and that she needed her control over fire back so she could free them.”

“Pyra’s the first Magicat Catra’s ever met.” Adora said quietly. “She promised to help Catra find her mother if Catra helps her, and that’s… That’s why we broke up. But this means,” She cheered up again. “I have a chance of getting her back! Once Catra learns Pyra’s been lying to her face, she’ll see that I was right about her the entire time!”

“Plus, it means we have free reign to stop Pyra’s plan of destroying the Kingdom of Snows.” Glimmer concluded. “It would’ve felt weird if we doomed the Magicats to an eternity in an icy prison, but knowing they’re not there…”

“Seems like this Pyra is quite the character.” Lance said. “George and I wish you the best of luck with stopping whatever she’s planning!”

“Thanks.” Adora smiled. “Now, all we need to do is find Catra and Pyra before they reach the Kingdom of Snows, and-”

“Hm?” Bow noticed that his tracker pad was ringing. “Getting a call from Frosta, hang on…”

As soon as he answered the call, he heard Frosta’s voice frantically shouting: *“PYRA’S HERE!!”*

“What?!” Adora and Glimmer gasped.

“My subjects spotted a massive amount of fire on the outer edge of the kingdom!” Frosta explained. She appeared to be holding a piece of paper in her hand. “It’s unnaturally red, and nothing we try seems to put it out! Guys, we need you here *NOW!”*

“No…” Adora mumbled. “We, we were too late.”

“There’s still time, Adora!” Bow encouraged her. “As long as the Kingdom isn’t completely destroyed, we’ve got a chance to stop Pyra.”

“Exactly!” Glimmer nodded. “C’mon, we gotta get going!”

“Be careful out there, you three.” George said to them. “Bow-”

“I know.” Bow gently smiled at his dads. “I-I love you both too. But we’ve gotta go.”

“S-see you later, Bow!” Lance tearfully bid them farewell. “You as well, Adora and Glimmer!”

Adora and Glimmer waved at Lance and George, before Glimmer teleported herself, Adora and Bow to the Kingdom of Snows.

Time was of the essence. If they couldn’t stop Pyra quickly…

Etheria would be doomed.

Chapter End Notes

I couldn't resist throwing a nod to the "Legend of the Fire Princess" graphic novel, hence Lance's line explaining the 'legend' when the squad ask him and George about Pyra.

As for Magicats hating the cold, every cat owner knows what happens when their cat asks to go outside while its snowing :D Pyra's a special case due to her fire powers and her former relationship with Glacia.

Chapter 11: Adora v. Catra

Chapter Summary

The princesses band together in order to save the Kingdom of Snows. Adora goes after Pyra to stop the Raging Inferno before it's too late, while Pyra orders Catra to keep Adora busy so she can finish the job. Adora and Catra end up facing off, and Adora seizes the opportunity to finally talk things through with her girlfriend.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I… I think… I-I think, I did it…"

Mara, having transformed into She-Ra, had made her way to the ruins of Magicat Kingdom. While all of the remaining Magicats had vanished, the Sunstone still sat proudly at the center of the kingdom where Pyra had left it.

Following Light Hope's instructions, She-Ra had focused and pointed the Sword of Protection at the Sunstone, launching a beam of energy from it which allowed her to interface with the runestone. It took a lot of time, effort and concentration, but with Light Hope's assistance She-Ra had finally succeeded in turning the Sunstone offline, deactivating it and rendering it dormant.

"I… I h-hope, Glacia… Glacia's okay…" She-Ra panted, leaning on her sword. After resting for a moment, she returned to her ship and piloted it to the Kingdom of Snows. It took her a while to locate Glacia amidst all the the ice and snow, but eventually…

“There!”

She-Ra landed the ship atop the tallest glacier in the kingdom, a bit of distance away from a figure the ship’s radar had managed to pick up. As soon as she exited the ship she could hear Glacia wailing in the distance, and immediately ran up to see if she was alright.

“Glacia!” She-Ra called out. It was windy and snowing all the way up there, obscuring her vision. “Glacia, are you-”

When She-Ra got close enough to see clearly, she gasped and nearly dropped her sword out of shock from what she was witnessing.

Glacia had fallen to her knees, her face buried in her hands and bawling hysterically. In front of her was a massive block of ice, and in the center of it, encased in all that ice, was-

“Pyra…” She-Ra mumbled, tearing up as she saw what had become of the woman who had been one of her closest friends. She noticed the burns all over Glacia’s body, and used the Sword of Protection’s powers to heal the Ice Princess before transforming back to Mara.

“Glacia,” Mara whispered, hugging her tight. “Glacia, it’s, it’s gonna be…”

Mara wanted to say things were going to be okay, but couldn’t bring herself to do it after seeing the state Pyra was in.

“M-Mara… I, ngh, I-I…” Glacia sobbed against Mara’s shoulder. “I-I had n-no choice, she… S-she was gonna… I-I loved her. *I loved her so much.”*

“I know.” Mara’s voice broke. “I know, Glacia.”

Eventually, once Glacia had calmed down slightly, Mara let go of her. Glacia sniffled, staring at the frozen Pyra with utter heartbreak on her face.

“It’s, it’s been done.” Mara stated. “The Sunstone has been deactivated. Etheria is safe.”

Glacia didn’t respond, she just nodded absently as Mara continued:

“It’s too dangerous to be left out in the open, if someone finds it... I, I’m going to hide it. There’s a cave in the Crimson Waste that nobody dares go to, it should stay safe there.”

“Yeah.” Glacia mumbled, without even bothering to look at Mara.

“Glacia, I-” Mara reached out trying to place her hand on Glacia’s shoulder, but Glacia slapped her hand away and shot a nasty glare at her. Mara sighed apologetically. “I’m sorry. This, this is all my-”

“Mara.” Glacia said sternly, turning her back on Mara. “Please. *Don’t.* Just… *Just,* ***don’t.”***

Mara nodded, keeping her mouth shut. The two stood there in silence, until Glacia eventually spoke up again:

“Mara, I… I think I’m pregnant.”

“W-what?”

“The night before Magicat Kingdom fell, Pyra… She, she came over to my castle, we spent the night together and we had…” Glacia voice was hoarse. “Yeah.”

“Oh…” Mara covered her mouth with her hands and stared at the frozen Pyra, horrified by the realization of what exactly had transpired here. “A-and it’s-”

“Hers. Yeah.”

“Glacia-”

“I’ll help you move the Sunstone.” Glacia turned back around to Mara, with a cold expression on her face. “We make sure nobody can get their hands on it again. After that… I think it’s for the best if we don't meet anymore, Mara.”

“Eh?” Mara was shocked. “Glacia, what are you-”

“Please.” Glacia teared up again. “It’s, it’s too painful for me.”

Mara, disheartened and riddled with guilt, hung her head and nodded meekly. She turned around getting ready to head back to her ship.

“Glacia, I’m… I’m sorry.”

“Yeah.” Glacia wiped her tears. “Me too.”

Mara walked back towards her ship. Glacia was about to follow, when she gave one last look at the block of ice Pyra was encased in. Then, she glanced at her wrist and realized she was still wearing the obsidian bracelet that Pyra had given her when they got engaged on her left arm.

She placed her right hand over it, getting ready to remove the bracelet but after thinking for a moment, she sighed and opted to keep it on her wrist. She stared at Pyra's frozen body with determination and stated to herself:

"I promise… *I am never going to fall in love again."*

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

As soon as she touched down on the Kingdom of Snows with Bow and Glimmer, Adora had summoned her sword and transformed into She-Ra. The Best Friend Squad caught up with the other princesses, who had grouped up outside of Frosta's castle.

"Guys! You're here!" Scorpia called out as she spotted the three of them getting closer. "About time!"

"Sorry we're late." Glimmer apologized. "What's the situation?"

"Umm, *THAT* is the situation, I guess." Mermista pointed towards the thick plume of black smoke in the distance, where the Inferno was eating away at the surrounding icy plains.

“Any sign of Pyra or Catra?” Bow wondered.

“My subjects said they saw some shady figures over the peak of the kingdom, that glacier up there.” Frosta explained, showing the direction of the glacier.

“Adora, what’s the plan here?” Perfuma asked She-Ra. “You, you *do* have a plan, right?”

“Y-yeah.” She-Ra nodded. She thought for a second, then gave orders: “Alright. Bow, you take Perfuma, Scorpia and Netossa and try to evacuate as many people from here as possible. Glimmer, you’ll go with Frosta, Mermista and Spinnerella and do whatever you can to contain the fire!”

“And… What will you do?” Spinnerella wondered. She-Ra deteminedly gazed at the glacier up above.

“I’m gonna go stop Pyra.” She-Ra stated. “As long as she’s still out there, Etheria won’t be safe.”

“What about Catra?” Glimmer asked.

“What *about* Catra?”

“Are you able to-”

“I’ve told you a dozen times, yes! I can still fight while pregnant, I’m not gonna sit by and let Pyra destroy-”

“No, I meant… Are you able to *fight* **Catra?**” Glimmer gently touched She-Ra’s hand.

She-Ra hesitated for a second, sighed and told Glimmer: “I’ve fought her before, haven’t I?”

“Yeah, but things are different now, Adora.” Bow said. “Back then, you two weren’t in love and… You also weren’t *carrying her child.”*

“I, I’m going to stop Pyra.” She-Ra reaffirmed her statement, even if her voice wavered. “And if Catra’s gonna stand in my way, I’ll… I’ll knock some sense into her if I have to.”

“Let’s get going, team!” Netossa said to the other princesses, who split up into two groups. Bow and Glimmer still stood by She-Ra’s side for a moment.

“Adora-”

“Guys, I can do this. I promise.” She-Ra gave her friends a reassuring smile, then ran off and started making her way towards the glacier where Pyra would be waiting.

Where *Catra* would be waiting.

“Alright.” Bow placed his hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “You ready, Glimmer?”

“Bow,” Glimmer was slightly trembling, looking unsure of herself. “Can… C-can I ask you something?”

“I uh, sure.” Bow said. “But we don’t have much time here, we-”

“If we survive this,” Glimmer held Bow’s hands and asked him: “Will you… *Will you marry me?”*

“G-Glimmer…” Bow muttered, completely taken back. His eyes got misty and he was smiling brighter and more lovingly than ever before as he said to Glimmer: “I will. I promise.”

Glimmer smiled back, and the two shared a tender, passionate kiss. Once they pulled back, Glimmer whispered:

“I, I love you.”

“I love you too, Glimmer.”

“Hehe, he…”

Pyra was controlling the flames from afar, concentrating and using her powers to keep them stoked and making sure they spread in every direction, quietly chuckling to herself. While watching the ice and snow melt away little by little, she felt so satisfied with herself.

She was going to *win.* She was going to have her revenge. And this time, *Mara and Glacia weren’t around to stop her.*

“How, how much longer is this gonna take?” Asked Catra, who was rubbing her arm and still feeling conflicted about Pyra’s plan.

“Patience, dear!” Pyra said playfully, with a hint of menace to her voice. “I have to keep the fire under control, and that takes time.”

“R-right…”

"We're not in any hurry here." Pyra gloated. "After all, there's nobody here who could possibly stop us. By the time the princesses notice something's up, it'll already be far too late-"

"Uhh, I wouldn't be so sure about that." Catra pointed in the distance, where she saw Glimmer, Frosta, Mermista and Spinnerella approaching the Raging Inferno and launching their magical attacks towards it. "I think we've been spotted."

"Ugh." Pyra groaned. "But no matter. The Raging Inferno is inextinguishable, they can tire themselves out all they like but only *I* am able to put it out! And I'm not planning to do that for a looong time…"

Catra stared at Glimmer in the distance and whispered to herself: "Stay safe, Sparkles."

She looked around and then noticed Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma and Netossa leading civilians out of the Kingdom of Snows.

"Seems they're evacuating the kingdom."

"Hmph, *fools."* Pyra hissed. "There's no place on Etheria where they'll be safe from my-"

"Wait," Catra looked at the two groups again. "I don't see Adora anywhere."

“Huh?” Pyra was alarmed. “If she’s not at the fire, and she’s not helping civilians, then…”

She looked down the mountain trail that led to the top of the glacier, and much to her chagrin found out her suspicions were correct: She-Ra was running up the path towards them.

“Ugh, she’s such a *pest.* Catra, be a dearie and stall her for a bit, would ya?”

“E-eh?” Catra gasped. “Stall her?”

“Make sure she can’t get here until I’m done.” Pyra elaborated. “Keep her busy.”

“What, what do you want me to do?”

“Just, distract her. Knock her out or something, *anything* so she can’t make it here in time!”

“You… You want me to *fight* Adora?” Catra asked.

"I don't care what you do!" Pyra yelled. "Fight her, *kill her* if you have to! If she gets here before I've had time to melt the kingdom, the Magicats will remain trapped *forever!"*

"B-but-"

"Do ya want me to help you find your mom or not?! Then you'll **DO AS I SAY!**"

Catra stared at Pyra, her pupils widened out of shock. Pyra's demeanor changed from angry to apologetic as she sighed and said: "Please, Catra. You, you've gotta help me here, I-I need to do this. I've waited for so long…"

While still torn, Catra eventually relented and muttered: "Okay." before turning around, running down the mountain path to intercept Adora before she can make it to the top.

Catra needed to do this. If she was ever going to find her family, she needed to do everything she could to help Pyra, keep Adora at bay.

But… *Was she capable of fighting her?* Catra had done it several times during the war, but things were so different now.

Catra wanted to find her people. But she didn't want to hurt Adora.

Not anymore.

She-Ra had made it halfway through the trail to the top of the glacier. There was still a long way to go, but she was starting to feel exhaustion kick in. Even a warrior as strong as her would still have her limits.

She-Ra paused to catch her breath, then looked down and placed her left hand over her stomach.

"Don't worry." She-Ra whispered. "Mommy is gonna keep you safe. I'll take care of Pyra and then…" She thought about Catra. "Then I'll talk with your other mom, I promise. Things are going to be okay."

She-Ra turned her gaze to the top of the glacier, where Pyra would be waiting. She was desperately hoping that Catra wouldn't be in her way.

She needed to do this. If she was ever going to save Etheria, she needed to do everything she could to stop Pyra before it was too late.

But she didn't want to hurt Catra. Not anymore.

She-Ra kept going up the trail, eventually coming to a wider, flat area. On the other side the trail kept leading up, but She-Ra noticed that someone was blocking her way forward and gasped.

"Catra."

"Hey, Adora."

She-Ra and Catra were standing on opposite sides of the path, just staring at each other in uncomfortable silence. She-Ra noticed that Catra looked just as troubled as she herself did.

"What are you doing?" She-Ra eventually asked Catra.

Catra glanced aside, gathering her thoughts before turning back and replying with determination: "What I must."

"Catra, I-" She-Ra saw Catra raising her claws and taking a stance, ready to fight, and was extremely distraught. Her voice broke and it took all her energy not to tear up as she begged Catra: "Please, don't… Don't make me do this."

Catra was in great internal turmoil, she clearly didn't want to do this either. But she had no options.

"...Raise your sword, Adora."

She-Ra's hands were shaking, the grip on her sword being loose. She sniffled, then thought of what was at stake here and steeled her resolve, tightening her hold on her blade and steadying herself.

"Alright, let's… *Let's get this over with."*

She needed to stop Pyra, no matter the cost.

After a moment of staring each other down, She-Ra and Catra charged towards one another and began their battle.

Unlike their fights in the past, both of them remained completely silent with even Catra throwing none of her usual quips. Something about battling Catra, after all these years, was oddly nostalgic for She-Ra. She thought back to her past in the Horde, Adora and Catra training together.

She remembered how back then, any time the two would have an argument about something they would sneak into the training grounds and duke it out with staffs to settle things. She-Ra wondered if something similar was happening now as well.

She-Ra noticed something else, too. She had been intentionally holding back, mostly just blocking Catra's blows and avoiding hurting her. But this time, unlike every time she had fought Catra during the war, she could tell… *Catra was holding back too.*

Something about the memories of their past battles, the knowledge that Catra didn't want to hurt her either, was easing She-Ra's mind ever so slightly. She found herself slowly getting into it, almost finding their current fight… *Fun.*

"Heh, you're slipping, Catra!" She-Ra said playfully, after blocking another blow from Catra's claws.

"Speak for yourself, Adora." Catra replied with a slight, cocky smile. Just like She-Ra, she seemed to be more at ease now as well. "I know you're holding back, you could crush me into atoms if you were fighting at full power!"

"Maybe." She-Ra couldn't help but smile herself. Despite everything that had happened during the past several days, even though she and Catra were on different sides once again, she felt this *warmth* inside of her that had been gone ever since Catra had left.

She-Ra wanted to tell Catra how much she loved her. She wanted to tell her about Pyra's lies and ultimate goal, she wanted to tell her about the baby…

But she knew Catra wouldn't be receptive to anything she says, not truly, until they had talked everything else through first.

"Catra," She-Ra started as she had her sword swing blocked by Catra's claws, with a remorseful expression on her face. "I'm really sorry about what I said back then. I genuinely am."

"Adora-"

"I, I shouldn't have dredged up your past like that, I was just… I was so angry and worked up, and I just, I-I wasn't thinking straight."

Catra swiped her claws at She-Ra, who blocked them with her sword, and said: "I know I've messed up. I spent so long trying to make things right, I tried my best to change and become better, to move on. But you still hold my past against me, do you…" She sighed, her eyes getting misty. "Do you have *any idea* how much that hurts, Adora?"

"Catra, I don't-"

"I've hurt so many people, I know that. A-and I know I could never make things right with everyone, that there's still people who can't forgive me for what I've done. But you know what?" Catra deflected She-Ra's sword with a kick. "*I didn't care.* It didn't matter to me how many people would still hate me, because even

if nobody else on Etheria would forgive me or trust me ever again I thought at least… At least *you* would."

"I **do** trust you, Catra." She-Ra said sadly. "And I know you've changed, that you wouldn't do those things anymore. I didn't mean what I said, at least not in the way I said it. I just," She blocked Catra's punch with her bracelet. "You, you've had this tendency to act impulsively sometimes, working on instinct. Making decisions without thinking the ramifications through first. And I know it… Because I'm the same way. A-and I thought you were sliding into that with Pyra, and I wanted you to see it."

"Adora…" Catra muttered. She had a hard time believing her girlfriend was still capable of trusting her, after everything she's done. After the way Catra had walked out on her.

"But it was still a low blow." She-Ra admitted. "And unfair. I know how much pain and guilt you still feel over your actions, I-I know you're not that person anymore. And I promise, I'm… I'm gonna do my best to change, too. I trust you, and I want to be someone that *you* can trust as well."

"Do you really trust me?" Catra wondered. "Even… Even after everything I've done? The way I tricked you guys to find the Sunstone?"

"You don't always make it easy." She-Ra snarked affectionately. "But… Yeah, I do."

Catra jumped backwards as She-Ra swung her sword at her, then said: "It, it wasn't exactly my finest moment, either."

"Huh?"

"Our argument. I said some really hurtful and unfair things to you, too. What I said about your ancestry, and Shadow Weaver and…"

"C-Catra…"

"I'm sorry." Catra apologized. "I shouldn't have blamed you for what the First Ones or Mara did centuries ago. Or imply what Shadow Weaver did to you wasn't as bad as the way she treated me, I… I know how much she hurt you, Adora. I was just, I was so disappointed and angry that you didn't wanna help, I went right back to my old habits and intentionally tried to hurt you and get under your skin, and- And I shouldn't do stuff like that anymore, I-I should be better. I ***need*** to be better."

Catra lunged towards She-Ra from up above, with She-Ra once again blocking Catra's claws.

"I think we both said things that we regret." She-Ra stated. "Things we wish we could take back. We were both pretty heated and inflexible, neither of us was willing to hear the other out. But," She smiled again. "I think we can fix that."

"You do?"

"We both have things that we need to improve upon. We could try… I dunno, couples therapy? Counseling? I'm not sure what it's called, but I'd be willing to give it a shot regardless. Anything to help fix our relationship."

"That's… Awfully mature, coming from you." Catra joked. She then asked, both curious and hopeful: "W-would you really be willing to do something like that?"

"Of course!" She-Ra nodded as she threw a punch towards Catra who dodged it. "You said it yourself: If we can't trust each other, then what's the point? And I wanna show you that I *do* trust you, and also prove that I'm worthy of your trust. No matter what it takes."

"Adora, I…" Catra sighed, closing her eyes for a moment. "I've been so worked up, ever since I learned I'm a Magicat. A-and if I hadn't met Pyra, I still wouldn't know… *Anything* about myself. I'd still have no leads on finding my-"

"I know, Catra." She-Ra said quietly. "You want to find your family, more than anything in the world. I'm sorry I didn't truly understand how important this was to you before. But I do now, and I'm still willing to help you find them, just like I've always been. I'll do everything I can, if… If you just come back."

“D-do you really want me back?” Catra wondered; It was getting hard for her to hold back her tears. “Even though I left you, and how much I’ve hurt you time and time again, y-you still want me?”

“Of course I do!” She-Ra was the first of them to break the facade, having teared up already. “Catra, *I **love** you!* I, I-I love you *so much.”*

“I… I love you too, Adora.” Catra cried, tears streaming down her face. *“I always have.* Y-you’re *everything* to me, I never wanted to leave you! O-or Sparkles, or Arrow Boy or-”

“They all miss you, Catra.” She-Ra stated. “Just like I do. And they want you to come back home. Please…”

Catra’s internal conflict reached it’s peak, her loyalty to Pyra and the Magicats versus her love for Adora. She clutched her head, gritting her teeth in anguish trying to decide what to do. What she **should** do.

“Catra, *please!”* She-Ra pleaded with her, lowering her sword and stepping closer to Catra. “We, we need to stop this before anyone else gets hurt! I don’t, I don’t want to fight you anymore!”

“I… I don’t wanna fight, either.” Catra said. Despite how much she loved Adora, she had made up her mind. “But I promised I would help Pyra, I… I can’t go back on that, *I can’t let her down!”*

“Catra-”

“The Magicats need me, I-I have no choice!”

“Ah!”

She-Ra saw Catra swiping her claws at her from up above and was getting ready to block it with both arms, but instead Catra juked her out and crouched down.

“I’m sorry, Adora!” Catra sobbed apologetically, clenching her right fist. “P-please, please don’t hate me for this when you wake up.”

“W-what are you-” She-Ra glanced down and had a horrifying realization.

Catra was aiming a punch directly at her stomach.

*“**CATRA, NO!**”* She-Ra screamed at the top of her lungs.

Right before Catra’s fist could make contact with her She-Ra’s entire body began glowing brightly, emitting an ethereal light that erupted out of her in all directions. The shockwave from this

magical blast was enough to launch Catra backwards at great velocity, screaming as she flew through the air until she eventually landed face first on snow, knocked out cold.

"Haah… Haah… W, what..."

The burst of light had drained She-Ra's energy, causing her to revert back to Adora. She fell to her knees on the snow, breathing heavily and still reeling from the experience.

"Oh, o-oh sweetie, I-I…" Adora frantically cried, holding her hand over her stomach. "I-it's okay, it's okay darling, mommy's got you. You, y-you're safe. Just like I promised, I-I'm never gonna let anything bad happen to you, *ever!"*

Adora still had no clue what had just happened, what her body had done and *how* exactly it had done it. She would need to ask Entrapta about it later.

"Owowowow…"

After calming down, Adora could hear Catra wincing in pain as she regained consciousness. Adora got up, still a little woozy, and slowly made her way towards Catra who was now lying down on her back, unable to stand up on her own.

“I, I failed…” Catra mumbled in tears, disappointed and ashamed of herself for having lost to Adora. “I failed the Magicats, I let Pyra down, I… She’s never gonna forgive me for this.”

While Catra was busy berating herself, Adora caught up to her.

“You okay?” Adora asked, sounding remarkably calm as she offered her hand to Catra and helped her up on her feet.

“I’ll live.” Catra grumbled. She was still angry at herself and didn’t have any fight left in her: Adora had won.

“Good.”

As soon as Catra had gotten back up Adora immediately punched her straight in the face, knocking her back down and almost knocking her unconscious a second time.

“Aagh!” Catra yelped. She sat up, rubbing her cheek and cussing under her breath. She glared at Adora and groaned: “Hey, *watch it*- Whoa!”

Adora grabbed Catra by her collar and harshly pulled her back up: The look on her face was absolutely furious.

"Are you OUT OF YOUR MIND?!" Adora shrieked, shoving Catra who lost her balance and fell back down once again. "Do you have *ANY IDEA* what you almost did?!"

"Okay, fine, it was a dirty move!" Catra yelled. "But you still didn't have to use your powers on me like that, that was complete overkill!"

"**Overkill?!**" Adora was fuming. "You... You stupid, unbelievable, *reckless, inconsiderate JERK!*"

"Jeez, what's the big idea?!" Catra asked, both profoundly confused and extremely annoyed. "I've knocked you in the gut like dozens of times in the past, I don't see what the big deal is here!"

"Oh, for the love of-" Exasperated, Adora smacked her own face with both hands before shouting at the top of her lungs: "I'm ***PREGNANT,*** you ***asshole!***"

For a while, the two went completely silent. Adora's breathing got steadier as she slowly calmed down, only realizing what she had just said out loud when she saw the utterly flabbergasted look on Catra's face.

"W-wha, what…" Catra stammered, unsure if she had heard Adora correctly. "Adora, w-what did you just say..?"

“Ugh, this is *not* how I wanted this to go!” Adora sighed. “I didn’t want you to find out like… **This.** Well, at least… At least you *know* now.”

Adora looked aside sadly, anxious about how Catra would react to the news she had just told her. Catra slowly stood up, walked up to Adora and gently grabbed hold of her hands.

“Adora.” Catra’s voice was tender and loving. There wasn’t even a hint of any sort of animosity or hard feelings towards Adora anymore, only curiosity and hope as she gazed into Adora’s eyes. “Adora, look at me. Is it, i-is it true? You’re-”

“I’m pregnant, yeah.”

“A-and the child, it’s-”

“It’s yours.”

“And we,” Catra’s voice cracked as she asked this last question. “We’re, we’re gonna be-”

“We’re gonna be parents.” Adora finished with a gentle smile. “Catra, we… *We’re gonna be **moms.**”*

A single tear rolled down Catra’s cheek. She was so overcome with joy and love that she cupped Adora’s cheeks, pressed her lips against Adora’s and kissed her with more passion than ever before in her life, completely catching Adora off guard.

“Dummy.” Adora giggled, blushing with tears in her eyes. She kissed Catra back just as intensely, causing her to purr quietly. She was so relieved.

Because after everything that had happened between them, Adora knew…

She had finally gotten Catra back.

Chapter End Notes

Catradora is back on the menu! I've always been a massive fan of the trope where two characters are talking through their issues while fighting, so I always knew I wanted this to be the way Catra learned of the pregnancy and how she and Adora ultimately reconciled.

This might've been a cheesy way to end the chapter, but I figured it was warranted in this case :P

Title is completely intentional, since the main conflict between Adora and Catra is with their words rather than the actual physical battle so I went with the form that's typically used in legal cases.

Chapter 12: Together

Chapter Summary

> Adora tells Catra of Pyra's plan to freeze Etheria, and Catra finally realizes how much Pyra has been lying to her. Catra goes to confront Pyra about everything, nearly losing her life in the process until She-Ra shows up. She-Ra battles Pyra in order to save Etheria from the Raging Inferno.

Chapter Notes

> For clarity's sake, the beginning of this chapter is happening concurrently with the ending of the previous one.
>
> Also just a heads-up: This chapter in particular was the reason I ultimately decided to tag this fic with "graphic depictions of violence".

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“This… This isn’t working!”

Frosta was feeling completely hopeless: Despite how many attacks she and the other princesses had launched towards the fire consuming the Kingdom of Snows, it was doing nothing to put it out. The crimson red flames kept spreading around, melting away everything in their path.

“My kingdom…” Frosta muttered sadly. “I-if we can’t do this, then Etheria will, *will…”*

“Don’t give up, Frosta!” Glimmer encouraged her friend while firing sparkle beams at the fire. “We’ve faced worse than this!”

“Umm, *have* we?” Mermista asked, raising an eyebrow while gathering up was much water as she could. “Because like, sure, Horde Prime was pretty bad, but this is uhhh…”

She sent out a huge tidal wave that washed over the flames, to no avail; The water just evaporated into steam.

*“**Uuuggghhh!*** Yeah, *no.”* Mermista groaned.

Spinnerella launched as many gusts of wind as she possibly could at the Raging Inferno, but every time the flames appeared to die down they would just immediately flare back up again.

“I fear Mermista’s right.” Spinnerella said gravely. “Nothing we do is working, our only hope is that Adora can stop Pyra before it’s too late.”

“We can’t quit now, guys!” Glimmer kept trying to embolden the other princesses, despite how futile their efforts currently seemed. “We didn’t survive the Heart of Etheria just to have some deranged lunatic from a thousand years ago flood the planet!”

“We’re… We’re not strong enough!” Frosta cried. “Pyra was right, I-I’m, I’m just a weakling!”

“No, you’re not!” Glimmer teleported up to Frosta, grabbing her hand. “Frosta, you’re one of the strongest people I know, despite how young you are! You were still just a child when we fought against the Horde, but you proved yourself time and time again. We could’ve never won the Battle of Bright Moon without your help!”

“G-Glimmer…” Frosta muttered, touched by how much Glimmer believed in her.

“I mean, Perfuma and I also kinda helped but-” Mermista started, but kept quiet after Spinnerella gave her a nasty glare.

“You’ve always been charging headfirst into battle, no matter the opponent.” Glimmer continued, smiling at Frosta. “We’ve fought Horde bots and armies of clones, surely one fire isn’t going to stop Winter’s Bane!”

Frosta smiled back, much less unsure of herself now thanks to Glimmer’s encouragement.

“You know what? Glimmer’s right.” Mermista chimed in. “We’ve like, totally got this.”

“We can do this, together!” Spinnerella agreed.

"Together." Frosta nodded, filled with confidence.

Suddenly, a bright light emanated from the glacier on the other side of the kingdom, shining like a miniature sun which caught the four princesses by surprise. They paused for a moment, staring at the light in awe.

"Whoa!" Spinnerella gasped. "W-what was *that?"*

"I think Adora's getting some work done." Glimmer guessed, having seen similar lights coming out of She-Ra in the past.

"We should get some work done, too." Frosta cracked her knuckles and conjured ice fists around her own. "I've got an idea! We might not be able to put the fire out… But maybe we can *slow it down!"*

"What's the plan?" Glimmer asked her. Frosta turned to Mermista.

"Mermista, can you gather as much water as possible? Enough to cover the entire fire!"

"Umm, didn't you see what *just* happened when I tried that a second ago?" Mermista questioned Frosta, before complying: "But sure, whatever."

After a while of gathering enough water Mermista suspended it above her head, having concentrated the water into a large orb.

"Great! Now move it above the fire, in the exact middle!" Frosta instructed.

"Reaaaally don't know what your end goal is here." Mermista said snarkily, using her powers to move all the water above the flames.

"Spinnerella," Frosta continued. "Can you use your powers to spread the water as wide as possible? So the fire will be completely surrounded by it!"

"Uh, sure." Spinnerella launched a powerful cyclone that flung the water Mermista had conjured all over the place.

"Glimmer, I need a good vantage point!" Frosta said as the water droplets began falling. "Can you teleport me up high, over the fire?"

"W-what?!" Glimmer yelled. "No way, we'll burn to a crisp once we fall back down!"

"It's only for a second! Trust me!" Frosta pleaded. Glimmer decided to have faith in her friend, grabbed Frosta and teleported them high in the sky. "Alright, NOW!"

Frosta launched her ice fists downwards, then as they made contact with the water droplets that were spreading around she used her powers to freeze all of the water, surrounding the Raging Inferno in a gigantic dome of ice.

"Whoa, that's genius!" Glimmer exclaimed after teleporting herself and Frosta safely back to the ground. "Good thinking, Frosta!"

"It's… Not gonna hold… For long…" Frosta stretched her arms forward, using all of her concentration and energy to conjure as much ice as she could to counteract the flames rapidly melting away the dome surrounding it. "B-but… It should buy the others enough time… To evacuate everyone… A-and give Adora an opening, to stop Pyra…"

"Uhh, we should like, probably help her out or something." Mermista said to Spinnerella, who nodded. They used their powers the same way as before, gathering water and spreading it around to help make more ice for Frosta.

"Keep at it!" Glimmer told the others while they did their best to keep the fire at bay. "I'm gonna keep an eye out in case the barrier breaks or Pyra notices what's up!"

She turned her gaze to the glacier on the other side, where She-Ra had gone.

"Adora, please… Hurry."

"Why," A tearful Catra asked. "Why didn't you tell me sooner, Adora?"

Catra still couldn't believe that the news Adora had just told her was actually real.

Adora was pregnant. With *Catra's* child. *The two of them would become* ***parents****.*

"I tried to." Adora replied. "Like a dozen times. But you… You kept cutting me off and running away, and I never got the opportunity!"

"I-I'm so sorry, I…" Catra hugged Adora tight. "I-I never would've left you if I had known!"

Adora hugged Catra back, gently stroking the back of her head and smiling compassionately. After the two let go of one another Catra had another question she needed to ask Adora:

"What uh, have you decided what you're gonna do? With the baby?"

“I…” Adora was extremely grateful that Catra was asking her this, that she respected her bodily autonomy and her say in the matter. “I, I wanna keep it.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah, I think I’m ready to have a child. But,” She held Catra’s hands and added in a teasing tone: “It’d be hard to raise it on my own. A-and I’m sure the kid would like to have both of their moms around, too.”

“So the almighty She-Ra isn’t able to look after a kid by herself?” Catra playfully fired back, before giving Adora a quick smooch on her cheek and assuring her: “Adora, I’m done running here. I’ll absolutely take responsibility and do everything I can to support you and help raise our child. Starting a family with you, it’s…” Catra smiled lovingly as she whispered: “It’s the thing I’ve wanted more than *anything* in the world.”

“You’re gonna be an *awesome* mom, Catra.” Adora stated, smiling back.

Catra felt happier than ever before in her life. Then, the realization of what she had almost done set in for her, and she gasped in horror.

“O-oh, oh no no no…” Catra started to panic.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked her, concerned.

“W-when, when I was… When I tried to hit your stomach, I-I almost, *I almost…* Oh!” Catra fell to her knees, hugging Adora’s waist with her head pressed against Adora’s abdomen and apologized profusely. “Oh, I-I’m so, so sorry little buddy! I’m n-never gonna try to hurt you again, I-I… I promise, m-mom is **never** gonna let anyone or anything hurt you, *ever!”*

Adora just giggled affectionately and stroke Catra’s hair.

“It’s alright, Catra. They’re safe.” Adora comforted her. “She-Ra was able to stop you before it was too late. The baby and I, we’re just happy to have you back-”

Suddenly, a large chunk of ice from a nearby mountain melted off due to the change in temperature from the Raging Inferno and fell to the ground below, causing a loud crash that startled both Adora and Catra.

“W-what was that?” Catra wondered, standing back up.

“Oh no.” Adora muttered. “Speaking of stopping before it’s too late…”

Adora placed both of her hands on Catra's shoulders and looked her in the eye, with a very serious expression on her face.

"Catra, you have to listen to me." She started. "Pyra, she… *She's been lying to you,* this entire time. She's trying to **destroy** Etheria!"

"Adora-" Catra sounded really exasperated, afraid that they were going to have the same argument again.

"Please, just listen. Bow's dads are historians, we went to talk to them. They had some information about the Magicats."

"T-they did?"

Adora nodded, then continued: "Their kingdom falling a thousand years ago, that part is true. Some sort of disaster happened that nearly wiped them out… But Mara and Glacia *never* rounded the surviving Magicats up or trapped them under the Kingdom of Snows! The Magicats formed a new settlement somewhere else, staying isolated from the rest of Etheria *out of their own volition.* They wanted to stay safe from whatever event had caused their downfall."

"Really?" Catra muttered. "How, how do they-"

“Some of them have traveled to the outside world over the centuries and given testimonies.” Adora explained. “Magicats have always kept to themselves, even more so after the disaster. That’s why you and I had never heard of them, they… They didn’t *want* anyone to find them.”

“D-did any of them say where their new settlement is?” Catra asked, her ears perking up.

“No.” Adora sighed. “They’ve kept that information secret to protect their kind. But they’re out there, somewhere, and that somewhere is **not** under the Kingdom of Snows! Magicats don't like the cold, and Entrapta even told me that the chances of *anything* living down there would be extremely unlikely.”

“I, I don’t understand.” Catra felt so confused. “If the Magicats aren’t here then, why is Pyra… What is she *doing?”*

“I don’t know *why,* but… I might know *what* she’s after.” Adora claimed. “Entrapta said that if the Magicats were down there, Pyra would have to destroy the entire Kingdom of Snows to free them.”

“Yeah, Pyra told me as much. But-”

“There’s so much ice and snow here, melting all that way,” Adora swallowed nervously. “I-it’s gonna cause the sea levels to rise, flooding the planet. Then, the temperature is gonna cool down, freezing Etheria over and… And *wiping out all life on it!”*

"What?!" Catra gasped, shocked and horrified. "Is she trying to kill us all?! That's crazy, why, why would Pyra…"

"I'm not sure, but it might have something to do with Mara and Glacia." Adora guessed. "We went through the library in Frosta's castle, apparently Glacia had worked together with She-Ra to stop something called the *'Raging Inferno'* that tried to destroy Etheria around a thousand years ago."

"That's… That's what Pyra said she'd use to set the Magicats free. What she's doing right now." Catra said quietly. All of this was making sense to her, but she didn't want to believe it to be true. She took a deep breath and asked: "Adora… Adora, are you *absolutely* sure about all this?"

"Yes." Adora said, without hesitation. Looking into Adora's eyes convinced Catra, and she finally pieced everything together.

"So this entire time, Pyra, she was…"

Catra turned around, staring at the path that led to the top of the glacier. She clenched her fists, shaking with fury as she finally realized the full extent of how much Pyra had deceived and manipulated her.

*How much Pyra had **used** her.*

“Ngh…”

“Catra-” Adora gently placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder. Catra turned around, giving Adora a very firm, determined look.

“Adora, I’m.. I’m gonna go talk to her.”

“W-what?”

“I’ll go talk to Pyra, I’ll…” Catra stared at her hands. “I’ll talk her out of this. She, she listens to me, I-I can convince her to stop.”

“Catra, she’s dangerous!” Adora warned her. “If she thinks you’ve turned against her, she’ll-”

“She won’t hurt me.” Catra mumbled. “Pyra, she… She likes me. She’ll stop this, if I just ask her to. Please,” She cut Adora off when she opened her mouth. “Adora, please just… Trust me, okay?”

Catra smiled at Adora gently. Adora hesitated for a second, sighed and backed down.

“Okay.” Adora nodded. “But I’m coming with you.”

“No, you stay here.” Catra shook her head. “I’ll do this on my own.”

“Catra, I’m not letting you go anywhere near that woman alone! You saw what she did back at the Brimstone Cave, you know what she’s capable of!”

“All the more reason for you to stay here.” Catra held Adora’s hand. “I don’t want to risk anything happening to you or our baby.”

“Catra-”

“It’s **my** fault Pyra got her powers back, Adora. This is my mess, I’m the one who’s gonna clean it up.”

Before Adora could protest any further Catra gave her a quick, soft kiss, whispered to her “I love you” and started running up the trail, back to the top where Pyra would be waiting. During the run there she did her best to contain the hurt and anger she felt.

Pyra had lied to Catra. She was just using her, all along.

Catra thought back to her time as Force Captain, Shadow Weaver being locked in her cell. How she had also manipulated and used Catra into letting her escape.

Catra was definitely going to talk to Pyra. And she would get her answers. *By force, if necessary.*

"Catra, wait!" Adora yelled after Catra, then sighed. She appreciated Catra's willingness to step up and help fix the situation, but…

"I'm sorry, sweetheart." Adora whispered to the baby inside her as she extended her hand and summoned her sword. "I know this'll be risky for us both, but I can't just sit here and let your other mom deal with that… That *monster* on her own."

After being sure Catra was out of earshot, Adora raised her sword and said quietly but determined:

"For the Honor of Grayskull."

"Ahahaha… Soon, this'll be over…"

Pyra watched as the Raging Inferno was slowly destroying everything in its path with malicious glee. She observed the four princesses desperately trying to put it out in the distance, and cackled at their futile attempts.

"Try as much as you'd like," Pyra said to herself. "You won't be able to stop me. *Nobody* is going to get in the way of my revenge!"

Pyra felt so triumphant, so vindicated. She might have needed to wait a thousand years, but finally… She was going to prevail.

She would finally have her vengeance on Mara and Glacia for their treachery. She would make all of Etheria pay for its sins, for the suffering that it has caused her.

And once this was done… Pyra wouldn't have to suffer anymore. She would be free.

Free of anger. Free of heartbreak. Free of pain.

Everything would finally be over. She could rest-

*"**NOW!**"*

“E-eh?”

Pyra observed as the princesses worked together, managing to form a massive ice dome over the Raging Inferno and keep it at bay.

“Unbelievable…” Pyra scoffed. “But no matter, they can’t keep that up indefinitely. The Inferno will burn its way through that soon enough. And with the Sunstone out of their reach, even She-Ra cannot take away my powers! Soon, Etheria will-”

“Pyra!”

Hearing her name being called, Pyra glanced behind her and noticed that Catra had returned.

“You’re back! Where’s She-Ra?” Pyra asked.

“I… Took care of her.” Catra muttered.

“Excellent, I knew I could count on ya.” Pyra smirked, turning her attention back to controlling the fire. “Now, *nobody* can interfere with my plan!”

“Your plan,” Catra started, doing her best to remain calm despite how furious she was on the inside. “To save the Magicats. Right?”

“That’s right. Soon they’ll be free again, all thanks to you kid.”

“And the Magicats… They’re all imprisoned underneath the Kingdom of Snows?”

“As we’ve established.” Pyra said impatiently.

“ALL of them?”

“Yes! Every single one!” Pyra yelled, losing her cool. “We’ve gone over this a dozen times, Catra! Now leave me be, I have to focus.”

“Sure.” Catra glared at Pyra. “But first, you’re gonna answer me one thing.”

“Catra, I’m a little busy here at the moment-” Pyra said through gritted teeth.

“If all the Magicats have been frozen for centuries, then… *How am I here?”*

"W-what?" Pyra glanced at Catra again, looking utterly confused.

"How am I here?" Catra reiterated her question. "If all of the Magicats have been trapped and isolated from the rest of Etheria for a thousand years?"

"Ugh, o-obviously some of them managed to escape!" Pyra grumbled. "Kid, if you want me to help you find your family you're gonna have to stop asking me stupid questions-"

"Finding my family's gonna be hard *when all of Etheria's underwater!"* Catra said loudly, finding it hard to keep calm anymore.

Pyra remained quiet for a moment, before saying in an indifferent voice: "I don't know what you're talking about."

"Drop the act." Catra hissed. "I know, Pyra."

"Know *what?"*

"Why you're here. Why you're *really* here."

"I'm trying to save our people!" Pyra growled. "I'm doing this for YOU, you ungrateful *brat!* Besides, how would you know *anything*

about what I'm-"

"ENOUGH!" Catra shouted, finally losing her patience. "Enough with the lies! Be honest with me for *ONCE* in your life!"

"I-"

"Pyra, look at me." Catra said, her voice wavering slightly. "Look me in the eyes and tell me that the Magicats really are trapped down there, that you're telling the truth. Tell me that you haven't lied to me."

Pyra kept completely quiet, her back still turned on Catra.

"LOOK AT ME!" Catra yelled. The longer Pyra kept silent, the more it angered Catra.

Pyra shot Catra a contemptuous glare, but she still didn't say anything. That sealed the deal for Catra.

"You… *You've been lying to me.* This entire time." Catra muttered, tears in her eyes and her blood boiling.

"Catra-"

"I TRUSTED YOU!" Catra roared. "I looked up to you! But all you did was *use and manipulate me!"*

"I did what I had to do!" Pyra shouted, finally turning around to face Catra. "I needed to get my powers back, I had to finish what I started! And as soon as I found out you were close with the current She-Ra, I realized you… You were the one I needed, to find the Sunstone."

"I, I left Adora," Catra cried. "I turned on my friends, I stabbed 'em in the back, I-I nearly *killed my own-"* She sniffled, looking at Pyra with nothing but fury and hatred in her eyes. "All because of ***YOU!****"*

"Ha! *Please."* Pyra jeered. "Did I *make you* do any of those things?"

"You, you filled my head with lies! By acting like you'd know where to find my parents! You deceived me!"

"Maybe." Pyra shrugged. "But I wasn't the one who asked you to leave Adora or betray your friends. You did all of that yourself, *you insolent child!"*

'Insolent child.'

"GRAARRGH!" Hearing Pyra use the exact same phrasing that Shadow Weaver had finally sent Catra over the edge, as she growled and scratched Pyra's left cheek with her claws. Catra breathed heavily with her claws raised, feeling nothing but anger and contempt towards the woman she had foolishly trusted for so long.

Pyra, however, stood completely still as she slowly touched her cheek with her hand, feeling the three claw marks that Catra had left behind. Then, she let out a deranged, empty cackle that sent shivers down Catra's spine.

"You really **are** Petra's descendant." Pyra said with a very threatening grin on her face. "You're just as much of a traitorous *bitch* as my dear sister!"

"Ah!"

Pyra shot a stream of flames out of her hands towards Catra, who managed to jump out of the way just in time. Catra was ready to fight Pyra, but first…

She had to know.

"***Why?*** Why are you doing all this?!"

“Mara and Glacia, they betrayed me.” Pyra stated, conjuring fireballs ready to toss at Catra. “Mara destroyed my kingdom, Glacia cheated on me and broke my heart… And I am getting revenge on them, *no matter what!”*

“Mara and Glacia are *gone!”* Catra reminded her. “They’ve *been* gone for a thousand years! Besides, do you realize what destroying the Kingdom of Snows will do to Etheria?”

“Exactly! It’ll cause a flood.” Pyra chuckled. “Then, the planet cools down and freezes over. This miserable garbage heap will be gone! All of Etheria is going to pay for the suffering it’s caused me.”

“W-what? Are you crazy?!” Catra yelled, her pupils narrowing as she realized that Adora had been correct about Pyra’s plan. “You’re gonna die yourself too if that happens!”

“So what?! I’ve got NOTHING to lose!” Pyra bellowed. “Ya hear me? ***NOTHING!*** Glacia, Mara, Magicat Kingdom, my people, even Petra turned on me by the end! I’ve already lost everything, and now… The rest of Etheria will share my pain. And then, I’ll be set free from it. *For good.”*

“Are you… Are you *serious?* You’re planning to destroy the world, just to get back at a couple of people who’ve wronged you?!” Catra was completely appalled. Something about Pyra’s plan and line of reasoning… It struck a chord with her.

"THIS ENTIRE PLANET HAS WRONGED ME!" Pyra roared as she tossed a fireball towards Catra. "If Etheria gets to take everything from me, then *I'M going to take everything from Etheria!"*

"Ngh!" Catra managed to barely dodge the fireball. She kept evading Pyra's attacks and fighting back for a while, getting in a few punches and scratches, then eventually she lunged at the Fire Princess and tackled her to the ground. Despite how angry Catra was, she decided to try and reason with Pyra one last time. "Pyra, please! You, you have to stop this! You can't-"

"Don't YOU tell me what I can't do!" Pyra knocked Catra off of her with a fireball, singing her hand.

"GYAAAH!" Catra screamed in pain as the fireball tossed her a good distance away from Pyra. She laid there on the snow, trying to get up and seeing Pyra walking towards her. "Pyra-"

Pyra kicked Catra in the stomach, knocking the wind out of her, then grabbed Catra by her collar with her right hand while raising her left, preparing to strike at Catra with her claws.

"Pathetic." Pyra spat on the ground, disgusted. "A weakling who associates herself with Etherians and is in love with a First One… You're a ***disgrace*** to all Magicats!"

"Ghah… Ngh…" Despite being injured, Catra remained defiant as she glared at Pyra and said: "You… *You're* the weak one."

"W-what?!"

"You, hehe…" Catra chuckled. "You, you face a few hardships… A-and instead of coping with it like an adult, you t-take it out on everyone else, and for what? Some sort of *desperate* ploy for attention?"

"SILENCE!" Pyra snarled. "You don't talk to *me* that way, you little shit! You, you have NO idea how much of an utter *hell* my life has been-"

"Me, me, me." Catra said in a mocking voice. "It's always about *you,* isn't it? You think only *your* suffering matters. You keep talking about Mara, Glacia, Petra, how they turned on you. You're blaming literally everyone and anyone else around you, all of Etheria… But did ya ever stop to think that maybe ***you*** were the problem the entire time?"

When she saw the absolutely murderous look on Pyra's face, Catra knew she wasn't going to get out of this. She knew Pyra was most likely going to kill her.

But Catra wanted to make sure she would get *zero* satisfaction out of doing so. Because when she looked at Pyra, she could see the exact same person she herself had been years ago, when she was still a Force Captain back at the Horde. When she opened the portal.

Catra knew exactly what was going on in Pyra's head. Catra knew how she would think. And she was going to make sure to call Pyra out on *all of it.*

"You," Catra gave Pyra a disparaging glare. "You're nothing more than a sad, frightened, self-absorbed **coward**, wallowing in your own misery instead of getting over it. You're completely empty on the inside, and you know what? I *pity* you."

Pyra looked incensed beyond belief, but instead of shouting or growling at Catra she just chortled once and asked: *"Hmph.* You done?"

"Just about." Catra snarked, remaining defiant as ever.

Pyra clenched her left hand into a fist and punched Catra in the face as hard as she could, knocking one of her teeth out and giving her a black eye. Catra groaned in pain, then felt Pyra's right hand grabbing her by the throat and lifting her off the ground.

"Gh… Ghaah…" Catra gasped for air and thrashed around, trying desperately to free herself from Pyra's hold before the Fire Princess would choke her to death.

"Hey brat, remember when ya said you would've liked to meet Petra?" Pyra taunted Catra. "How about I send ya *directly to her,*

right now?!”

Catra kept struggling and hitting Pyra’s arm. Her eyes were watering and her vision was getting blurry.

“You brought this on yourself, you *ingrate.”* Pyra stated. “I’ll dispose of anyone who tries to interfere with my revenge. You stood against me, and now I have no choice but to **put you down.**”

“I wouldn’t do that if I were you.”

Pyra turned her head after hearing another voice chime in, and gasped. She-Ra was standing there, her sword pointed towards Pyra.

“***You…”*** Pyra growled.

“Let her go, Pyra.” She-Ra said in a threatening voice. *“Or else.”*

“A-Adora…” Despite running low on oxygen, Catra was still just barely able to speak. “Adora, I-I told you to stay back!”

“Sorry Catra,” She-Ra apologized playfully. “But I couldn’t let you deal with this maniac on your own. Pyra, release her!”

"You, you *lied* to me!" Pyra shouted at Catra. "You said you took care of her!"

"Heh," Catra grinned. "Like *you're* one to talk- GHAH!"

Pyra tightened her chokehold on Catra enough to knock her unconscious on the spot. She then used a fireball to send Catra's limp body flying a good distance away.

"CATRA!" She-Ra cried, worried for her girlfriend's safety. Enraged, she swung her sword and launched a wave of magical energy at Pyra, which coiled around the Fire Princess and knocked her to the ground restraining her, before running after Catra. "Catra… Please hang on, I-I've got you…"

She-Ra channeled her magic and used her powers to heal Catra's injuries, but the Magicat still remained unconscious. Suddenly, she sensed something coming from behind and turned around; Pyra had managed to free herself from the restraints and thrown a fireball towards She-Ra, who shielded herself with her bracelets to block the attack before summoning her sword back into her hand.

"Should never turn your back on your opponent." Pyra smirked, conjuring more fire in both of her hands and giving She-Ra a very bloodthirsty look. "I might've missed my chance to have Mara's head, but now… *I can have the next best thing.* I finally have the opportunity to finish what I started a thousand years ago!"

"That's what you think." She-Ra raised her sword, ready to charge at Pyra. "But I'm going to do everything in my power to stop you and the Inferno from destroying Etheria. And you're gonna answer for everything that you've done!"

"Me?!" Pyra cackled. "YOU'RE the one who has the blood of my people on your hands!"

"E-eh?"

"You're *She-Ra.* That means you're just as responsible for what happened to the Magicats as Mara is… And you're gonna PAY FOR IT!"

Pyra tossed a fireball towards She-Ra, who deflected it aside with her sword. She charged towards Pyra, and the two princesses began duking it out, exchanging blow for blow. They were fairly evenly matched, and while She-Ra was physically much stronger Pyra had an advantage in being quicker and more nimble.

Fighting against Pyra reminded She-Ra of her past battles with Catra. Except this time, *she didn't need to hold back.*

But Pyra was a much more ferocious opponent than Catra had ever been, constantly being on the offensive and throwing as many fire-based attacks at She-Ra as possible. She-Ra's magical

properties shielded Adora's physical body from suffering any burns, but she still took extra care to protect her abdomen.

After a while of fighting, She-Ra could feel herself starting to tire out, breathing heavier.

"Ngh… T-this isn't good." She-Ra muttered to herself, glaring at Pyra. "If I don't stop her soon, Etheria will be… I have to think of something!"

"Hehe, g-getting tired, eh?" Pyra smirked, while also feeling her stamina running low as well. "Is this the best ya can do? Your generation is so WEAK!"

"Maybe." She-Ra shrugged. "But there's one thing I'm good at."

"Oh? And what might that be?"

"Improvising."

"H-huh?"

She-Ra transformed her sword into a staff, then rapidly spun it around as she thrusted it towards the snow underneath her feet,

blowing snow everywhere to the point she obscured Pyra's vision in a snowy veil that enveloped them both.

"Hmph. *Clever.*" Pyra scoffed, shielding her face from the snow. "Using my own trick against me. However, you should know *it's not gonna work-"*

Having heard movement behind her, Pyra turned around and threw a punch: However, She-Ra had managed to catch Pyra surprise and blocked her fist. Using her superior physical strength she grabbed hold of Pyra, slammed her to the ground and then placed her foot over the Fire Princess' abdomen while pointing the tip of her sword towards her throat.

"Give it up." She-Ra said. "You've lost."

"Grrr…" Pyra growled at She-Ra at first, before soon laughing victoriously. "Lost? Far from it. *I've already won!"*

"Enough with your games!" She-Ra yelled. "Tell me how to put out the Raging Inferno!"

"'Put out?'" Pyra had the most smug grin possible plastered on her face. "Didn't Catra tell ya? The Inferno is an ***everlasting*** fire! Ya CAN'T put it out!"

“W-what?” She-Ra gasped. “B-but you have control over it! You have to be able to stop it!”

“Even if I were,” Pyra glared at She-Ra. “Why would I ever do so?”

“Because I have my sword pointed directly at your neck! If you won’t stop the fire yourself, I will-”

“Kill me? *Go ahead!”* Pyra laughed. “Like I told your little *girlfriend* earlier, I’ve got NOTHING to lose! But that won’t put the flames out. The Inferno will keep raging through the Kingdom of Snows, melting it into a puddle and taking out this entire planet with it, and there’s not a damn thing you can do to stop it!”

“No,” She-Ra mumbled in disbelief. “No, y-you’re bluffing!”

“Am I? See for yourself!” Pyra gestured towards the Raging Inferno in the distance, slowly eating away at the ice dome that Frosta, Mermista and Spinnerella had cast over it.

“No… I-it can’t be…” She-Ra whispered in horror as she observed her friends.

“Your friends have done their best to keep the fire at bay, but all they can do is slow it down. Speaking of which,” Pyra used She-Ra’s momentary distraction to her advantage and shot out a

gigantic fireball towards the four princesses by the ice dome, which looked like a crashing comet. "I reckon it's time to *speed things up a little!"*

"NO!" She-Ra ran after the fireball towards the edge of the glacier, but wasn't able to stop it in time. She shouted at the top of her lungs: "GLIMMER! LOOK OUT!"

She-Ra wasn't sure if Glimmer could hear her from such a large distance away. The fireball was approaching her friends at a rapid speed; She-Ra prepared to transform her sword into something that could hopefully destroy it in time, when suddenly-

"W-what?"

An arrow, a large vine, a net ball and a red lightning bolt had been shot towards the fireball, colliding with it and causing it to explode mid-flight before it could reach its destination.

"That, that must've been… Way to go, Bow!" She-Ra cheered. "AAHH!"

A fireball struck She-Ra from behind, greatly injuring her. She fell to her knees on the snow, crying out in agony. Then, another fireball to the back of her head caused She-Ra to revert back into Adora, giving her a concussion and almost knocking her out. Adora collapsed on the snow, still managing to roll over onto her side before she hit the ground in order to protect her baby.

“Tsk tsk tsk! What did I tell ya about turning your back on your opponent?”

Adora’s vision was blurry, but she could barely make out Pyra approaching her with arms extended to her sides, holding flames in both hands. Adora tried to run, but she was too injured to even stand up.

“For… T-the Honor… Of- AARGH!”

Adora attempted to summon her sword, but Pyra angrily stepped on Adora’s wrist as hard as she could, nearly breaking it.

“Oh, no you don’t.” Pyra said, her voice full of sadistic glee. As Adora’s vision was recovering, she saw how giddy and murderous Pyra looked. “It’s over, Adora. Your concern for your friends was your undoing. *You* ***failed.”***

“N-no…” Adora cried, disappointed in herself and afraid of her impending demise. Pyra was aiming the fires towards Adora, ready to finish her off.

“And now, I’ll finally have She-Ra’s head!” Pyra gloated. “When you see Mara, *tell her that I won.”*

“Ngh…”

Meanwhile, Catra was finally regaining consciousness. She slowly opened her eyes and sat up, feeling mildly disoriented.

“Wha, what happened… Ah!” Catra spotted Pyra standing in front of Adora, who was lying on the ground, holding flames in her hands. She jumped up and desperately ran up to them.

“If ya have any last words,” Pyra taunted Adora. “I think now’s about the time to-”

“PYRA, WAIT!”

Pyra turned her head, seeing Catra standing behind her.

“C-Catra…” Adora muttered.

“Well well well,” Pyra scoffed. “Looks like *the traitor* finally woke up! Did ya come to see me finish off *'the love of your life?'”*

“Pyra, stop!” Catra begged her. “You can’t! She, *she’s pregnant.”*

Pyra remained quiet for a while, before she burst out laughing.

"Oh please, do tell me," She asked Catra, sounding extremely amused. "Why in the world should ***I*** care for some *bastard* First Ones?"

"Don't you get it? The child is mine!" Catra explained. "That means it's a Magicat, just like you and me! You… You can't hurt it!"

Pyra gasped, having a realization. She slowly turned to face Catra properly, and based on the deranged look on her face it appeared that the final screw had just come loose in her head.

"You… You mixed *a Magicat… WITH A* ***FIRST ONE?!****"* Pyra screeched at the top of her lungs. "Y-you have betrayed and tarnished *OUR ENTIRE RACE!"*

"What are you- *Urgh!"*

Pyra hit Catra in the stomach with one of the fireballs she'd been holding, causing her to double over in pain.

"Catra… N-no…" Adora sobbed.

"That child," Pyra was trembling with pure, unadulterated rage. "Will grow up to become an ***abomination***. It has to be put down, *NOW."*

"P-Pyra…" Catra, clutching her stomach, begged Pyra with tears in her eyes. "P-please, don't… D-don't do this!"

"Oh, don't worry." Pyra said quietly, whilst turning back to Adora. "Once I'm done here, I'll make sure to *send you to them* right after."

Adora saw Pyra raising the fireball in her right hand. Realizing there was no escape from this, Adora closed her eyes and braced herself for death.

Then, Adora heard the sound of Catra screaming, Pyra gasping for air and something that was concerningly similar to *flesh* being torn. She felt something warm dripping on her face, opened her eyes and gasped out of horror, feeling sick to her stomach from what she was witnessing.

Catra had impaled Pyra by striking her right arm directly through Pyra's back. Pyra, who had completely frozen up, slowly shifted her gaze down to see Catra's forearm sticking out of her abdomen, drenched in Pyra's blood.

"Cat, ra…" Pyra mumbled absently and turned her head to Catra, looking heartbroken and confused with blood pouring down the

right corner of her mouth.. “Why… You…”

Catra was breathing heavily while she pulled her bloodsoaked arm out of Pyra’s torso, leaving behind a gaping hole. Pyra gasped again, clutching the hole in her stomach and stumbling off to the side. After a few steps she went completely limp, first falling on her knees and then on her face.

Catra watched as Pyra laid there on the snow, completely motionless.

Chapter End Notes

> We're entering the final stretch here, only two chapters left to go! They were originally just going to be one longer finale, but things expanded in scope to the point I saw fit to split it in half.

Chapter 13: Out of Time

Chapter Summary

> Mortally wounded and on the brink of death, Pyra has a moment of clarity and tearfully apologizes to Catra for everything she's done. Catra begs Adora to heal Pyra, who decides to show mercy to the Fire Princess and revives her. A remorseful Pyra wishes to set things right before the Raging Inferno can destroy Etheria.

Chapter Notes

> Just like last time, the beginning of this chapter is happening concurrently with the end of the previous one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I think that was the last one, Bow!"

Bow, Perfuma, Scorpia and Netossa had been hard at work gathering all of the citizens of the Kingdom of Snows and leading them to a safer area on the outskirts of the kingdom. Evacuating had taken a while, but eventually they managed to get everyone to safety before the Raging Inferno could reach their homes.

"You sure?" Bow asked Netossa, who nodded. He then turned to address all the civilians of the kingdom: "Alright everyone, try to remain calm! The situation is under control!"

"W-when can we go back home?" One of the citizens, a young girl, asked.

“I dunno, pal.” Scorpia answered sadly. “But we’ll do everything we can to make sure it’ll happen as soon as possible.”

“Consarn it, this is even worse than that Horde Prime debacle!” An elderly citizen remarked. “At least we didn’t hafta abandon our homes back then! And that fire an’ smoke? It’s a sign of the end times, I tells ya!”

“Just try to stay positive and think happy thoughts!” Perfuma smiled, holding her hands together. “We have the She-Ra on the case, she and the rest of us princesses will do our best to put out the fire.”

“Where is Princess Frosta?” One of Frosta’s servants asked Bow. “She didn’t come with us!”

“Frosta is currently working on stopping the fire and keeping your kingdom safe.” Bow explained. “We promise she’s going to be okay and will make sure she comes back safely!”

“We should probably regroup with the others.” Netossa suggested. “I, I want to make sure Spinny is okay.”

“Good idea.” Bow nodded. “They might need help with the fire.”

“Let’s get going!” Scorpia said. She, Bow, Perfuma and Netossa then departed to catch up with Glimmer and the others.

“How do you think they’re managing?” Perfuma wondered.

“I dunno.” Bow shrugged. “But they’re doing everything they can, I know it. And Glimmer’s with them, they’ve got nothing to worry about!”

“You’re right, they can hold their own.” Netossa agreed, although she wasn’t fully able to quell her fears. “But I’m still worried about Spinny.”

“I know the feeling.” Bow said sympathetically, knowing himself what it feels like to worry about someone he loves.

“Do ya think Adora’s having any luck with Pyra?” Scorpia asked. “Or with Catra? Man, I really hope Adora can get through to her… It sucks Pyra was able to dupe Catra the way she did!”

“Don’t worry, if anyone is able to reach Catra it’s Adora.” Perfuma comforted her. “She’ll come around, especially once she realizes what’s at stake here!”

“She’s faced off with Catra many times in the past.” Netossa remarked. “I’m more concerned what we’ll do if Adora isn’t able to deal with Pyra.”

“Hey, she managed to defeat *Horde Prime!”* Bow reminded her. “Adora’s saved the universe once, she’s not gonna let Pyra have her way. I have full faith in her!”

“I’m just saying, we should have a plan B.” Netossa shrugged. “We all know Pyra’s a very ruthless opponent, we need to be prepared for the possibility that Adora might-”

“Whoa! W-what is THAT?!” Scorpia gasped in awe, pointing forward with her right pincer: She spotted the Raging Inferno in the distance, surrounded by a gigantic dome of ice.

“That’s gotta be Frosta’s doing!” Perfuma exclaimed. “Looks like the others figured out a good way to slow the fire down!”

“It’s not gonna last for long, though.” Bow said, seeing how the fire was melting the ice away at a gradual pace. “We should go help them out, together we might be able to-”

“GLIMMER! LOOK OUT!”

“Huh?” Bow suddenly heard a faint voice coming from the top of the glacier at the edge of the kingdom. “W-was that Adora?”

“Ah!” Perfuma yelped. “L-look at that!”

Bow, Scorpia and Netossa turned their gaze to the sky, and saw a gigantic ball of fire that was currently on crash course with the icy dome that was keeping the Raging Inferno at bay.

"Oh no…" Netossa mumbled. "I-it's headed for Spinny and the others!"

"We've gotta hurry!" Bow took an arrow out of his quiver and took aim at the fireball, while Netossa, Perfuma and Scorpia prepared their own attacks.

Meanwhile, Frosta, Mermista and Spinnerella were still hard at work keeping the Raging Inferno encased in ice, with Glimmer cheering them on.

"Keep at it, guys!" Glimmer encouraged her friends. "You've got this!"

"I… Can't keep this up… For much longer…" Spinnerella panted as she sent out another gust of wind.

*"**Uuuuggghhh.**"* Mermista groaned, feeling exhausted while gathering up water. "Feels like… I'm gonna have… A hernia or something…"

“D-don’t give up!” Frosta was on the verge of collapsing from using all of her energy to keep the ice dome steady. “We, we can… We can do, t-this…”

“Adora’s doing her best to stop Pyra!” Glimmer stated. “This’ll be over soon, I know it!”

“D-do we, even know…” Spinnerella asked. “I-if stopping Pyra… Will also stop the flames?”

“I…” Glimmer paused for a moment, then sighed. “I dunno. But it’s the best shot we have right now, we gotta just trust Adora and-”

“Ummm, what’s *that?”* Mermista looked at the sky and squinted. “Is that a sun or something?”

“Huh?” Glimmer turned her head to look up, then yelped as she spotted the massive fireball crashing towards them. “Ah! T-that’s no sun, that’s-”

“Pyra.” Spinnerella gasped.

“We gotta get outta here, quick!” Glimmer stated, getting ready to teleport the four of them to safety. Frosta, however, didn’t budge.

“No…” Frosta muttered. “J-just, a little longer…”

“Frosta, there’s no time!” Mermista grumbled. “We have to go, before-”

“I, I won’t…” Frosta said through gritted teeth, tears in her eyes. “I won’t let, that… That *bitch,* destroy m-my home!”

“F-Frosta…” Glimmer was taken back by Frosta’s resolve, how determined she was to protect her kingdom. However, she couldn’t let her friend sacrifice herself this way. “Frosta I’m sorry, but we’ve gotta go- AH!”

Suddenly, the fireball that was heading towards the group exploded midair, causing a loud boom. Glimmer, Mermista and Spinnerella shielded their faces with their arms, but were completely unscathed.

“Uhhh, *what* just happened?” Mermista scratched her head.

“I-I dunno!” Glimmer stammered. “L-looks like we got saved, but-”

“Glimmer!”

Glimmer turned her head after hearing an all too familiar voice calling her name and saw Bow, Scorpia, Perfuma and Netossa approaching the group from a bit of distance away with Bow waving at her.

"Bow!" Glimmer, delighted and grateful, teleported to meet Bow halfway, hugged him tight and gave him a kiss.

"You okay?" Bow asked gently.

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded, smiling lovingly at Bow. "You came just in time! You saved me, *again."*

"Of course, gotta keep *my future bride* safe from any danger!"

"Bow…"

Netossa approached Spinnerella, who had sat down on the snow and was breathing heavily.

"H-hey, darling." Spinnerella said, wiping her brow. "Glad to see you here."

"You did good, Spinny." Netossa crouched down and placed a kiss on her wife's forehead. "Get some rest, we'll take it from here."

“How are you feeling?” Perfuma asked Mermista, noticing how exhausted the Water Princess looked.

“Oh I dunno, like I just got done swimming a marathon.” Mermista snarked, doubling over with her hands on her knees. “Buuut, I’ve had like, worse or whatever. Frosta’s done most of the work here, anyway.”

“Ngh…” Frosta was still desperately trying to keep the ice barrier up, but finally she was completely tapped out of energy and fell on all fours on the snow. She watched as the Raging Inferno finally melted her ice away and continued to spread across the snowy plains. “D-damn it…”

“You’ve earned a break, lil’ buddy.” Scorpia said as she and Perfuma helped Frosta up on her feet. “We’ll tag in for ya!”

“B-but, my kingdom… I-I have to-”

“Frosta,” Perfuma started. “You’ll die if you try to exhaust yourself any further. Please. You’re not alone here, you don’t have to do this on your own.”

“But…” Frosta mumbled.

“She’s right, Frosta.” Netossa agreed. “You, Spinny and Mermista need to rest. The ice dome was a genius move, Scorpia, Perfuma and I will continue from where you left off!”

“I… O-okay. T-thank you.” Frosta sighed, falling on her back on the snow. Netossa, Scorpia and Perfuma stepped forward, staring at the Raging Inferno.

“Ready?” Netossa asked them.

“Ready!” Scorpia and Perfuma said in unison.

“Let’s do this!"

Following Frosta’s example, Netossa conjured a gigantic net barrier over the fire that Perfuma then encased completely with vines, with Scorpia using her lightning powers to keep the barrier stable.

“Whoa.” Bow whistled, impressed.

“W-we won’t be able to hold it off for long, we’re running out of time here.” Netossa stated. “The fire’s gonna burn through that sooner or later. Bow and Glimmer, go and find Adora! If she still hasn’t taken Pyra down, s-she… *She might need backup.”*

“You’re right.” Glimmer nodded. She grabbed Bow’s hand, getting ready to teleport the two of them to the glacier where Pyra was last seen.

“B-be careful.” Frosta said quietly. “You know what Pyra’s capable of.”

“Right.” Bow turned to Glimmer and asked her: “How do you think Adora’s doing?”

“I dunno.” Glimmer shook her head. “But Netossa’s right, she might need our help. Ugh, we shouldn’t have let Adora take on Pyra by herself, she’s pregnant and-”

“I’m sure she’s fine.” Bow reassured her. “But… I guess it won’t hurt to check.”

“As long as Catra hasn’t gotten in her way.” Glimmer channeled her powers, teleporting herself and Bow to the glacier.

“I really hope she hasn’t done anything stupid.”

“Adora, a-are you alright?”

A tearful Catra hugged Adora tight. Her heart was racing and she was overwhelmed by adrenaline and her emotions, but she felt so relieved at the same time.

"Yeah, I-I'm fine." Adora muttered, still in shock from what she had witnessed a second ago.

"A-and the baby?"

"Also fine."

Catra gave Adora a weak smile. Then, she noticed the way Adora was staring at her right arm, still drenched in blood, and sighed. She turned her head to look at Pyra's body laying there on the snow, feeling both bitter and remorseful.

"I had no choice." Catra said quietly. "She was gonna kill you, kill you *both*. I-I had to stop her!"

"Catra, I-"

"I promised I wouldn't let anyone hurt our child, no matter what, and *I* ***meant*** *it.* I understand if you're-"

Adora cupped Catra's cheeks, tilted her head and gave her a very tender kiss.

"Thank you." Adora whispered, tears in her eyes. "You… Y-you saved us."

"You would've done the same for me." Catra gently stroke Adora's hair, then asked her: "Can you walk?"

"Y-yeah, I think so." Adora muttered. Catra offered her hand to Adora and helped her up on her feet. Adora then noticed that Catra's stomach had been burned by the fireball that had hit her earlier. "Y-you're hurt."

"It's nothing." Catra assured her. "I'll be fine. You know what they say about playing with fire."

Adora smiled at her, but soon turned serious. She and Catra both glanced at Pyra's body.

"Catra, I… *I think we're screwed."*

"W-what?"

“Pyra told me that the Raging Inferno… It’s an eternal flame.” Adora said quietly. “It can’t be put out. I don’t, I don’t know what to do.”

“We’ll figure something out. Together.” Catra encouraged her. “But we gotta hurry. Let’s get going, before it’s too late and-”

“C… Cat… Ra…”

Catra and Adora both gasped after hearing a weak, gravely voice calling Catra’s name. Catra’s pupils dilated as she turned her gaze back towards Pyra, realizing that the Fire Princess was somehow still alive.

“Pyra!” Catra yelped. She cautiously approached Pyra and crouched down, holding the older Magicat’s hand.

“No way…” Adora covered her mouth with her hands out of sheer disbelief. She felt nauseous staring at the hole in Pyra’s abdomen.

“Catra… You, you made the right choice.” Pyra’s voice sounded oddly calm and serene; It appeared that she had finally snapped out of her berserk state. “I, I had gone completely off the deep end, blinded by grief and rage… I-I let my thirst for vengeance consume me, this… *This is what I deserve.”*

“Pyra, no-” Catra was cut off by Pyra coughing up blood. “Nonono no, please d-don’t die!”

“It’s… Better this way.” Pyra said, smiling with tears streaming down her face. “T-there’s nothing left for me here… I, I don’t deserve to live, after everything I’ve done… All the pain I’ve caused. To Etheria, to your friends... ***To you.”***

“Don’t say that!” Catra cried. “Please, it’s gonna be… I-it’s gonna be-”

“Catra, I’m… *I’m sorry.*” Pyra wept, touching Catra’s cheek with her hand. “I-I hurt you so much, I… I lied to you about everything, I took advantage of your desire t-to find your mother, I tried to kill you and Adora, I…” She felt so disgusted with herself. *“I-I nearly murdered an unborn infant*. I’m a *monster,* you… I, I want you to know that I don’t blame you for this, for *any* of this… You did the right thing, I needed to be put down.”

“Pyra…” Adora mumbled.

“I’m… Glad I got to know you, Catra.” Pyra whispered fondly. “Spending time with you, it… It made me feel like I’d gotten Petra back. You were right about me, I-I drove her away… I drove *everyone* away, and now… It’s too late for me.”

“Pyra, I-” Catra could feel Pyra’s pulse getting weaker and weaker, her face turning pale from the blood loss.

“Take care, kid.” Pyra closed her eyes. “I’m sorry, f-for everything…”

“No… Please, don’t go! H-hang in there!” Catra sobbed as she felt Pyra’s hand going limp. Despite how much the older Magicat had tricked and deceived her, despite how much she had hurt her, despite all the anger and contempt Catra had felt towards Pyra for her actions… *She didn’t want it to end this way.*

“Catra,” Adora placed her hand on Catra's shoulder. “We should go. We-”

“Adora.” Catra frantically stood up and grabbed hold of Adora's hand, tearfully begging her. “Adora, *heal her.* Please.”

“W-what?” Adora was completely taken back by this request. “Are you serious?”

“Please!” Catra’s voice broke. “You’re She-Ra, y-you can save her! I can’t lose her like this, I… *I need her.”*

“Catra, *she has a hole through her stomach!* I-I’ve healed injuries before, but never something like THIS! I… I don’t know if I can.”

“You… You managed to bring me back from the dead, after you saved me from Prime. I know you can do this, Adora. Please... Do it for me.”

Adora thought about Catra’s words for a second, looked at the nearly dead Pyra and sighed. She asked Catra: “Are you *sure* about this? We both know what she's capable of.”

“Yes.” Catra nodded without hesitation. "W-we can't just let her die like this."

That was good enough for Adora, who softened and summoned her sword once more.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

Adora transformed into She-Ra. After first healing Catra's injuries she crouched down next to Pyra, placing her hand over the Magicat’s chest while observing the gaping wound in her abdomen.

“She’s lost a lot of blood, her heart’s about to give out.” She-Ra said quietly, turning her head towards Catra. “She’s almost out of time, I… I can’t promise anything.”

“You’ve got this.” Catra gave She-Ra an encouraging smile while fidgeting with her fingers. “I-I believe in you.”

She-Ra smiled back at her, then turned to Pyra. She thought about everything Pyra had done, how dangerous she could be… This might be a bad idea.

But Catra was right. She couldn't just let Pyra die. *Not like this.*

She-Ra closed her eyes, took a deep breath and concentrated, channeling her powers. She began to glow a bright, ethereal light, transferring that light into Pyra through her hand. She-Ra focused harder than she ever had when healing people in the past, using up a lot of her remaining energy until eventually-

"Ah!" Catra gasped, watching in awe as the hole in Pyra's stomach started slowly repairing itself, in addition to the various other injuries she had sustained while fighting She-Ra and Catra, and soon enough the wound had completely healed over. "You, you did it!"

While her injuries were healed, Pyra still remained motionless with her eyes shut. She-Ra and Catra waited with bated breath for her to wake up, and just when Catra was about to think that Pyra was dead she saw her fingers twitching.

"Mmph…" Regaining consciousness, Pyra slowly opened her eyes. She felt really disoriented at first, taking a few slow breaths. "Wha… What happened… Ah!"

Pyra gasped and frantically sat up, patting her hands over her stomach only to discover that the wound had healed. She was in complete disbelief, not understanding what was going on.

"Where am I… W-what just, how- I-is this the afterlife? Am I-"

"Pyra." She-Ra gently called her name. Pyra turned her head and saw She-Ra cautiously smiling at her.

"A-Adora…" Pyra mumbled. "Did you, did you just…" Realizing what had happened, Pyra sighed, then clutched her head with her right hand.

"Are you okay?" She-Ra placed her hand on Pyra's shoulder. Pyra remained quiet for a moment.

"Why… *Why did you save me?"* Pyra eventually asked with a pained, guilty look on her face. Her voice sounded bitter, almost *resentful*. "You should've just let me die, I'm not worth saving. I… Why?"

"Because Catra asked me to." She-Ra said nonchalantly, before giving Pyra a playful smirk and adding: "And because I wanted to show you that not all of us First Ones are that bad."

"B-but… A-after everything I've done, h-how could you-"

“You’ve done a lot of terrible things.” She-Ra said. “But I can tell… You were being sincere about what you said to Catra, and that means you can't be fully evil. I’m willing to give you another chance so you can set things right, I hope you won't make me regret it!”

“I, I’m… I don’t know what to say.” Pyra whispered, her eyes getting misty. She was extremely grateful of She-Ra’s mercy and forgiveness, even if she believed she didn’t deserve it at all. Pyra slowly stood up, turned her head and looked at Catra, feeling a massive sting of shame and regret in her heart. “C-Catra… Catra, I’m-”

“Hey, Pyra.” Catra muttered, glancing aside. While relieved that Adora had managed to revive Pyra, she felt uneasy due to her unresolved feelings regarding the older Magicat and her actions, how much she’d hurt and used her. Catra opened her mouth and was about to say something, but was caught completely off guard by Pyra hugging her tight. “Eh?”

“Catra, I-I’m, I’m s-so sorry! For everything!” Pyra broke down sobbing. “I-I’m never going to forgive myself for all the things I did to you, t-the way I used you and nearly tore you and Adora apart, I-I… I don’t know how I can ever make things up to you! I was awful, I-I was out of my mind, I was-”

“You were hurting.”

“Huh?”

Pyra let go of Catra, instead placing her hands on Catra’s shoulders. Catra had a strangely sympathetic look on her face.

“Years ago, I… Opened a portal.” Catra started. “It almost destroyed the world, and I knew it could do that. But I wanted to get revenge on Adora, on Shadow Weaver… On *everyone.* I’d lost everything, I had nothing left but anger and pain and-” She paused for a moment and sighed. “I just wanted it to stop. So I could be *free.”*

Opening up about the portal was still painful for Catra, even after all these years. But she needed Pyra to hear this.

“C-Catra…” Pyra mumbled, taken back by Catra’s confession. “Why, why are you telling me this?”

“Because I know how you feel.” Catra said quietly. “I, I was in your position before. I snapped and let vengeance consume me, I drove away everyone around me… But eventually I was able to change, get better. A-and I… I, want to believe you can get better too."

“Really?” Pyra sniffled. She couldn’t comprehend how Catra could possibly be so understanding towards her. “E-even after everything I’ve done, you… You still want to-”

“It’s gonna be hard for me. To fully forgive you.” Catra said, giving Pyra a slight smile and adding: “But Adora was able to forgive me for all of my many, *many* mistakes, it only feels fair I at least *try* to do the same for you.”

“Catra’s right.” She-Ra agreed. “You seem to genuinely regret your actions and wish to make up for them, I don’t see a reason why we shouldn’t give you the chance to do so.”

“T… *T-thank you.”* Pyra wiped the tears from her eyes and was able to smile again. “Thank you both. I promise I won't let you down, I’m gonna prove myself to you, to all of you! A-and I’m going to do everything I can to fix things, I-”

“Adora, look out!”

“Huh?” She-Ra, Catra and Pyra all turned their heads. A sparkly, magical blast hit Pyra in the eyes, temporarily blinding her: Afterwards, an arrow flew through the air and bursted into a net that wrapped itself around Pyra, restraining her and knocking her to the ground.

“Agh!” Pyra grunted, hitting the snow. “Son of a-!”

“Don’t move!” Bow and Glimmer ran up to She-Ra and Catra, with Bow readying another arrow and preparing to fire it towards Pyra

if necessary. “If you try anything, I’ll-”

“Whoa whoa whoa!” She-Ra raised her hands. “Guys, calm down, it’s-”

“Adora!” Glimmer hugged She-Ra tight. “Are you alright? S-she didn’t hurt you, did she?”

“Looks like we came just in time.” Bow remarked. “Who knows what she would’ve done if we hadn’t shown up!"

“Guys.” She-Ra said. “It’s uh, it’s a long story but Pyra… She, she’s with us now. She’s good.”

“Wait, *seriously?”* Bow raised an eyebrow. Pyra used her powers to incinerate the net around her and stood back up, giving Bow an annoyed look.

“Yeah. ***Seriously.”*** Pyra said, sounding very deadpan.

“Uhh, s-sorry about that, we uh-” Bow stammered.

“It’s fine.” Pyra chuckled. “Think I deserved that one. But I promise ya, I won’t try anything anymore.”

“Good.” Glimmer crossed her arms, then glared at Catra. “And you?”

“I-I…” Catra rubbed her arm, feeling guilty and ashamed of herself. “Adora told me everything, I’m…” She sighed deep and apologized to Glimmer: “Sparkles, I’m really sorry, about everything. The way I tricked you guys and had Double Trouble spy on you, and-”

That appeared to be enough for Glimmer, who smiled and immediately embraced Catra.

“Glad to have you back,” Glimmer said fondly. *“Horde Scum.”*

“But for real this time.” Bow joined in on the hug. Catra was taken back at first, but smiled and felt extremely grateful that her friends seemed to have no hard feelings towards her.

“Adora,” Glimmer asked after she and Bow let go of Catra. “Did you tell her about the, you know...”

“Yeah.” She-Ra nodded. “She knows now.”

“Good! In that case…” Glimmer flashed a mischievous grin, hugged Catra even tighter than she just had and giggled:

“Aaahhh, congrats Catra! You two are having *a baby!”*

“You and Adora are gonna be *amazing* moms!” Bow stated, also hugging Catra again.

“Guys, I-” Catra’s cheeks turned red. “T-thank you.”

“We’re gonna need to start planning the baby shower for you two!” Glimmer said. “Even if it’s still gonna be like, eight more months until-”

Suddenly, the group heard a large explosion and screams. She-Ra looked over the edge of the glacier and gasped: The Raging Inferno had managed to break through the barrier Netossa, Perfuma and Scorpia had cast over it and was spreading at an alarming pace.

“I-I completely forgot about the fire!” She-Ra yelled. “If we don’t stop it soon the Kingdom of Snows will be done for, and Etheria with it!”

“This…” Pyra mumbled, staring at the fire with horror in her eyes. “This is all my fault, this-”

“Pyra,” Catra turned to the older Magicat. “I-is there any way to put out the Inferno? There’s gotta be!”

"I… *I don't know."* Pyra admitted. Catra's heart sank.

"W-what do you mean, *you don't know?* You, you told me you knew how to put the flames out in a safe way! You have to be able to control it!"

"The Raging Inferno, my ancestors…" Pyra felt a lump in her throat. "They realized it was a mistake, the damage it could cause and how easily it could go completely out of control. That it could destroy the world. We were warned to *never* unleash its power, under any circumstances."

"No way." Glimmer muttered. "S-so are we just doomed?!"

"The only way to stop it would be to deactivate the Sunstone." Pyra said. "But… That's not an option anymore, not after what I did to the cave."

"What… What do we do?" She-Ra asked out loud, feeling desperate.

"Please, try to think!" Catra begged Pyra. "There has to be something else!"

“Ngh…” Pyra clutched her head, trying her hardest to remember what she had been taught about the Raging Inferno. She recalled herself and Petra being lectured by their mother when Pyra first connected with the Sunstone, how their predecessors had come up with the Raging Inferno, the destruction it could cause if ever unleashed on Etheria and how to-

“Ah!”

“W-what is it?” Catra asked, hopeful.

“There… There ***is*** a way.” Pyra muttered, looking despondent after having remembered a particular detail. “But… I think it might be too late.”

“What’s the way, Pyra?” Bow asked.

“The Fire Princess serves as a conduit for the Raging Inferno.” Pyra stated. “I can concentrate all of the flames into one central point, and then release the stored energy of my ancestors to neutralize them. But…”

“But what?” She-Ra wondered, looking concerned.

“The ensuing release of energy causes… An explosion.” Pyra explained, looking serious. “Which is exponentially proportional to the amount of fire.”

“Meaning?”

“With how rapidly the Raging Inferno has spread, at this point…” Pyra sighed. “The blast would be enough to completely destroy the Kingdom of Snows, and probably half of Etheria with it.”

“No…” Glimmer gasped, covering her mouth with her hands. “I-is there really nothing we can do here?”

“I’m, I’m sorry.” Pyra hung her head, filled with self-loathing and shame. One way or another, Etheria was going to be destroyed… *And it was all her fault.*

“We can’t give up hope.” Bow said, looking determined. “We're the Best Friend Squad, we managed to survive the portal, the Heart of Etheria and Horde Prime. We’re gonna get through this, too!”

“Bow’s right.” She-Ra nodded. “We can do this, together.”

“We should go and help out the others.” Glimmer said. “We can try to figure out a way to stop the Inferno, once and for all.”

“Maybe you guys could try out the same thing you did to the Whispering Woods?” Catra suggested. “When you combined your powers? Maybe the rainbow light show would be enough to-”

“The Woods…” Gears started turning in Pyra’s head. “Powers, combined… Of course, that’s it!”

“Huh?” Catra turned to Pyra. “Y-you’ve got something?”

“Yeah, I think I have an idea.” Pyra claimed with a confident smirk. “But we’re gonna need everyone here to pull it off. Go gather the other princesses, quickly!”

“R-right, on it!” Glimmer teleported to the other side of the Kingdom of Snows to regroup with the rest of the princesses, and soon enough after having gathered everyone she teleported them to the top of the glacier where She-Ra, Bow, Catra and Pyra were waiting.

“...And *why* did you bring us here, again?” Mermista asked Glimmer, her arms crossed. “Shouldn’t we be like, I dunno, trying to put out the fire before-”

“**YOU!**” Frosta shouted after spotting Pyra. The look on her face was one of absolute fury.

“I uh, I-” Pyra started, attempting to apologize but Frosta, Perfuma and Netossa all used their powers to restrain her. “Whoa!”

“Heyheyhey, wait! Don’t!” Catra stepped between the other princesses and Pyra after seeing Mermista, Spinnerella and Scorpia getting ready to attack as well. “S-she’s on our side now!”

“W-what?” Scorpia was befuddled. “Wait, weren’t *you* supposed to be on *her* side, Wildcat? But now *she’s* on our side and then *you* are on- Oh wow, I’m getting confused here!”

“To cut a long story short, Catra and I patched things up and Pyra’s had a change of heart.” She-Ra explained. “She wants to help us.”

“I, I might know of a way to put out the Raging Inferno.” Pyra said. “But for that, I need all of your help and-”

“Umm, and why exactly should we trust *anything* she says?” Mermista scoffed. “She’s the reason we’re in this mess to begin with.”

“Yeah!” Perfuma agreed. “First she set the Woods on fire, now this! She can’t be trusted.”

“I, I promise-” Pyra muttered.

“She *did* lie to and manipulate Catra a lot.” Scorpia said, her pincers crossed. “I mean, getting Catra to break up with Adora?

And while she's *pregnant*, no less? …Oh crud, uhh," She gave Catra nervous glances. "I uh, I mean-"

"It's fine, Adora told me already." Catra said casually.

"Phew! Okay, good! Point being, she could be lying to us now, too."

"Look, I know what a complete and utter scumbag I've been." Pyra gave the other princesses an apologetic, pleading look. "I've done a lot of awful things, and I'm not expecting forgiveness from any of ya. But… I really do wish to atone for my sins and set things right. I promise."

Frosta kept giving Pyra resentful, suspicious glares. But there was something else on her face as well: *Uncertainty.*

"Right now, I only wanna hear one thing." Frosta said quietly, staring at Pyra. *"Why?* Why did you do all this? Why were you trying to destroy my kingdom, destroy *all of Etheria?"*

"I, I uh…" Pyra looked away, feeling an immense amount of regret as she thought about the series of events that had led her to her breaking point.

"Actually yeah, I wanna hear it as well." Netossa chimed in, with Spinnerella nodding in agreement. "Even *if* you've had a change

of heart, you must've had **some** reason for doing what you did."

"I… W-we don't have much time here-"

"Then I guess you've just gotta be quick about it." Mermista snarked. "Because we're not doing anything you say until you give us the truth!"

"Pyra," Glimmer started. "You were trying to cause a flood and an ice age that would wipe out Etheria. You owe us an explanation."

"Something happened between you and my ancestor." Frosta walked up to Pyra. "And I want to know what it was."

Pyra gasped when Frosta brought up Glacia. She looked around and saw all of the princesses and Bow staring inquisitively at her. Pyra hesitated for a moment longer, when she suddenly felt Catra's hand on her shoulder.

"Pyra." Catra said quietly. "Please. Tell us what happened."

Pyra gave Catra an unsure, pleading look, and when Catra nodded she sighed deep and finally relented. "Okay."

Pyra began telling the others her history with Mara and Glacia, how she and Glacia were engaged and Mara was their best friend, how the First Ones had installed drills in her kingdom and how Magicat Kingdom ultimately fell.

"...When I got home the next day," Pyra's voice wavered. "My kingdom, it was… *Gone.* Everything was destroyed, m-most of my people were dead, my sister, she…" She swallowed anxiously. "She lost an arm."

"And… You think it was Mara who did that?" Bow asked her.

"Petra told me it was She-Ra." Pyra affirmed. "But-"

"T-there's no way." She-Ra was in denial, unable to believe that Mara could have ever done something so monstrous. "I-it had to have been a mistake or something, Mara, she wouldn't have done something like that, she… *She wouldn't!"*

"That's what she and Glacia tried telling me, when I tracked 'em down." Pyra continued. "That Mara had tried to save my people. And, deep down… I know Mara wouldn't have been capable of committing such atrocities. I-I should've given her a chance to explain, but I, I was in shock, I was so angry and on edge a-and…"

"Anyone would've been messed up after witnessing something like that." Glimmer said sympathetically. "But what's this got to do

with Glacia?”

“I, I went to go ask her for help, in tracking Mara down. Trying to stop her.” Pyra explained. “But Mara, she had made it to the Kingdom of Snows first, she told Glacia her side of the story and…” Her pupils narrowed.

“What happened?” Frosta asked cautiously.

“I… I heard Glacia and Mara say that, that they **loved** each other.” Pyra said quietly. “And then I saw them hugging, and… And my brain connected the dots, I thought Glacia had been having an affair with Mara behind my back. A-and that, combined with everything else, i-it was just… *It was too much.”*

“And that’s when you snapped?” Spinnerella guessed. Pyra nodded.

“I went off the rails, I-I attempted to kill Mara.” Pyra’s voice was bitter. “Glacia stopped me, and that’s… How I ended up with *this.”* She raised her blackened left arm. “And that, it was the final straw for me. I was so angry and in pain and I just wanted everything to end. I wanted to get revenge on Mara and Glacia so badly, I unleashed the Raging Inferno on Etheria. Petra, she tried to stop me but… I stabbed her in the back. Eventually, Mara severed my connection to the Sunstone and Glacia, she…” Pyra buried her face in her hands and sniffled. “I was out for blood, I-I tried to murder Glacia and in the end she… Froze me. And that’s how I ended up here.”

"Whoa…" Scorpia looked at Pyra in astonishment. "No wonder ya went nuts, that woulda been a lot for *anyone* to go through!"

"Do you think Glacia and Mara really had something going on?" Perfuma asked.

"T-they both kept denying it, the entire time." Pyra muttered. "Glacia tried to explain, saying that she had just been comforting Mara. A-and, on some level I knew she was telling the truth, but I… I was too far gone by that point. I was hellbent on getting revenge one way or another and-" She felt so disgusted with herself. "I should've just heard what she had to say, I-I… *I loved Glacia!* I loved her more than a-anything in the world, I-I…"

Pyra wiped her eyes, which were welling up with tears, and sighed.

"I hurt Glacia so much." Pyra's voice broke. "Even if she really had been cheating on me, it still doesn't justify **any** of the things I did to her! I caused her so much pain, I… Maybe it's for the best that she got rid of me. Who would've wanted to be shackled to a *lunatic* like me for the rest of their life? Someone who *immediately* assumes the worst about you and tries to ***kill*** *you for it?!* Glacia probably moved on with her life, or… She died hating me."

"I… I wouldn't be so sure." Frosta said all of a sudden.

“H-huh?” Pyra was completely taken back as Frosta reached into the pocket of her parka. “What do you mean?”

Frosta hesitated for a moment, before handing a piece of paper she had in her pocket over to Pyra. She-Ra, Bow and Glimmer recognized it as the same paper Frosta had been holding when she called Bow earlier.

“What’s this?” Pyra wondered.

Glimmer turned to Frosta, looking just as confused as Pyra and asked: “Frosta, what are you-”

“I finally remembered where I’d seen Glacia’s name before.” Frosta explained. “My father had been doing research into our ancestors when I was a young kid, I think he had been trying to figure out something he could use in case the Horde ever decided to attack our kingdom. After he-” She paused with a very pained expression on her face and sniffled. “Anyway, this was in his study.”

“I, I still don’t understand what-”

“It’s a letter penned by Princess Lumira. *Glacia’s daughter.”*

“W-what?” Pyra gasped, her pupils dilating. “Glacia had a- *Oh.”* She let out a completely empty, joyless chuckle. “Of course, she

remarried. She, she had to keep her bloodline going, I… I'm glad she was able to move on from me, find someone else. Someone *worthy* of her love."

"I went back and checked the timeline." Frosta continued with a cautious, knowing look. "Lumira was born roughly nine months after Glacia and She-Ra had worked together to stop the Raging Inferno, meaning she would've had to have been conceived some time before that. And she was said to have been different from the other rulers of the Kingdom of Snows in that she had *strangely catlike eyes."*

"Wait," Catra had a realization. "Are you saying that Lumira, she was-"

*"She was **my** daughter?"* Pyra muttered. Her hands were shaking as she took the note from Frosta. "Why, why didn't Glacia say…"

"Lumira wrote that when she took the throne after Glacia's passing." Frosta said. Pyra began reading the note:

"The time has come for me to follow in my mother's footsteps and lead the Kingdom of Snows. My mother, Queen Glacia, left behind a very complicated legacy. Most people had the perception that mother was a cold, ruthless ruler, but I know there was more to her that she never showed to the public. I saw her when she was vulnerable, I saw the amount of pain she was in. Mother could be strict and distant at times, but she had her tender side: Every year she would travel to the tallest glacier in the kingdom with an ice lily in hand, coming back without it and with a much softer

demeanor than usual. I presume this had something to do with someone important to her.

"I've always known myself to be different from my peers. But mother never talked to me about my other parent, who they were or what had happened to them: Any time I tried to inquire her about it, she would shut me down in tears. The only thing I knew is that mother said I had their eyes, and that the bracelet mother kept on her arm, the same one she was buried in, was something she had received from my other parent. Whatever had happened between the two, it seemed mother had loved them with all of her heart, just as much as she loved me. Losing someone that close to you... I cannot imagine how hard it must have been for her.

"Mother was oddly at peace during her final years. Even on her deathbed she was smiling, saying she was looking forward to 'seeing her beloved again'. I will never forget the moment she passed, me holding mother's hand. The gentle, tender look she had as she gazed into my eyes, whispering 'I love you' as her final words. While ostensibly saying it only to me, I am certain she also directed them towards my other parent. Her beloved.

"Whoever this person was, I hope that mother gets to have a peaceful afterlife with them. Free of all of the pain and sorrow she had carried within her heart in life."

"G-Glacia…"

Tears were streaming down Pyra's face as she finished the letter. She was completely stunned and overwhelmed, she felt so awful for how much pain she had inflicted on Glacia and how she had never been able to move on from her, yet she was also so moved and grateful that despite it all Glacia had still loved her in the end.
"A-after all this time, after *e-everything* I did to her, s-she, *she still…"*

“She never stopped loving you, Pyra.” She-Ra concluded.

“I, I’m so… Ah.” Pyra managed to smile at Frosta through her tears. “I- T-thank you. For telling me this, f-for showing this to me, I…”

“Now that I know the context, I realized something.” Frosta said, looking at Pyra. “Since all of my predecessors have been descendants of Glacia, and the only child she ever had was Lumira, that means technically… You’re *my ancestor.”*

“WHAT?!” Everyone else exclaimed.

“Whoa, that’s a twist right there.” Mermista said dryly.

Pyra stared at Frosta completely dumbfounded. Then, she spread her arms and gave the Ice Princess a very gentle hug, catching her off guard.

“Frosta, I…” Pyra let go of Frosta and placed her hand on Frosta’s head in an affectionate way. “I promise, I’ll do everything I can to help save your kingdom. Save Etheria.”

Frosta didn’t reply, she just smiled and nodded. Pyra stood up, then looked over the glacier towards the Raging Inferno with

everyone else.

“We’re running out of time here. Let’s get to work.”

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, it's finale time! Thanks to all the readers who've been sticking along this far, I'll hope to see you there!

Chapter 14: Farewell

Chapter Summary

The princesses work on a last-ditch effort to stop the Raging Inferno once and for all. Pyra, wanting to make things up to Catra, reveals where Magicat Kingdom was located so she may one day find her mother. Pyra ends up paying the ultimate price in order to save Etheria.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A young girl was walking down the icy corridors of the Kingdom of Snows' castle, seeming slightly bored. In all other aspects she looked like a typical resident of the Kingdom, she had braided blue hair and she was wearing a parka, but one detail that made her stand out were her eyes; They were yellow and resembled those of a feline.

"So *booooring…"* The girl whined. She turned her head and looked out the window: It was snowing. "Hmmm, wonder if mother would let me play outside today!"

She picked up the pace and dashed down the hallways of the castle, trying to locate her mother. Eventually, she came across one of the castle servants.

"Hey! You there!" The girl called, catching the servant's attention.

“Hm? O-oh!” The servant gave the girl running towards them a salute: The expression on their face was somewhat nervous. “Princess Lumira!”

“At ease.” The girl, Lumira, smiled at the servant. “No need to be so tense, it’s just me!”

“You shouldn’t run in the halls like that, princess.” The servant gently admonished Lumira. “You could trip and hurt yourself, you know what the Queen-”

“I know, I know.” Lumira grumbled, crossing her arms. “Mother’s told me a thousand times. Speaking of, have you seen her around? I want to ask her something.”

The servant tensed up slightly as they said: “H-Her Majesty’s currently in a meeting with the rulers of Plumeria and Salineas in the war room. She is not to be disturbed!”

“A meeting? Oh, crud.” Lumira pouted, kicking her foot. “A-any idea when she might be available?”

“I cannot say for certain.” The servant shook their head. “Could be fifteen minutes, could be several hours. Depends on what topics they’ll be discussing.”

"Hours?!" Lumira sighed. Then, gears began turning in her head and a smirk formed on her face. "But wait, that means… Oh!"

"What is it?"

"Huh? Oh, nothing!" Lumira grinned, then commanded the servant: "You're dismissed. But come tell me once mother is finished with the meeting, okay?"

"Y-yes, Your Highness!" The servant saluted Lumira once more, before walking away down the hallway where Lumira had just come from. Lumira waited until the servant was out of earshot, then giggled to herself mischievously.

"Perfect!" Lumira rubbed her hands together in anticipation. "While mother is busy with the meeting, I'll have a good opportunity to sneak outside!"

Lumira began slowly and discreetly making her way out of the castle. Her movements were unusually nimble and graceful for someone her age and she was capable of moving silently, ensuring that she wouldn't get caught.

Eventually Lumira made it out of the castle gates, reaching the snow-covered courtyard. She gasped in awe as she took in her surroundings.

“Whoa… Aaahh, so cool!” Lumira squeed. The first thing she did was fall on her back on the snow and make a snow angel, then afterwards she got to work building a snowman. Once she was done with that, she stared at her hands: There was one thing in particular she was dying to try out.

“I know mother said I’m not ready to use my powers unsupervised. But…”

Lumira extended her arms forward and concentrated, channeling the powers of her runestone that she had connected with recently, until finally she was able to shoot a stream of ice out of her hands.

“Yes!” Lumira cheered. Excited to use her powers she fired more ice around her, skating on it and eventually forming a rail that she could surf on while making more ice in front of her, allowing her to go high above the ground.

“Wohoo, this is so fun! I, I wanna try a loop-de-loop!”

Lumira skated forward, gradually creating a massive loop out of ice. She had picked up a lot of speed, but once she reached the apex of the loop she was feeling exhausted.

“O-oh no… M-my powers…” To her horror, Lumira discovered that she wasn’t able to make any more ice. Having no more ice to

support her she began plummeting to the ground screaming: "AAAAAAAAHH!"

Lumira covered her eyes and braced herself for the fall, but instead she soon found herself sliding downward on a slope of ice that had formed out of nowhere which saved her, slowing her descent and allowing her to make it back the ground completely unscathed.

"Ahaha, that was fun!" Lumira giggled, having no idea who had just saved her.

"LUMIRA!"

"Ah!" Lumira yelped after hearing a strict, angry voice shouting her name. She swallowed nervously and turned around, facing the figure behind her: Queen Glacia, her mother. "Oh, h-hello mother! Hehe… *Uh-oh."*

"How many times have I told you?!" Glacia angrily scolded her daughter. "You're far too young to be using your powers by yourself, especially in such a reckless manner! You could've seriously hurt yourself, or someone else!"

"I know." Lumira hung her head in shame. "I-I'm sorry, mother."

“You were lucky that my meeting got cut short, young lady.” Glacia gave Lumira a disapproving glare. “Otherwise I wouldn’t have been able to save you.”

“Yes, I- T-thank you, mother-”

“One more stunt like this, and you’re *grounded.* For a **month.** *Do I make myself clear?”*

“Yes, mother.” Lumira nodded fearfully. “I’m sorry, I-I didn’t mean to scare you, I… I was just bored, I wanted something fun to do.”

Glacia kept glaring at Lumira, until eventually she sighed and her expression softened as she crouched down to meet her daughter at eye level, placing one hand on Lumira's shoulder.

“You need to be more careful, Lumira.” Glacia said sadly. “I need you to stay safe, you… You’re the *only* thing I have, the legacy I’ll be leaving behind. One day you’re going to be in charge of our kingdom, and you cannot afford to act so carelessly. The power that we have,” She made ice with her left hand as a demonstration. "It can be dangerous to those around us if we're not careful. You have to treat it with respect."

“Yeah, I know.” Lumira pouted. Glacia smiled as she looked into Lumira’s eyes; Lumira, however, spotted something in her mother’s right hand. “Are… Are you going to go see them again?”

“Hm?” Glacia was confused. “See *who* again?”

“The one you’re gonna give that flower to.” Lumira explained, pointing at the light blue lily that Glacia was holding.

“Oh.” Glacia stood up and looked aside, suddenly feeling extremely uneasy. “It’s, uh…”

“Every year, you go to the glacier with an ice lily in hand.” Lumira crossed her arms. “And every time you come back without it. Who are you leaving them to?”

“...It’s none of your concern.” Glacia said coldly.

“Is it… Is it for my other parent?”

“Enough.”

“You never tell me anything about them, mother! I want to know what happened to-”

“I SAID **ENOUGH!**” Glacia shrieked, causing Lumira to flinch. She soon felt immense regret for having lashed out at her daughter,

wiping the tears that had welled up in her eyes and sniffling.

"M-mother, I-" Lumira started, but was cut off by Glacia hugging her all of a sudden.

"I'm sorry, sweetie." Glacia whispered. "I shouldn't have lost my patience, I just… This isn't something I want you to worry about. You're too young to understand."

"B-but-"

"Maybe one day, when you're older." Glacia let go of Lumira, who felt disappointed that her mother wasn't telling her anything.

"Okay." Lumira let out a dejected sigh.

"I have to get going now, it'll be dark by the time I'm home." Glacia stated. "Return to your room, Lumira. You are not to leave the castle until I've come back. Understood?"

"Yes, mother." Lumira nodded.

"Good." Glacia smiled at Lumira and added: "There should be some ice pops left in the kitchen, feel free to have those. And tomorrow, we can do something fun together. Sound good?"

“Yeah!” Lumira cheered up somewhat, smiling back at Glacia. “Thank you, mother!”

Glacia affectionately stroke Lumira’s hair with her left hand, then started making her way outside of the castle grounds. But before she could leave…

“Hey, mother?” Lumira called out.

“Yes?” Glacia stopped dead in her tracks and turned her head, giving her daughter an inquisitive look.

“I, I’m sorry, but…” Lumira nervously fidgeted with her fingers. “C-could you tell me something? About them, my other parent?”

“Lumira-”

“Please, j-just one thing!” Lumira begged. “I know you hate talking about them, a-and I promise I’ll drop the subject afterwards, I just… I want to know something, ***anything*** about them! *Please,* mother.”

Glacia stared at her feet, hesitating for a moment. Her eyes got misty, as thinking of *her* was extremely painful for Glacia, but she

decided to acquiesce to her daughter’s request. Glacia turned her gaze back to Lumira and said in a very warm voice:

"You have their eyes.”

“Pyra, what’s the plan here?”

Catra, Pyra, Bow and the other princesses were looking over the edge of the tallest glacier in the Kingdom of Snows. On the other side of the kingdom, the Raging Inferno kept spreading, burning and melting down everything in its path.

Time was running short; If they couldn’t stop the Inferno soon, Etheria would face flooding and an ice age that would completely wipe out the planet. They needed to act fast.

“You said you had an idea.” Glimmer stared inquisitively at Pyra. “What do we do?”

“Yeah, what did you need us for?” Perfuma asked.

“Like I told ya before,” Pyra turned around, addressing the group. “I'm able to serve as a conduit for the Raging Inferno. I can release the stored energy of my ancestors to neutralize it."

“But you said that it will cause an explosion that’ll level half of Etheria.” Bow reminded her. “And-”

“That’s where you lot come in.” Pyra smirked.

“Huh?”

“What you did at the Whispering Woods, the way y’all connected your powers.” Pyra conjured a flame in her left hand as demonstration. “You surrounded the flames with your magic and ya managed to put the fire out.” She put her right hand over the flame in her left and smothered it.

“Ummm, your point being?” Mermista raised an eyebrow.

“Yeah, I’m not sure I’m following here.” Scorpia scratched the back of her head.

“We’ll repeat what ya did at the Woods, but at a smaller scale.” Pyra elaborated. “I’m gonna compress the Inferno into as small of a space as I can. Then, you surround me with your attuned elemental powers, where I can safely release the energy. The thing that gives the Raging Inferno its power is the magic of my predecessors, the actual flames themselves aren't special in any way!"

"Which means?"

"If my theory is correct," Pyra concluded. "Your combined magic should be enough to counteract the energy that powers the Inferno and cancel out the ensuing blast, mitigating the damages and saving the kingdom!"

"Whoa." She-Ra whistled. "A-are you sure it's gonna work?"

"I'm not sure about *anything* here." Pyra shook her head. "But I think it might be our only shot. If any of you can come up with a better idea, I think now's about the time to say it."

Everyone remained silent.

"I think we're out of options here." Spinnerella surmised. "Let's do it."

"Yeah, worst case scenario is we're gonna be doomed anyway so…" Netossa shrugged, agreeing with the plan. The other princesses and Bow all nodded, but Catra looked extremely concerned and hesitant.

"Wait." Catra said to Pyra. "If you release that energy, then… W-what's gonna happen to *you?"*

“Me?” Pyra looked aside for a moment with a thoughtful expression on her face. Then, she gave Catra a comforting smile and said: “Don’t worry about me, kid. I managed to survive being a popsicle for a thousand years, one blast won’t be enough to put me down! I’m sure I’ve got a couple spare lives left.”

“B-but-”

“We’re out of time here.” Pyra stated gravely. “Either we do this, or we all perish. What’s it gonna be?”

“I don’t think we have a choice.” Bow said.

“Everyone, gather around me!” She-Ra yelled. The other princesses formed a circle holding hands and closed their eyes, focusing as hard as they could.

“Remember, we can only try this once.” Pyra stared intently at the flames in the distance. “Once the Inferno is in my hands, I can’t hold its energy for long. We’ve got one shot to pull this off!”

After a while of concentrating, the other princesses managed to attune their powers, each of them being surrounded by a different colored aura of magical light.

“We’re ready.” Glimmer said, her voice having a slight echo to it. Pyra nodded, then took a deep breath and did her best to focus.

“Pyra…” Catra walked up to Pyra, feeling extremely torn. Despite everything that had transpired between the two of them, she still found herself caring for the Fire Princess. “A-are you sure about this?”

“I’ll be fine.” Pyra affectionately ruffled Catra’s hair and smiled. “I promise.”

“O-okay.” Catra muttered. “If you say so. I’ll- Eh?”

Suddenly, Pyra had hugged Catra extremely tight.

“Catra,” She whispered into Catra’s ear. “*Thank you.* For everything.”

“Huh?” Catra felt so confused. “What, what are you-”

“I’m so proud of ya.” Pyra let go of Catra and shed a single tear. Then, she remembered one more thing: “Hey, you wanted to find a lead on your mom, right? I know where ya can start looking!”

“W-what?” Catra gasped. All this time she had expected Pyra to have lied to her, that she wouldn’t know or tell Catra anything about her mother. Pyra turned around, facing the edge of the glacier.

“Magicat Kingdom.” Pyra spoke loud enough that everyone could hear her. “It was located… On *Beast Island.”*

“Whaaa-” This reveal made Bow’s jaw drop.

“B-Beast Island?” She-Ra muttered.

“Pyra…” Catra’s pupils narrowed and she stood there with a bewildered look on her face, she wasn’t sure if she had heard Pyra right. Was this real?

Catra finally had the lead she had been searching for, after all this time. And of all the places on Etheria...

“Find your family, kid.” Pyra gave Catra one last smile, before finally getting to work.

Pyra yelled and raised her arms, using her powers to take control of the Raging Inferno. Everyone watched in awe as the crimson-colored flames rose high into the sky, then slowly descended and contorted as Pyra began compressing the Inferno into a smaller state.

“Ngh…” Pyra winced, struggling to keep the overwhelming amount of energy under control. Once she was finally done condensing

the Raging Inferno into an orb of fire the size of a basketball in her hands, she was emitting a bright orange aura of light similar to when she made contact with the Sunstone back at the Brimstone Cave. “Alright, i-it’s… Done. Everyone, get ready!”

“‘Thank you, for everything…’”

Catra thought about the words Pyra had just said to her. Then, it hit her:

It was *a goodbye.*

Pyra was going to ***sacrifice herself.***

“No,” Catra whispered. “No, she… She couldn’t, she-”

“NOW!”

One by one, the princesses encased Pyra in a barrier of their respective elements: Frosta with ice, Mermista with water, Perfuma with large vines, Scorpia with red lightning, Spinnerella with a gust of wind, Netossa with a large net and Glimmer with an orb of sparkles.

“Alright. Here goes nothing.” She-Ra took a deep breath and pointed her sword towards Pyra with both hands, launching a wave of rainbow-colored energy that wrapped itself around the dome of elements surrounding Pyra.

“Sparkles!” Pyra barked to Glimmer. “Teleport me as high up as you can, in case this doesn't end up working!”

“R-right! On it!” Glimmer nodded and walked up to Pyra, placing her hand over the magical dome surrounding her.

“Pyra, *no!”* Catra begged. “D-don’t, don’t do this, please! Y-you can't… *Please-”*

But it was of no use, as Glimmer teleported herself and Pyra high up in the sky.

“NO!” Catra screamed in tears. “PYRA!”

“Catra?” She-Ra gave her girlfriend a puzzled look while Glimmer teleported back to the ground. “Catra, what’s going on?”

“Pyra, s-she…” Catra cried. “She, she’s gonna… *She’s gonna **die!**”*

“What?!”

"**I'm sorry.**"

Everyone gasped and looked towards the sky as they heard Pyra's voice booming from up above, being amplified by the magic surrounding her which was also keeping her suspended in the air.

"**I lied, again.**" Pyra's voice was gentle and apologetic. "**I don't think I'm gonna make it out of this one. This… Is the end of the road for me. But,**" She sounded strangely optimistic as she continued: **"Once I've done this, the energy of my ancestors will return to whence it came. And with the Sunstone out of reach, the Raging Inferno can never endanger Etheria again.**"

"No!" She-Ra yelled. "She, she can't! Glimmer, bring her back down here, quick!"

"B-but-"

"**There's no time.**" Pyra said. "**It's either me, or all of Etheria. This is a fitting end for me, after all the pain I've caused, I… I've made peace with it.**"

"No…" Frosta gasped, horrified. "Pyra, y-you can't do this!"

“We’ve gotta do something!” Bow stated. "We can't let her sacrifice herself this way-"

“**I’ve made my choice.**” Pyra sounded determined. “**Please, don’t make this any harder than it has to be. I don't belong in this time, it’s time for me to go. And, just maybe… *I’ll get to see Glacia again.*”**

“Pyra, d-don’t…” Catra desperately wanted to talk Pyra out of doing what she was about to do, even though she knew Pyra’s already made up her mind. “Please, don't…Y-you can’t just leave me like this!”

Pyra kept talking: “**Frosta. I’m sorry about everything I did to your home. You’re a fine, strong ruler, Glacia would be happy to know her kingdom is in good hands. She'd be proud of ya.**”

“Pyra…” Frosta began tearing up.

“**And… Catra. You and your child, you two are the future of the Magicats. You and Adora are going to be great parents.**” Pyra gave Catra a salute with her index and middle finger. “**Take care of yourself, kid.**”

“Nononono, no! NO!” Catra screamed. *“PYRA-”*

*"**Farewell.**"*

Pyra clenched her hands, detonating the ball of fire she was holding and releasing the stored energy of the Raging Inferno inside the dome around her.

Everyone watched in horror as the dome of magic in the sky exploded in a spectacular fashion, sending out a massive shockwave that split the nearby clouds and could be felt on the ground below.

"Whoa!" Scorpia yelped when the shockwave knocked her off her feet.

The group watched as the smoke up above dissipated, with wisps of magical energy flowing towards the direction of the Crimson Waste. Pyra's body was completely gone, presumably having been vaporized in the ensuing blast.

"No way, she…" She-Ra reverted back to Adora, who stood there in stunned disbelief. She, Glimmer, Frosta and Perfuma were all shedding tears, while everyone else just had a somber, mortified look on their faces.

"She… *She saved us."* Glimmer sniffled.

“Catra?” Adora cautiously called out once she noticed Catra had completely frozen in place.

“No…” Catra fell to her knees on the snow. “Pyra… PYRAAAAAAA!”

She screamed in anguish and broke down sobbing once the reality of the situation set in for her: Pyra was ***gone****.*

Adora approached the crying Catra, helped her back up on her feet and hugged her tight. Bow, Glimmer and Scorpia soon followed suit.

Etheria had been saved. But the victory felt bittersweet.

Glacia had finally made it to the top of the glacier where she had faced off against her fiancée several years ago. She stopped in front of a very familiar, large block of ice, which over the years had been partially covered by snow.

“Hey, darling.” Glacia whispered fondly. “It’s me.”

She began slowly plucking the petals of the lily she was holding one by one, letting them descend in front of the ice block.

“It’s… Been a while.” Glacia muttered. “I hope the afterlife’s been treating you well, I…” She sighed. “I’ve been… Managing. Some days I barely have the energy to get out of bed, being a queen is pretty taxing as is and having to be a single mother on top of that, it-”

Glacia sniffled, but soon she smiled as she thought of her daughter. *Their* daughter.

“Lumira’s such a handful.” Glacia chuckled. “A real troublemaker, that girl. She’s so stubborn and hotheaded sometimes, I-I wonder if she got that from you, or me. But she's also so sweet, so gentle. So thoughtful. You… You would have *really* loved her, honey.”

She plucked another petal from the lily, but held onto it and stared at it for a moment trying to gather her thoughts.

“She keeps asking me about you.” Glacia shifted her gaze towards the block of ice again, letting go of the petal. “She wants to know what you were like, I… I don’t have the heart to tell her what happened to you, to *us.* W-what I had to do to…” She sniffled again, her eyes misty. “S-she’s too young to know. And I don’t want to tarnish her perception of you. It’s for the best she doesn’t find out the truth.”

Glacia turned her gaze towards the sky.

“It’s been lonely.” She said sadly. “First I lost you, and then Mara… I shouldn’t have pushed her out the way I did, I should’ve mended our friendship sooner! B-but, by the time I tried to reconcile with her it was already too late, it… It was the night the stars disappeared. And Mara, she’s… Gone now. She never got to meet Lumira, either.”

Glacia looked at the block of ice again, lost in thought.

“I don’t know what exactly happened, that night. Mara’s superiors, they… They did *something* to Etheria, something shady. Y-you were right, they *were* up to something. But Mara stopped them. And now, her people have vanished as well. It’s… It’s all so confusing.”

Glacia could feel snow slowly falling on her, a gust of wind blowing through her hair.

“Lumira, she... She’s got your eyes.” Glacia whispered, smiling fondly again. “And in general, she reminds me so much of you. When we first met. We, we were so young and stupid back then, weren’t we? Things were so simple.”

She didn’t expect anyone to answer. After all, it’s not like *she* could hear Glacia within all of that ice. After plucking one more petal Glacia decided to ask another question:

“Remember our first date?” Glacia giggled. “We went on a walk in the Whispering Woods, we found the tallest tree there and carved our initials on it. And that clearing, with all the fireflies… Where we had our first kiss. And then the rain caught us by surprise, we were soaking wet and we holed up in that cave. That was the first time we had-” She blushed lightly. “I remember it all like yesterday. But it also feels like it happened a million lifetimes ago. We were so happy, so in love. Everything was perfect. A-and then…”

Glacia plucked another petal from the lily, then caressed the obsidian bracelet she was still wearing on her wrist. She had tried so hard to remain strong and hold back her tears, but her facade finally broke.

“I miss you so much.” Glacia wept softly. “I miss you every day. I-I thought it would get easier with time, but the pain, it just… I-it won’t go away. I don’t know what to do, I… Feel like *I’m broken.”*

Ever since her battle with her fiancée, Glacia had kept up a hardened, cold appearance in front of everyone aside from Lumira. The days where she would come up to the glacier were the only times she allowed herself to be vulnerable, where she would let all of her bottled up emotions out.

“I-I’ve never loved anyone the way I loved you, I… I don’t think I’m even *capable* of loving anyone or anything ever again. It feels like my heart has been frozen completely, e-everyone thinks I’m just some cold, emotionless bitch, even Lumira’s a-afraid of me sometimes, and…”

Tears kept streaming down Glacia's face. She felt so overwhelmed by her emotions, her pain. Regret, guilt. How she yearned for her fiancée, how she pined for the love she had lost.

"I-I'm sorry!" Glacia sobbed. "I'm sorry that I failed you, I'm sorry that I wasn't able to help you! Y-you were sick, you were hurting so bad a-and I couldn't reach you, I… *I couldn't save you."*

Glacia plucked another petal. There was only one left now.

Glacia had blamed herself for what had happened back then. That there was something wrong with her, which had caused *her* to not be able to trust Glacia. Assume the worst of Glacia, think she could be so cruel, so unfaithful. Think she could have ever hurt *her* in such a way.

It had to have been Glacia's fault.

"Why…" Glacia whispered, filled with bitterness and self-loathing. "Why, w-why did you make me do it? Why did I have to do it? I-I never wanted any of this, I… *I…"*

After a while Glacia calmed down somewhat, wiping her tears and sighing.

"I won't ever tell anyone what happened, to you." She closed her eyes for a moment. "I don't want your legacy to be tainted, I… I

don’t want people to only remember you for the things you did while you were unwell. You deserved better.”

Having gotten all of her feelings out, Glacia's soul felt so much lighter. She wasn't sure if this was the healthiest way to process her grief... But it did help.

“One day,” Glacia said, feeling at peace. “I’m going to see you again. I don’t know how long it’s going to take, but when the day eventually comes… I look forward to it. The chance to be together with you, forever. Like we were planning to do when we got engaged.”

Glacia rubbed the bracelet on her wrist, then plucked the final petal from the ice lily and set the now bare flower on the ground among its petals.

“I have to get going now, Lumira’s waiting for me.” Glacia stated. “I’m going to do my best to raise our daughter right. She will become a fine ruler one day. Someone we both would be proud of.”

Glacia held her index and middle finger together, placed them on her lips and then pressed her fingers on the block of ice before departing from the glacier.

“Farewell, Pyra. I’ll come see you again next year.”

“Congratulations you guys!”

Three days later, Glimmer had hosted a party in Bright Moon, celebrating both Etheria having been saved from the Raging Inferno and herself and Bow having gotten engaged, just like Bow had promised. While Adora still didn’t fully understand what engagement, marriage and weddings were, she was clued in enough to know it was a grand showing of the love between her best friends and was really important to them.

“Thanks, Adora!” Glimmer grinned as she hugged Adora. “Not gonna lie, this was kind of a spontaneous decision but hey, you only live once!”

“Well said, honey.” Bow agreed, planting a kiss on Glimmer’s cheek. “Besides, no need to prolong this any further when I already know I want to spend the rest of my life with you.”

“Likewise.” Glimmer wrapped her arms around Bow’s neck and gazed lovingly into his eyes.

“You two are adorable.” Adora squeed, causing the pair to blush.

Glimmer cleared her throat and then giggled: “You know, it’s kinda funny…”

“What is?”

“You and Catra are having a baby before us,” Glimmer explained. “But Bow and I are getting married before you two!”

“Ohhh. Right!” Adora chuckled awkwardly, not really understanding what was so funny about it. “Guess all four of us have got something to look forward to.”

“True! It’s exciting times for the Best Friend Squad all around.” Bow said.

“Speaking of exciting times, we should probably decide on a date for the wedding at some point.” Glimmer scratched the back of her head. “Dad keeps asking me about it, he’s so excited even though-”

“Glimmer!”

Adora, Bow and Glimmer saw Micah approaching them, his arm spread and with a smile brighter than a thousand suns.

“Hey, dad-” Glimmer greeted him. As soon as he caught up with his daughter Micah immediately hugged her as tight as he possibly could.

“Oh, my sweet baby girl is getting married!” Micah exclaimed, sounding happier than Adora had ever heard him. “You’re all grown up now, A-Angie would be so proud of how far you’ve come!"

“Daaad, you’re crushing meee!” Glimmer giggled. Adora couldn’t help but laugh.

“And Bow!” Micah let go of Glimmer and hugged Bow, though not quite as tightly. “I couldn’t have imagined a better husband for my Glimmer, you two are so good for each other! I can trust you’ll take good care of her, just like she will of you!”

“T-thanks, Your Majesty.” Bow blushed lightly. “I promise I won’t let you or her down, I’m going to treat Glimmer right.”

“Ah,” Micah wiped a tear from his eye after letting go of Bow. “This is such a momentous occasion… During my time in Beast Island, I-I couldn’t have ever even *imagined* getting to walk my little Glimmer down the aisle one day. But now, that day is finally coming!”

“Dad, you’re jumping the gun a little there.” Glimmer snarked. “We haven’t even settled on a date yet-”

“And you, Adora!” Micah then hugged Adora out of the blue. “You and Catra, you two are becoming moms soon! You kids have grown up so fast!”

“Hehe, I-I guess!” Adora chuckled awkwardly while hugging Micah back. “Truth be told, I’m a liiittle nervous how it’s gonna go, but I’m sure we’ll get the hang of it eventually!”

“You two are going to be great parents, I know it.” Micah stated. He turned his gaze towards Bow and Glimmer and in a playful tone said: “And I hope you two will as well, some day!”

“I-It’s still a work in progress.” Bow replied jokingly.

“Speaking of works in progress, if you need any help with planning the wedding just let me know!” Micah said. “I’ll do everything I can, I’m sure Casta and Bow’s dads would love to help as well!”

“Yeah, same here!” Adora chimed in. “And I know Catra will wanna help too, once she’s feeling-”

The atmosphere among the four of them became more gloomy. They all turned their heads to the side with a sad, sympathetic expression on their faces: Catra was leaning on a railing a bit of

distance away from everyone else at the party, with Melog standing right next to her purring quietly.

“How is she doing?” Bow asked.

“A little bit better every day, but… Not great.” Adora sighed. “She’s still grieving. Having a lot on her mind.”

“Pyra was the first Magicat she ever met.” Micah claimed. “Catra had gotten really attached to her, despite everything.”

“Frosta’s been pretty shaken, too.” Glimmer said sadly. “No wonder, she had just figured out Pyra was her ancestor and then five minutes later she…”

“It kills me to see Catra like this.” Adora whispered. “I've tried getting her to open up to me, but I... I wish I could do more.”

“Right now, all we can do is try to support her in any way we can.” Micah stated. “I've done my best to try and be there for her, while also giving her space when she needs it.”

“You should go talk to her, Adora.” Bow said gently. "She needs you right now."

“You’re right." Adora nodded. "You guys continue the party.”

“Good luck.” Glimmer gave Adora a thumbs-up, and Adora walked away towards Catra while Bow and Glimmer caught up with the other guests at the party.

Meanwhile, Catra had her gaze locked to the Whispering Woods, letting out a sigh while absently petting Melog’s head. She felt so conflicted.

Everything was so confusing to her.

Catra hadn’t known Pyra for very long. During most of her time knowing her, Pyra had done nothing but lie to and manipulate Catra. Use her.

Pyra had hurt her. Pyra had tried to kill her. Pyra had tried to kill *Adora.*

Pyra had tried to destroy the world.

And despite it all, Catra had this naive, childlike hope that somehow, Pyra would walk out of the Whispering Woods looking alive and well. That she had somehow survived.

But Pyra was gone. And Catra knew she wasn't coming back.

After everything, after all of the awful things Pyra had done…
Catra still missed her.

Catra thought of what Pyra had said to her, moments before she sacrificed herself:

'I'm so proud of ya.'

"Catra."

Suddenly Catra felt a hand on her right shoulder and heard a familiar, warm voice. Catra placed her left hand over the one on her shoulder and turned her head.

"Hey, Adora." Catra said quietly.

"How are you holding up?" Adora asked, concerned.

"I'm fine." Catra managed to muster up a smile. "Don't worry about me, you…" She shifted her gaze towards Adora's abdomen for a second. "You've got other things to-"

“The baby’s got nothing to worry about.” Adora asserted. “But you do.”

“Adora-”

“You’ve had one heck of a week, you’ve got so much on your mind and… Catra,” Adora gently squeezed Catra’s shoulder. “You can talk to me, it’s okay. Please, let me help you.”

“I…” A small part of Catra would’ve wanted to push back, but she nodded, feeling grateful of Adora’s willingness to support her and giving Catra the chance to air out all of her feelings. The two women remained quiet for a moment as Catra tried to figure out where to begin.

Eventually, Catra chuckled.

“Ironic.”

“What is?” Adora wondered.

“That I had to go through this a second time.” Catra explained.

“Huh?”

“Shadow Weaver.” Catra started. “She never loved me, she did nothing but mess with my head and berate me all my life… And then she sacrificed herself to save me, saying she was proud of me right before blowing herself up. And for the longest time I was so torn, I-I didn’t know how to feel or what to think about her. And now… Pyra. She lied to me and used me, sacrificed herself to save us, said she’s proud of me, and once again I- I have no idea. What to think.”

“Catra…” Adora muttered.

“I feel so stupid. For missing her.” Catra’s voice wavered and her eyes were getting misty. “I feel like I should hate Pyra, I feel like I should *want* to hate her. But, I just…” She sniffled, and Adora hugged her tight.

“You really looked up to her.” Adora said sadly, stroking Catra’s back. “You’d gotten so close with Pyra in such a short amount of time, it’s no wonder you’re so broken up about her.”

“I just, I-I feel like I *shouldn’t* be!” Catra cried. “Like, Shadow Weaver-”

“Catra, Pyra wasn’t Shadow Weaver.”

“Huh?”

Catra gave Adora a very confused look, unsure of what she had meant by this.

"Shadow Weaver **never** apologized for or regretted *any* of the things she did, all the pain she put us through." Adora stated. "She died as she lived, a heartless manipulative monster. Pyra, she did a lot of awful things too, but… In the end, she felt guilty for everything she had done and wished to make up for her actions. Pyra wanted to set things right, she… She died a hero."

"You think so?" Catra wondered. Adora nodded and gave her a gentle smile.

"You don't have to feel obliged to forgive Pyra for all the things she did, you don't owe her anything. But you're also allowed to miss her. She genuinely cared about you, just like I know you still cared about her."

"I did." Catra muttered. "Pyra taught me so much about myself, despite all her lies she… She almost felt like a sister I never had. But," She turned her gaze towards the sky. "Maybe its better this way."

"Eh?"

"For Pyra." Catra clarified. "She gets to be with Glacia again."

“I, I guess you’re right.” Adora said softly.

Catra turned her gaze back to her girlfriend, feeling a pang of guilt. Pyra’s death wasn’t the only thing she had on her mind.

“Hey, Adora?”

“Yeah?”

“I… *I’m sorry.”*

“Huh?” Adora tilted her head. “For what?”

“I…” Catra glanced aside, rubbing her arm. “I walked out on you, while you’re pregnant.”

“Catra, you didn’t know-”

“And I walked out on you after you took the Failsafe. Both times you needed me, and both times I just… Ran away.”

"Catra…" Adora hugged Catra again. She had no idea Catra had felt this way, that Catra thought *she* had been the one in the wrong during their argument. "Catra, ***I'm*** the one who pushed you away, after what I said. You had *every* right to leave me, I… I made you think I didn't trust you-"

"And I can't even blame you for that." Catra sighed. "After all the ways I've hurt you. Who'd trust someone who keeps bailing on you every time you need 'em?"

"Catra, I-"

"I need to be better." Catra looked Adora in the eyes. "I don't *ever* want to run away again, I… I can't risk losing you, Adora. I need to prove it to you, prove that I won't run. That I won't hurt you anymore, that you can trust me."

Adora thought for a moment. She felt really moved by how committed Catra was to her. Then, she had an idea:

"We could do what Bow and Glimmer are doing."

"Eh?" Catra's ears flicked. "Y-you mean, getting married?"

"Yeah! You know what that is?" Adora wondered.

"Nope." Catra chuckled. "I mean, I know what 'wife' and 'fiancée' mean, but only vaguely."

"Yeah, same here." Adora giggled. "But based on what Bow and Glimmer told me, it… Apparently means, you want to stay with that person for the rest of your life."

"Oh, huh." Catra blushed a little. "That… Sounds kinda perfect, honestly."

"Right?" Adora nodded. "Although I'm not sure what exactly it entails, getting engaged and all that… We can ask Spinnerella and Netossa about it, they've been married for years! They probably know."

"Good idea." Catra agreed. Adora smiled and held Catra's hands for a moment, while Melog affectionately nuzzled Catra's leg.

Catra still had one more thing on her mind. She reached into her pocket, taking out the note her mother had left her and read through it once more.

"Funny how that first letter," Catra remarked as she reached the part of the note that had been torn out. "It stood for *'Beast Island'* this whole time."

“You finally know where to look.” Adora stated. She asked Catra: “Have you decided yet?”

“Decided what?”

“What you’re gonna do. You wanna go after her?”

“I…” Catra glanced aside for a second, having to think. “I dunno, I-I feel so close to finally finding her. But Beast Island ain’t exactly a walk in the park from what I’ve heard.”

“Bow and I have been there before.” Adora reminded her. “Micah as well. And I’m sure Glimmer’s willing to tag along too, you don’t have to do this alone.”

“Yeah, Micah already told me he’s willing to help out with this.” Catra felt a little uneasy. “Just, feels like such a big ask, knowing how long he spent there…”

Catra paused for a while. She thought about something Adora had said during their fight:

‘Catra, I have you. And you have me. We… We’ve got each other. Isn’t that enough?’

“We’re not in any hurry here.” Catra said playfully. “The Magicats, they’ve been there for a thousand years. What’s a few more weeks gonna do?”

“Y-you sure?” Adora asked. Catra wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck. “You’ve wanted to find your mom for so long, you-”

“The Magicats can wait. They aren’t going anywhere.” Catra gazed lovingly into Adora’s eyes. “And besides, this past week has been like… REALLY exhausting. Right now all I wanna do is get some rest, and also make things up to my girlfriend and the mother of my child who I’ve been neglecting for *way* too long.”

“Catra…” Tearing up, Adora cupped Catra’s cheeks and pressed her lips against Catra’s, sharing a tender kiss with the woman she loved so much. Catra began to purr quietly as her tongue danced with Adora’s, afterwards pressing their foreheads together.

“I love you, Adora.” Catra whispered.

“I love you too, Catra.” Adora replied. “And I’m never gonna let go of you, I promise.”

“Good. Me neither.”

The two women stood there for a while, with Melog happily meowing as it observed them. Soon Adora glanced at where Bow,

Glimmer and Micah were with the other party guests.

"We should probably get back to the party." Adora suggested. "It's Bow and Glimmer's big day, after all."

"Right behind you." Catra said. She watched as Adora walked away, then shifted her gaze to the sky while gently petting Melog.

Catra now knew where she can start looking. Where she might find her family.

And one day, Catra was going to find them. But right now, she was going to focus on Adora and her pregnancy. Focus on fixing her relationships with everyone, making amends.

Finding her mother would have to be a story for another day.

Catra had a strangely peaceful smile on her face as she whispered to herself:

"Thanks for everything, Pyra. Farewell."

She and Melog then followed after Adora back to the party.

Chapter End Notes

And that's a wrap on my longest fic yet! Thank you so much for everyone who's been tagging along, leaving comments and kudos and who've sticked with me all the way to the end. There's still going to be one more short epilogue chapter coming in the next few days, but the main story is concluded here.

My output's probably going to be slowing down for a little bit, there should be one more short fic coming before Christmas but for the rest of 2025 I'll be taking it easy, I'm gonna need to rest for a while after having sunk so much time into something this long :D

I do have plans for a follow-up that focuses on Catra finally finding her mother, as well as going into more detail about what exactly happened to Magicat Kingdom in Mara's time, which I'm hoping to start putting out some time in 2026 once I have it fully outlined. Might also be putting out one or two more oneshots that follow up from the events here, like Adora and Catra getting engaged for example.

Also, while I didn't really have proper concrete designs or voices in mind for Pyra or Glacia since I wanted to leave them up to the reader's own imagination, while writing their dialog in my head I heard Pyra's voice sounding like Laura Bailey and Glacia's sounding like Jennifer Hale so, take that as like their "canon" voices.

Farewell!

Chapter 15: Epilogue: Six Years Later

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"FINN! Finn, get back here!"

Catra rushed deeper into the Whispering Woods, frantically searching for her child. She looked around, but they were nowhere to be seen.

"FINN!" Catra yelled again, growing worried. "That kid sure is slippery for someone so small… Ohh, Adora's gonna kill me if something happens to them!"

Catra stroke the golden wing buckle that was pinned to her shirt, then kept on going deeper into the Woods. Her hair kept getting caught on tree branches and she eventually tripped on a thick tree root in front of her that she couldn't see.

"Urgh!" Catra grunted as she hit the ground. She observed her surroundings and sighed deep. "I swear, that little troublemaker is gonna be the death of me some day! Where could they have gone-"

Then, her ears flicked when she heard the laughter of a child. *Her* child.

"Finn."

Catra quickly got up and headed towards the direction of the sound, eventually locating its source.

On a clearing in the Whispering Woods was sitting a young Magicat no older than five, with bright blue eyes and blonde hair. About twenty feet away from them has a huge, boarlike beast, but the child looked completely carefree and just laughed despite the impending danger.

"Cute piggy!" The child giggled. "Can I ride you?"

The boar seemed agitated by this, exhaling sharply out of its nostrils and baring its teeth.

"Finn!" Catra yelled, catching the child's attention.

"Oh! Hi, mom!" Finn, the child, waved at Catra, blissfully unaware of the predicament they were currently in.

"Finn! Get back here, before-"

Then, Catra noticed that the beast was pawing the ground, before it began charging towards Finn.

*"**NO!**"* Her maternal instincts kicking in, Catra desperately tried rushing to where Finn was to stop the creature from trampling her child to death, but before she could make it-

"E-eh?"

Suddenly, the boar squealed in pain, turned around and skittered off into the other direction. For a second it almost looked like its fur had been *singed.* Catra sighed out of relief, wiping her brow.

"Oh!" Finn turned their head, then enthusiastically waved at something they spotted deep in the forest. "Thank youuu!"

"Finn!" Catra immediately ran up to Finn and hugged them tight. "Oh, thank goodness you're alright, sweetie! I was so worried!"

"Mom, you're crushing meee!" Finn whined. Catra let go of them and immediately gave them a very disapproving glare.

"I've told you not to run off on your own like that!" Catra scolded her child. "You could've seriously gotten hurt, or lost in these woods."

"I-I'm sorry, mom." Finn nervously fidgeted with the tip of their tail, feeling guilty. Catra kept up the tough exterior for a moment,

before chuckling once and affectionately ruffling Finn's hair.

"Guess it can't be helped." She said fondly. "You've got my and Adora's genes, after all. I'm just glad that you're safe."

Catra picked her child up, wondering whether it was the First One or the Magicat in them that was making them so rambunctious.

"Time to go home, kiddo." Catra said as she began carrying Finn out of the woods. "Your other mom is waiting for us back at Bright Moon, and afterwards Grandpa Micah promised to take you to-"

"Mooom, I can walk by myself!" Finn stated, trying to wrench their way out of Catra's hold.

"Oh, no you don't!" Catra tightened her grip on her child. "I don't want you running off on your own again and bothering more wild animals, I wanna get home before it's dark out here."

"But *mooooom…"* Finn pouted.

"No buts." Catra playfully booped Finn's nose. "I can't be there to save you every time you end up getting yourself in danger, y'know."

“You don’t have to!” Finn claimed with a knowing grin. “The Forest Spirit keeps me safe!”

“Huh?” Catra gave Finn a confused look. “The Forest Spirit?”

“Yuhuh!” Finn nodded. “She guards the Whispering Woods, she saves me any time I’m in danger! She said she’s protecting me no matter what, like a guardian angel!”

“Oh, huh.” Catra said curiously, not knowing whether to believe her child or not. “Well, guess I oughta thank this Forest Spirit, then!”

“She said she’d like to see you,” Finn claimed. “But she thinks it's for the best that she stays hidden.”

“Huh. That’s odd…” Catra muttered, wondering if Finn had an imaginary friend.

“Oh yeah!” Finn just remembered something. “She told me to tell you that you’re a good mom, and that she’s proud of ya!”

Catra gasped, stopping dead in her tracks. She looked behind her, at the direction she and Finn had just come from.

“M-mommy?” Finn asked cautiously.

Gears were turning in Catra’s head as she put two and two together. The singed fur on the boar. Knowing Catra was Finn’s mother. Saying she'd like to see Catra, *saying she’s proud of her.*

“Could, could it be..?” Catra mumbled to herself.

No, Catra thought. There’s no way *anyone* could have survived that blast. She shook her head and looked back at Finn, who had a very curious expression on their face.

“What’s wrong, mommy?” Finn wondered.

“Huh? Oh, nothing.” Catra gave Finn a reassuring smile. “Hey listen, what would you like for dinner tonight?”

“Ice cream!” Finn yelled excitedly.

“Ohh, no way lil’ buddy!” Catra giggled. “You need to eat proper people food too, like vegetables and-”

“Blegh, veggies are gross!” Finn whined, causing Catra to giggle even harder.

Finn looked off to the side, noticing something that completely evaded Catra's gaze: A cloaked figure in the woods with similar catlike features to themself and Catra, who was waving at them from a bit of distance away. Finn grinned and discreetly waved at the figure without Catra noticing anything, before the two Magicats finally exited the Whispering Woods.

"Heh."

Once they were sure Catra and Finn were out of sight, the figure pulled their hood down and smiled.

It was Pyra.

"Finn's a good child." Pyra whispered fondly. "Free-spirited with a strong will and a good heart, just like a Magicat ought to be. You and Adora have raised them right, kid."

Pyra turned around, walking back to the camp she had set up near the heart of the Whispering Woods. While she had managed to survive the explosion, it had left its marks on her: She had been scarred in various parts of her body, she'd gone blind in her right eye which had turned completely white, a small chunk was missing from her left ear and her frostbitten left arm had been completely blown off from the elbow down, having since been replaced with a prosthetic.

“I really wish I could see ya again, Catra.” Pyra said to herself. She sighed, not feeling comfortable inserting herself into Catra’s life anymore after all of the pain Pyra had caused her. “But I'm glad to see you're doing so well. And I promise ya, I’m going to do everything in my power to protect Finn, make sure they never get hurt. I… I owe you that much.”

Pyra smiled, then placed her right hand on a particular tree that she had set up her camp by: The very same tree she and Glacia had carved their initials on centuries ago.

“Glacia… I’m sorry.” Pyra whispered. “You have been waiting for me so long. I, I hope you and Lumira can wait *just a little bit longer.”*

Pyra sat down with her back leaning against the tree, staring up into the sky. She thought about her past, all of the things she had done. The events that had led her to do those things.

The loss of her people had turned Pyra into a monster. But now, she was working on becoming a better person, trying to set things right while she still had time in this world.

Pyra felt content living a peaceful life in exile, no longer being burdened by the rage, pain or thoughts of revenge that had plagued her mind for so long.

She was free.

Chapter End Notes

Everyone could probably see this coming from a mile away after her comment about having a couple spare lives left in the previous chapter, but yeah I didn't have the heart to actually kill Pyra off. In some respects it might be more cruel to have her live, but I never saw Pyra as an outright villain who deserved to die but rather a victim of circumstance who snapped after reaching her breaking point, so giving her a more bittersweet but ultimately optimistic ending where she's looking after Finn from the shadows and trying to become a better person to make up for her crimes always felt right to me.

I like to think that maybe one day Catra gets to learn that Pyra survived and they might meet again and have at least some kind of an amicable relationship, but for now at least Pyra's story ends here as does this fic.

Again, huge thanks to everyone who've been reading all the way to the end! I hope the journey was worth it :)

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